INDEX CARD RPG ADVENTURES

A comprehensive collection of adventures and material released for ICRPG since its first publication in 2016

RUNEHAMMER GAMES presents:
INDEX CARD RPG ADVENTURES

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Special Thanks to All the Lumpy Heads

CONTENTS

INTRODUCTION 4

THE ADVENTURES

Last Flight of the Red Sword 5
Doomvault 14
Speed Kills 22
Eyes of Sett 30
Beneath The Door 38
Planet Killer 49
The Mercury Dale 63
Blackbird 74
Heckoon Carapace 79
Into the Sunset 89
Devious Dimensions 101
Red Fang 109
Orvald's Tower 115
The Relics of Odium 120
Crossroads 139
Minotaur Bridge 143
The Myre Miners 147
Hairpin Gate 151
Mechs and Mykonoids 155

INTRODUCTION

THE ARCHIVE

Over the past few years, **ICRPG** has enjoyed the creative efforts of GM s and players from al l over the world. The archives of what has been made and played since 2016 is not easily assembled!

As the *ICRPG Master Edition* came together, it quickly became apparent that the book would simply be too huge if it included all the adventures and peripheral content available. Thus, this PDF was born to rescue those adventures from the cutting room floor. Hundreds of readers took their first steps into **ICRPG** with Red Sword, Doomvault, or one of the supplements available only to Runehammer Patrons.

Now, it's all here. There's simply no way to thank the numerous people who made all this possible, playtested, refined and battle-hardened the **ICRPG** system and content. Thank you!

EDITION, SCHMEDITION

The content included here was published under **ICRPG CORE Second Edition**. No matter what revision of the game your table uses, these adventures will plug in with ease, even if you notice older terms or the absence of the new DEFENSE stat from Master Edition.

That said, the **ICRPG** Master Edition Core Update is free to all. A quick read there should prepare you to run any of these adventures, with almost no changes. Besides, **ICRPG** is a game about doing things your way. The *concepts* are what matters in a great adventure, not the stats.

As always, get a command for the big truths, exciting events, and hidden secrets of an adventure. Let the stats create themselves, or negotiate with players to create the most exciting version of events for your play style.

Also don't die. Dying is bad.

LAST FLIGHT OF THE RED SWORD

Your WARP SHELL brings you to a derelict Reptoid cruiser, drifting near a dying star. It is the 'Red Sword,' an infamous pirate ship feared in dozens of systems. What happened to its crew? Sometimes evil takes the last form we expect.

ADVENTURE OVERVIEW

GMS BULLETS

The absolute, bare bones key facts to remember to understand and improvise all the astounding details of the adventure:

- A REPTOID cruiser drifts near a dying star
- The star is unusual...calving black matter into space
- The star is PURE EVIL, and MUST BE DESTROYED
- The REPTOIDS failed to destroy it
- In their failure, they were changed...mutated
- Destroy the star before another time fold occurs
- Time has folded: your crew are already here

These raw bullets should ignite your curiosity, and spawn a thousand new questions. As we answer those questions, and introduce a Warp Shell crew, the action unfolds.

MOMENTS

Though players can work the adventure a million ways, there are 7 primary segments to comprehend and prepare. Take them as written, or use the random card method to give spaces unexpected details and quirks. It's your call, you're the GM.

1: ARRIVAL

Your Warp Shell appears from subspace in a silent instant, drifting in the solar shadow of a dead Reptoid Supercruiser: the 'Red Sword' a notorious pirate vessel. Beyond that lightless, bladed ship a dying star bleeds weird, coiling vapors into the abyss. A low hum of dread fills your ears.

- Scans reveal life signs
- The star is unlike anything surveyed... ever

2: DOCKING BAY

The massive cruiser is undamaged, but without power. Your boarding umbilicus mates perfectly with a hiss, and the hatch grinds open. Once inside, the solar flares erupt, and fear creeps up your spine.

- Trap them aboard
- Begin damaging them with solar flares
- Set the grim tone with details

3: THE CORRIDOR

A massive, three-part corridor forms the center of the vessel. It is bare, empty, and cavernous. Each door has to be pried, and an oppressive heat fills the stale air.

- Massive scale
- Clues about why they're here
- Explosives to sever command module

4: BRIDGE

The ship's con explodes with Reptoid ceiling-runners. Their uniforms are torn to shreds, and they've been twisted into a more terrible, ravenous form.

- A galleon-style helm
- First big battle: Mutant Reptoids
- Nav systems set for the core of the Darkstar

5: SCIENCE BAY (MAG LOCKED)

The Reptoid pirates were gathering data on the Darkstar. A closer look reveals VERY SPECIFIC data about how to use the ship itself as a massive projectile, to destabilize and destroy the bleeding sun. Even pirates have their moments of righteousness.

- A solar flare rips this module into deep space
- Fully reveal the Reptoid plan
- Fully reveal the endless evil of the Darkstar
- Why the Warp Shell brought you here

6: MEDICAL MODULE

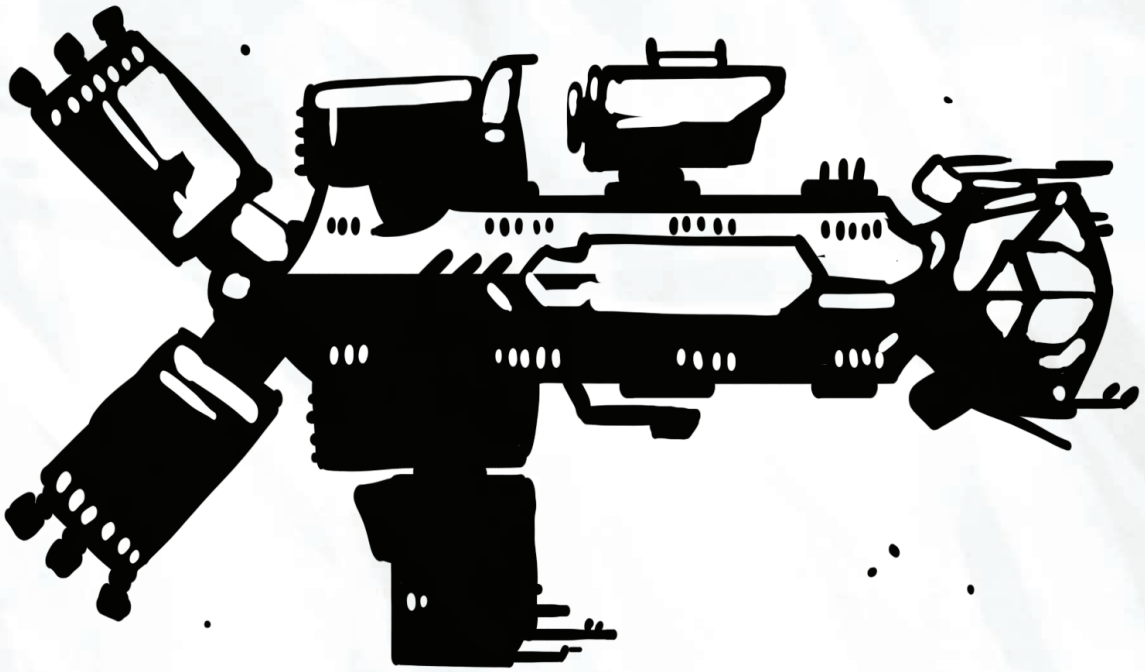
Here they tried to slow the mutations caused by the Darkstar, but their fates were sealed. Lurking in one bay, a hulking, heaving giant reveals itself.

- A brutal, stalwart enemy to give chase
- Spawn more Mutant Reptoids to aid the big guy
- Contains MAG KEY for Science Bay

7: ION ENGINES

To execute the pierce maneuver, and destroy the Darkstar, each Ion Engine must be overloaded for triple its normal output. This can only be done manually, leaving only seconds to escape before the vessel pierces the sun's heart and is incinerated.

- Be clear on timing for the final escape
- The engines can be used to fry the Gargantua



DEVIL IN THE DETAILS

As players begin to explore, they're bound to be curious. Here are 20 details that can be found with a closer look. ROLL or CHOOSE on successful investigations.

1: The exterior of the ship is warping, bending, even melting in spots from the stellar emissions
2: A rack of scimitars and EVA breathers, stacked near a grapple-winch mechanism and hatch
3: Claw marks gouged into a floor panel, far larger even than a Torton foot
4: A Reptoid holo-file, depicting garbled images and screams, the words "Changing" and "it's PURE EVIL!"
5: A gaping hole in the hull, sealed with vac-foam, torn by a blast of acidic heat
6: A necklace lying in a corner, flips open to reveal a holo pic of a lovely female Reptoid. It reads "Laila"
7: A ripped-off Reptoid hand, still clutching a hatch release lever
8: Flashing readout screens indicating the engines are primed for max over-burn, awaiting manual command
9: Weird printed schematics showing a massive bomb retro-fitted into the nose of the ship
10: An ancient Reptoid book, glyphed and hand-written, depicting an evil sphere, and portents of cosmic doom
11: A discarded blast rifle, lying amid a huge pile of spent shell casings, blast holes in all directions
12: The wreckage of a mangled sentry gun, torn apart
13: A locker of Reptoid uniforms and EVA suits, and one, ripped to shreds, on the floor
14: A Reptoid shadow burned onto a metal wall
15: An audio recording of layered whispers and a nauseating sub-bass hum
16: A captain's hat, two-cornered, with a skull insignia and bone pin
17: Three thrown daggers stuck in a wall, one of them sheathed in blood
18: The captain's corpse, hands lashed with micro cable to a control lever, head torn clean off
19: A micro-explosive device set to sever the corridor bulkhead
20: An observatory window, cracked from a blunt blow from within...a perfect view of the Darkstar beyond

CREATING THE TABLE

To build your version of the RED SWORD, start with a base of black felt or black cardboard roughly in the shape shown below. This gives the players a lay of the land, but the details are all in shadow. As they enter spaces and move about, add INDEX CARDS for each chamber. These can be blank, drawn at random, hand selected, or custom made depending on how you want to reveal the ship piece by piece.

Once explored you should have something like the map at left here. Don't get too hung up on the details, and keep things moving. Make sure you have a good command of the setting so you can handle unforeseen questions and situations with ease and speed!

The Darkstar bathes this ship in pure, hideous evil power. From that core fact you can improvise all you need.

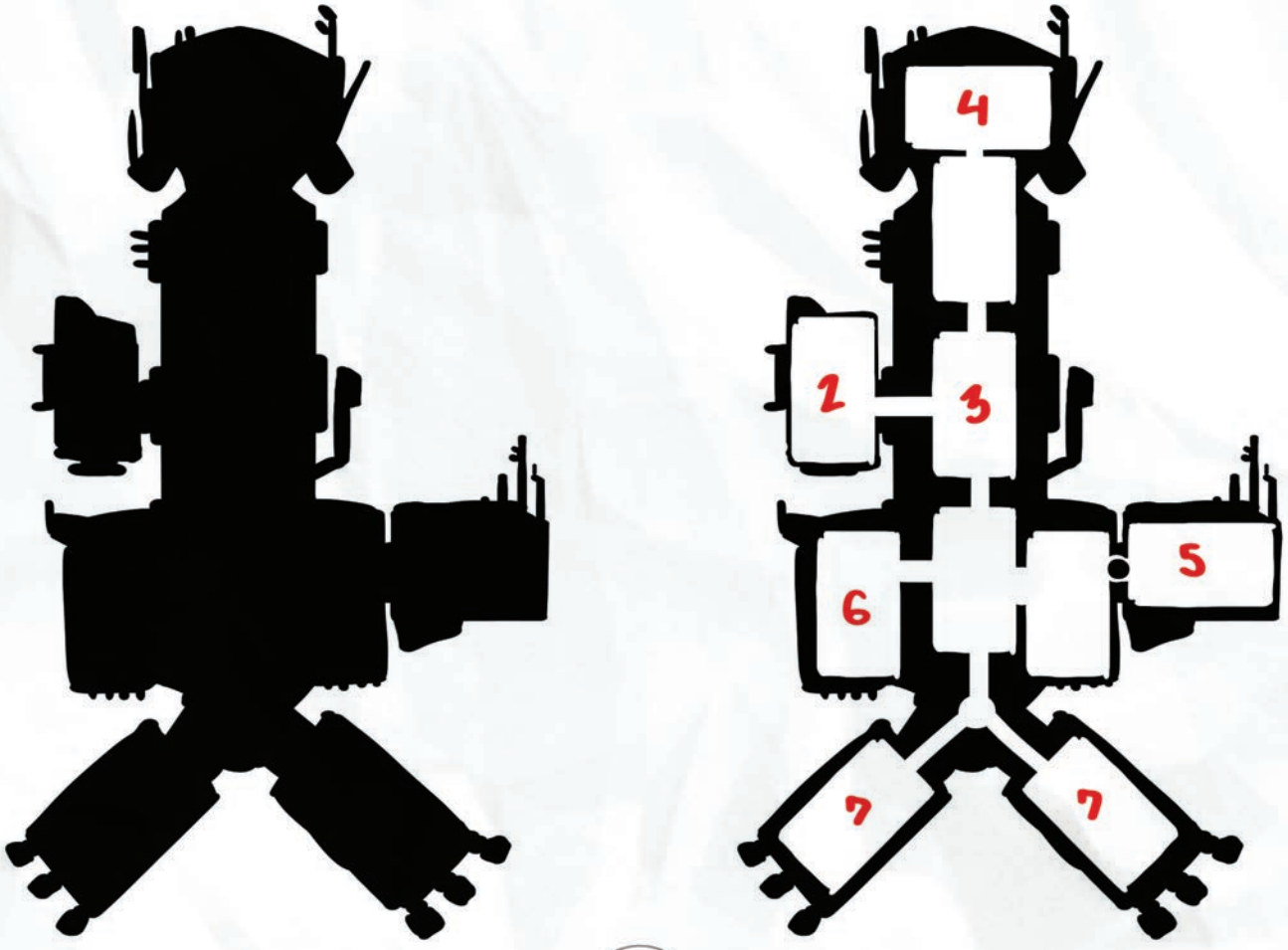
TIME HAS FOLDED

If your players rip through things too fast, reveal the TIME FOLD. The hero group is already here, already mutated, prowling for prey and not themselves. This is a devious way to show the evil of the Darkstar, and even 1 or 2 anti-heroes can be a brutal fight. Your call.

PACE AND RHYTHM

Plan a 3 hour session for the adventure. To speed things along, let the DOORS be mostly free and easy, with an occasional tough one (see MECHANICS). The only door that should HALT players is the door to SCIENCE BAY. This has to be unlocked by acquiring a MAG KEY in the MED LAB (bumping into the Gargantua).

Once they hit those engines, roll your session end die (throw out a 1). They have that long to disembark, or be vaporized along with the ship and the Darkstar!



MECHANICS

NEVER A MOMENT'S PEACE

Part of what makes **ICRPG** unique is the way TIME continues to pressure each action, especially when it comes to teamwork and EFFORT. If RED SWORD is a one-shot for you, do all LOOT as INSTANT, and ignore LEARNING on LOOT. This will have them progressing fast, and keep focus on survival. 10 MECHANICS to push them...

1: Solar Flares: Not just heat, but waves of pure evil. Every 1D4 ROUNDS, all heroes DEX check or fall for 1 damage
2: Hull Rip: If you roll a 4 on your FLARE TIMER, hit the ship hard. CON check or take MAGICAL evil damage
3: Jammed Door: Duranium doors can't be destroyed, only forced. 1 HEART of STR EFFORT to open
4: Number-Lock Door: Trap them with GARGANTUA, then require 1 HEART of INT EFFORT to get out
5: Mutants in Hiding: Loud sounds, yelling, or firearms draw out an additional 1D4 Mutant Reptoids
6: Vacuum: If air is escaping into space, in 1 ROUND vac foam will repair. Until then, STR or DEX to hold tight
7: Mutation: If a hero takes 5 or more damage from solar waves, he starts to change...in terrible ways...
8: Blessing of the Warp Shell: Heroes drop out of warp with a TEMPORARY HEART. It is gone once empty
9: Escalate: As the ship is torn apart, TARGETS rise, and you can even start re-rolling TIMER 4's
10: Melting Gear: Waves of unnatural heat slide over the ship between SOLAR FLARES. Heroes make a CON save to resist the heat, or drop 1 piece of GEAR in a daze. The GEAR melts, morphs into the flooring plates on impact, destroying it utterly

LOOT

Keep 1 LOOT in every room (10 total). Mix these between STARTER, SHABBY, and WARP SHELL tables. When Gargantua is killed (if) drop 3 LOOT from the EPIC table. Again, if this is a one-shot for your group, all LOOT is INSTANT and requires no LEARNING. If part of a campaign, mix INSTANT and CHESTS.

MUTANT REPTOID

ROLLS: +3 STR, +3 DEX, +1 EFFORT

ACTIONS

BLAST RIFLE: Mutant Reptoids will fire as they run toward prey, but never take up strategic firing positions

BLUDGEON: An attack using the butt-end of a blast rifle, or any junk lying around

CLAWS: Mutated to ragged blades, and infused with Darkstar fire. This attack inflicts MAGICAL DAMAGE

Twisted and enraged by energy from a Darkstar, these hideous killers know only predatory frenzy. Like all things subject to Darkstar flares, they have no self-preservation instinct, or sense of time. They exist only to kill, and are a sad shadow of their former selves.

MUTATION TAKES ITS TOLL: Of every 4 Mutant Reptoids encountered, at least one of them will be mutated almost beyond function. These wretches have only 1 HP, and be killed with a simply CHECK. Their gooey bones and shedding skin flops into biologic proto-gel as they perish.

CEILING RUNNERS: Reptoids can use any surface as walkable, and these use this ability to deadly effect. Attacking Reptoids on ceilings is always a HARD roll.

SADISTIC: If Mutant Reptoids see an enemy below HALF its max HP, they will all attack it on their next TURN. Even if at 0 HP, at least 1 of them will continue to hack and bite at the body for 1D4 ROUNDS.

REPTOID GARGANTUA

ROLLS: +3 ALL STATS AND EFFORT

ACTIONS (2 PER TURN)

ENERGY CANNON: A massive weapon. Hits all targets in a straight line, MAGICAL DAMAGE

LASH: A barbed tentacle attack. If hit, make a STR check or be grappled by the rubbery whip. NEAR reach

MACHETE TAIL: A deadly melee weapon slash that can reach FAR range

SCREAM: Subsonic death, no ROLL required. All enemies save with CON or take WEAPON DAMAGE

When the Reptoid crew attempted to halt the Darkstar mutations, things only got worse. This abomination absorbed technology and bio-matter as it grew to enormous size. Such will be the fate of all creatures should the Darkstar endure.

UNSTABLE CANNON: When 3 HEARTS have been destroyed, the creature's ENERGY CANNON is torn off, with one shot left in its fuel cell. Bulky, Giant, Unstable

LAIR LURKER: This beast will remain in its Med Lab lair until attacked, even if it spots prey. When engaged there, it will regenerate 5 HP per ROUND by eating bio matter and IV blood bags.

POOR SENSES: The monster chooses targets randomly, has terrible vision, and will even attack walls or objects in its fury to kill.

MASSIVE MOMENTUM: If pursuing prey, this creature stumbles forward in an awkward, reckless charge. It can ONLY be stopped by a wall. Those pinned take WEAPON damage, and must make a HARD STR roll to squeeze free of its crushing bulk.

TORTONS

THE TORTONS

A normally isolationist bio-form of turtle-like, reptilian bipeds recently rendered all but extinct by the Devourer. Now they've set out from their ruined homeworld into deep space. The mighty among their shattered kin vow to search for a light against the cosmic darkness.

They are a hearty race, able to quickly heal minor wounds, stave off infections and resist toxins. CON +1

Their shell and overlapping layers of scales form natural armor. ARMOR +1

A long-lived race, whose experience speaks volumes when given a voice. WIS +1

SLOW AND STEADY: Speed is not a virtue the Tortons possess. They can only move NEAR when moving.

TURTLE MODE: These heavy warriors retract their head, legs, arms and tail into their shell to form a bulwark for their allies and endure hell fire. +4 ARMOR while in this state, and immunity to damage dealt with FIRE. While in TURTLE MODE, a Torton cannot move.

GET IN, LET'S GO

Here is a 1D8 list of reasons a Torton winds up in your story.

1: Hitcher: Drifting without power in a shuttle craft, this hero needs a lift, the Warp Shell moves for a pickup.

2: Attuned: Tortons can be matched with a companion Warp Shell like many other bio-forms. This character is acutely aware of the weird ship's mind.

3: Marooned: Scans of the Red Sword reveal scattered life signs, one of them a Torton, barely alive, in a VAC suit tethered to the wreck. His SOS beacon is still active.

4: One Step Ahead: This hero is already scouting the Red Sword when your Warp Shell arrives, and you receive hails through a scrambled, barely audible static.

5: Materialize: As your Warp Shell exits its cross-space blink, a Torton appears without warning on the bridge, reeling from a dimension-jump. How, why?

6: Left for Dead: When exploring the Red Sword, your crew comes upon an injured Torton spacefarer slumped in a hallway. He seems dead at first, but stirs.

7: Hypersleep: You waken from hypersleep to the comforting face of a Torton crew mate. How long has it been? What happened?

8: Rookie: Xevos 1 has ordered you delay your departure to take on a new crew member. This is highly unusual, why the newcomer?

CONCLUSION

ESCAPE

Once the engines are sparked, the heroes have precious little time to escape. On a SESSION END roll of 2, for example, they may have to simply leap into open void, or ride a boarding grapple with the slimmest hope of reaching the Warp Shell.

Here is your chance to make a hero of your strange, sentient vessel. The Warp Shell loves its crew, cares for them, and does all in its power to protect them. To that end, it swoops into position, risking itself in the blast of ion burn, and opens its entry bay for the heroes. They are one, they are family, and no one is left behind.

Take a breath. It's over.

SUPERNOVA

Your allies at your side, you somehow manage to board the Warp Shell as the RED SWORD speeds into the heart of the Darkstar. The ion burn from the Reptoid ship tears at the cosmic fabric, and a shockwave beyond imagination showers the Warp Shell in liquid fusion. The evil is gone, the shadow illuminated, the universe safe again.

The wave of energy released is so intense, so reality-ripping in its power, the Warp Shell is involuntarily cast into subspace. In a silent instant, it vanishes, and only the legends of those unknown heroes betray its passing.

The Darkstar is no more.

DOOMVAULT

Darkness gathers beneath the city of kings.
An age-old enemy has gathered its strength, threatening to end the days of peace above.
Can a handful heroes stop the ritual of shadow before it's too late?

OVERVIEW

GM'S BULLETS

Below the city of Norburg, high on the cliffs of Ire, something is about to happen that will leave the THREE KINGS dead and the realm in chaos. It's up to you to stop it...if you can.

- The Ogdru Ritual will kill all 3 Kings if not stopped
- The Kings are totally unaware
- The Ogdru Brotherhood have INVINCIBLE guards
- The ritual changes the Doomvault's structure
- The deepest chamber holds the ritual altar
- The only way out is DOWN

Doomvault is a classic dungeon crawl with a variety of challenges and grim shadow of evil.

MOMENTS

1: THE CRAGS OF NORBURG

Norburg is an ominous city of brutally high architecture, black stone, and low fires. There is little street life, little cheer. From this high perch, you survey the angry sea, and Milo describes what must be done as time whisks him away. Don't look down.

- The entrance far below
- The slamming mists

2: HAG ROOST

A wind-scoured cavern mouth bathed in freezing spray, opening suddenly on vertical stone. The rocks below are broken with shattered masts and anchor chains.

- A perilous entrance
- Reveal the shifting corridor within
- Extreme contrast to the outside

3: THE LONG PATTERN

A mile-long tunnel of flawless cut basalt, inlaid with intertwining rivulets of quartz. The floor is a smooth maze of patterns, bloodied with the tortured knees of Ogdru initiates. At the far end, the INVINCIBLES stand watch.

- Dizzying length and high ceiling
- A ritual, kneeling pilgrim trail
- Find a way past the INVINCIBLES

4: MIRROR LAKE

An underground lake with no apparent crossing. Beneath the still black water, the brotherhood slide and slurp in their mucky trances.

- Cave Ropers above and below
- What were once men swimming about
- Noxious vapors

5: OSRIC'S GATE

A purplish energy hovers over this gateway, barring passage. Only by reciting the password, written on the adjacent wall, may it be moved through.

- A 2 HEART translation
- The swimming men give chase from the lake
- Some enemies carry a codex, which aids reading
- Exit to the Sleeping chamber is unbarred

6: SLEEPING WITH THE DEAD

The Brotherhood take sleep near a large stone grave-box or sarcophagus which holds the corpse of their leader: Osric the Cursed. As they sleep, they slowly feed him life force to one day awaken.

- Living quarters for the brotherhood
- Very flexible room for GM discretion: rest or battle
- Contains a codex on a small table

7: GUARDIANS

These towering statues blast intruders with hellish beams of magical fire from their stone eyes. They are near indestructible and older than humankind.

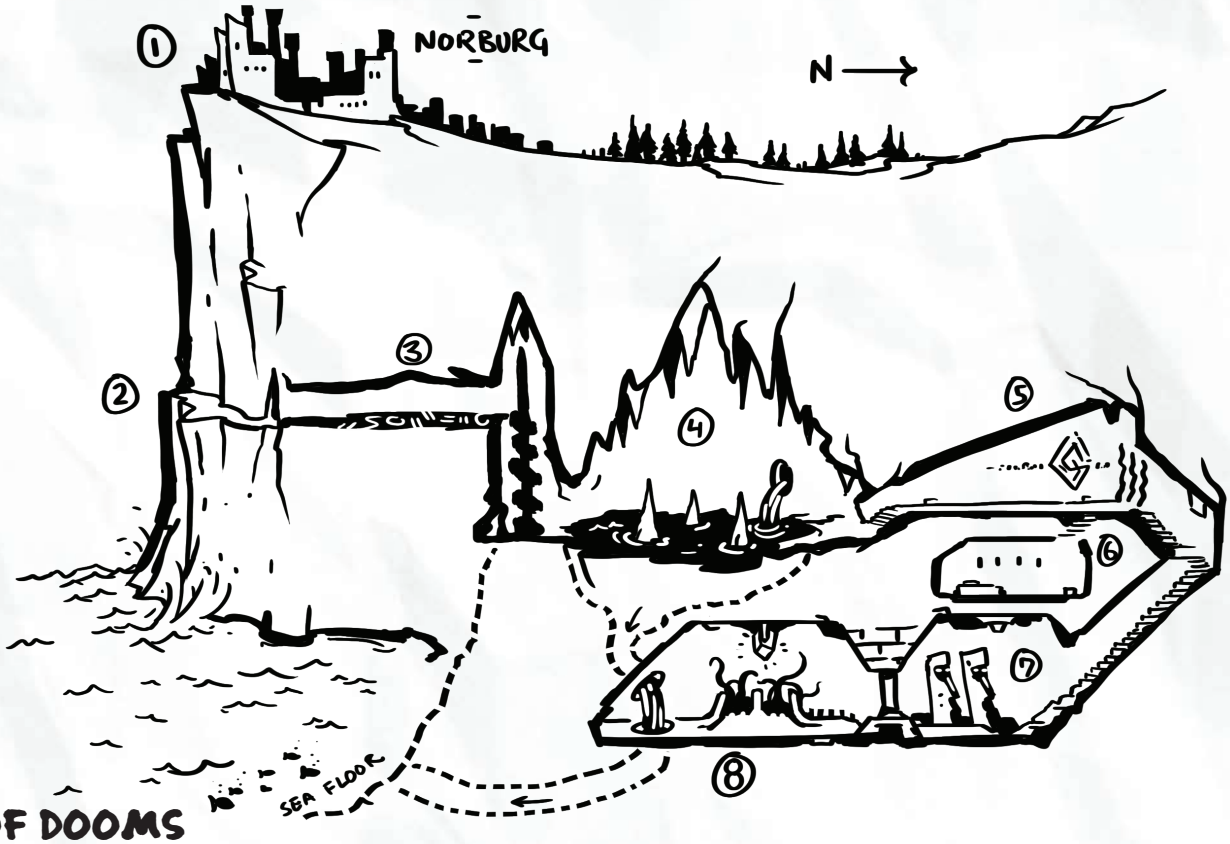
- They can be deceived, not destroyed
- Beyond them a massive door can only be raised from within the far chamber
- Monks occasionally walk past, heading to the upper areas

8: THE PIT

Here the Ogdru is called from the sea to touch the great YOG crystal and complete the ritual and kill the three kings!

- A group of murderous, mutated monks
- The ritual is almost complete
- It can only be stopped by shattering the crystal
- Collapse makes the waterway the only escape

THE VAULT MAP



DEN OF DOOMS

Here are 20 details that can be found with a closer look. ROLL or CHOOSE on successful investigations.

1: Carved stone effigies of three crowned figures, portrayed as skull-faced corpses
2: Etched writing mentioning the Ogdru and the end of days
3: A reading podium whose tome discusses ritual method: the Ogdru and the crystal become one...
4: A map-carved tablet showing a massive sea cavern in the depths offshore, marked with an eye symbol
5: A blood-stained child's doll, forgotten in a cobwebbed corner
6: An incomplete set of Brotherhood Armor, worn by the invincible guard
7: Black silk robes with gilded trim hanging on wooden hooks
8: A cluttered wooden bin of mixed personal belongings such as belts, shoes, and hats
9: A feast table, complete with roast pheasant, black gar, and Norburg cheeses
10: Weird vertical bedding for a few dozen men, apparently used for sleeping while standing
11: A rack of manacles and burlap sacks
12: A removable oil lamp, with an odd rotating timer that marks a half-day
13: A large rake clogged and tangled with black seaweed and slime
14: A cryptic diagram of an armored figure, showing a skeleton inside a shell of metal plates
15: Dimly lit frescoes showing a mountain of bodies below the Hag Roost cliffs
16: A wooden staff topped with a finely carved tentacle motif
17: A tiny chip of red crystal
18: Wet, slimed footprints leading from the lower chambers to the Mirror Lake
19: A jeweled skull on a podium, distorted with six eye sockets
20: A severed hand being dissected on a wooden table

THE INVINCIBLES

One key aspect of DOOMVAULT is the indestructible, super-lethal guards. There are only FOUR of these powerful enemies in the dungeon: two posted at the end of the Long Pattern, and two wandering the inner chambers. They are utterly indestructible! They can only be bypassed with stealth, diversion, or trickery.

When the INVINCIBLES defeat the entire party, they do not kill them but rather cast them out the entrance like garbage onto Hag Roost. Characters awaken with 1 HP. At that moment, all players roll a 1D6. On a 1, they plummet from the ledge, barely holding on down by the crashing surf.

If ALL players plummet to the waves, it's a true wipe-out. Consider stripping them of all LOOT and washing them ashore on some hellish island for more adventure, or consider killing them utterly.

KNOWING THE OGDRU

To improvise or invent new details and descriptions during play, get an intuitive sense for what the Ogdru Brotherhood looks and feels like: the patterns on their robes, their black, lidless eyes, the half-formed gills on their necks, or their odd, inhuman footprints. These details will build the right atmosphere for the big reveal of the Ogdru in THE PIT.

OSRIC'S GATE AND THE GUARDIANS

If approached without pursuit, these obstacles are mechanically simple. Add a wandering Invincible, or a few of the semi-humans from Mirror Lake, and things get very messy very fast. It is simply a race against time whenever stealth or deception is compromised. Be certain and clear with your brutality, so players see that they can't simply force their way through!

INVINCIBLES

ROLLS: +5 ALL ROLLS

ACTIONS (2 PER TURN)

BROKEN WEAPON: A crushing blow from a long-ruined iron mace or broken sword. ALWAYS does ULTIMATE
STRANGLE: The thing grabs you by the neck. Make a HARD STR roll to break free or take ULTIMATE damage for every ROUND in its grasp
SHIELD BASH: Take ULTIMATE damage from this ram-like attack and be thrown FAR backwards. If you hit anything while sliding back, take normal WEAPON damage on impact
BATTLE CALL: If in combat more than 3 ROUNDS, The Invincible will yell with a low, raspy howl. Its companion will arrive in 1 ROUND to assist

Created by the blackest magic of the Ogdru Brotherhood, the most powerful warriors of Ire are turned into these indestructible wardens of the Doomvault. They can be killed, burned, or disintegrated in any way and know only the most basic drive to stand watch and repel intruders.

STRICT SENTINELS: ONLY when the line they stand watch upon is crossed do these brutes react. Until that time, they simply stare into oblivion.

INEVITABLE: INVINCIBLES can only move NEAR on their turn, slowly plodding forward. Once set to a location, though, anything in their path will be ignored, trampled, or walked right through.

SLAVES: These creatures are created with a safeguard never to attack a particular master. This is usually an Ogdru Monk or Priest. They will completely ignore their masters' presence, capable only of killing, not taking orders.

WHAT WERE ONCE MEN

ROLLS: +2 ALL ROLLS

ACTIONS

LASH: A ragged set of webbed claws where hands once were. A WEAPON wound inflicted with this attack will itch and burn

DROWN: Gods, the way they drag you below the water! Disappear in the murk, taking WEAPON DAMAGE each ROUND below. Make a CON roll to hold your breath and negate the damage, or make a STR roll to break free. If you take drowning damage twice, gulp water and be stunned for 1 ROUND

WATER SPINE: Speaking a gurgled word beyond human tongues, these creatures control water, forming a sharp projectile that can hit up to FAR range. MAGICAL damage is inflicted

The devotees of Ogdru bathe in unnatural muck below the world and slowly turn to big-eyed freaks. They become one with the black water and kill to feed their hideous master the bodies of the innocent.

THIEVES: As mentioned in MECHANICS, these creatures take 1 LOOT from their victim any time they roll a critical attack. Choose this LOOT randomly from that character's EQUIPPED list. The LOOT is absorbed into their gelatinous guts in seconds and ruined utterly.

STALKER: Once-men will stay hidden underwater as long as possible, trying to gain an advantage on their prey. They also use group tactics to distract or steer prey into corners or near a Cave Roper if possible.

ONCE MEN: It's important to remember these monsters were once people before being hypnotized, brain washed, and mutated by the Ogdru. With great effort, they can be reached by compassion. 1 HEART of CHA EFFORT gives them pause, or 2 HEARTS of CHA EFFORT turns them completely and awakens their original selves. The nightmares they must know....

THE OGDRU MONKS

WHATEVER YOU NEED

Wait, no page for a Monk monster? Nope! Use these hooded blasphemers as a creative free-space. Make them lowly 1 HP humans or formidable magic users! Make them inhuman mutants or blank-eyed children. You know best what fits your table, your moment, so be flexible with the Monks and use them to effect.

Especially once the characters reach THE PIT, you can really unleash a big battle with Monks, and cackle with sadism as they tear your heroes to shreds. Maybe one Monk is actually Ogdru itself in semi-human form, waiting to be revealed! Maybe one of your players has been masquerading too long and joins their evil number at the end, revealing his treachery in the worst way! Gods, the horrors a GM can conjure!

SHUT YOUR GURGLEY TRAP

Here are 12 things an Ogdru Monk might say:

1: "Interlopers? Here? Impossible!"
2: "My child, you come seeking the truth of your night-mares...here, let me show you...."
3: "Barat Oon! Hideous land man! Barat Oon!"
4: "I see in you lies, greed-worshipper. Be gone from this sacred place!"
5: "Gurglurgl-bakahh! Ogdru in my eye, on waves die, Bakah! Bakah!"
6: "So, this is the caliber of man they send against us."
7: "Do what you must, insect. My death has already served the master."
8: "You there! Intruder! Die!"
9: "All are welcome here, wretch. Read you these walls and join the black sleep."
10: "Garakeeer! Garakeeer! The liars have arrived!"
11: "I would like, I think, to lick your eyes from their sockets."
12: "Back to the sunlit hells with you, blasphemer!"

TARGETS AND OTHER BITS

By reading RED SWORD and DOOMVAULT, you may notice that several details are not listed. What are the timers, area TARGETS, and other things I need? Where is all the detail? Udin's eye, what trickery is this?!

ICRPG takes the view that GMs are crafts-folk! Adventures are a starting place, not an almanac of answers. Make each adventure your own! Tune TARGETS to fit your group or how fatigued or injured they may be. No module can ever know what players will do or how their imaginations will alter the foundations of the story. Likewise, as you prepare these adventures for your session, leave holes! Play to see what will happen, and be ready to have your mind blown.

RECIPE FOR DOOM

Notice too, these adventures all follow the exact same format. This is no accident! By giving yourself a confined space to be creative, you'll find you can get much more done. Nothing slows the creative mind more than an infinite blank page. Give it a try! The Ogdru Monks are just the gateway to seeing that **ICRPG** believes in YOUR ability to make the magic happen. Apply that very same enthusiasm, and brilliance, to entire adventures and story lines.

Let it all go haywire, and your players will keep coming back for more. Now, let's get to the big ending....

CONCLUSION

THE BIG SWIM

The sheer size and force of the Ogdru's tentacles as it rises into THE PIT will cause the place to collapse. Once the ritual is complete, huge chunks of stone fall everywhere, for the purpose of this ancient place is fulfilled at last. The only way out is the gushing drain of Mirror Lake. Use CON rolls, and who knows what else for players to survive the swim.

Make it memorable! As they slurp and slide into the crashing waves, they see nightmare visions of huge black eel shapes, a giant blinking eye, or clouds of ink.

Whether or not they stop the kingslayers, the Ogdru lives in seething hate below the surf.

MORE THAN DEATH

End the adventure with a grim scene. If the Kings are killed, a great black-cloud storm rolls over Norburg. The earth shakes, and unnatural black smoke rolls through the town. What doom awaits? If the ritual is stopped, the Ogdru is enraged and lashes out like a sea monster of old, bashing the cliff walls of the city! The three Kings, still alive, appear on the battlements! Heroic and mighty stand they and unleash a hail of catapult fire!

Maybe, in awe of their unstoppable saviors, the elders of Norburg choose the heroes as the new council of Kings! Nothing makes a great ending like an epic beginning.

SPEED KILLS

When nitro burns too hot, and the gear heads lose control, the innocent pay the price.
This time, justice will be served.
There is no escape... she's just too fast.

OVERVIEW

GM'S BULLETS

Your WARP SHELL brings you to the Kerrakian moon of GONE, where the infamous illegal DEATH RACES are rumored to take place. Something isn't right, or you wouldn't be here. What could it be?

- Surface scans reveal a high speed object blipping impossibly around the moon's surface
- A string of vehicular murders is plaguing the race scene
- The object, a Hypercar called 'Phantom,' is killing racers one by one in cold blood
- Cornering Phantom reveals its driver, STAR, but she is a ghost...murdered by the Death's Head crew
- STAR can be reasoned with, but Death's Head steals Phantom and accidentally warps it into LIMBO
- If they aren't stopped, they will rip LIMBO apart and threaten the very fabric of reality

STAR wants revenge, but her car is even more dangerous than she is. This adventure can play out many different ways, but here are the pieces.

MOMENTS

SPEED KILLS rides a delicate balance between linear adventure and free-form play. Familiarize yourself with everything, and be ready for things to go haywire.

1: ARRIVAL

Once materialized in orbit, your WARP SHELL brings up numerous scans indicating a high speed object on GONE. Also, a series of new blipverts show a string of murders in the Death Race pit camps.

- The object is moving so fast it's phasing
- One of the victims is GONE Warlord 'White Knife'

2: IN THE PITS

Upon arrival, you meet Twitch and Ratboy, two tweakers scared to death of what they call 'The Phantom,' a rogue hypercar killing racers every night.

- Your talk is interrupted by the streaking car itself
- It plows a crowd, killing a few racers
- Players can give chase in one of Ratboy's numerous vehicles

3: THE FIRST CHASE

With Twitch or Ratboy or both in tow, hunt down the murderous car. A sliding, chaotic romp across the deserts of GONE.

- Dodge rock towers and junker huts
- Have fun with some vehicle combat
- Phantom is simply too fast and vanishes before being defeated, blipping into phase

4: DEATH RACE

Certain the Phantom will show for the big race the following day, Ratboy also reveals that the Phantom car belonged to Star, a beautiful newcomer who was killed a few weeks back by the Death's Head gang. They've got a dozen or more 'cars in the Death Race.

- Join the big race, modify vehicles
- Phantom appears, but Death's Head drivers also try to kill the heroes
- A huge chase with easy-kill Death's Head junkers, and the ever-elusive Phantom, lead to a boxed in volcanic canyon

5: THE HEIST

The Phantom powers down in a volcanic box-canyon, and Star's ghost appears in the smoke. Her rage and despair are so intense, a portal to the afterlife rips open, the Styx flowing beyond. Death's Head crashes in, bent on stealing Phantom for themselves.

- The portal to hell pulls with incredible force
- Death's Head wants to drive straight in
- A crazy battle with many possible outcomes
- Charon the ferryman is visible, beckoning

6: HELL AND BACK

Depending on how THE HEIST goes, Death's Head will attempt to steal Phantom and drive straight into hell. This is why the WARP SHELL brought you, as the Phantom's phase drive could destabilize the barrier between worlds. With Star's ghostly help, end it.

- An insane high speed chase beside the Styx
- If victorious, Star can finally rest
- Once Phantom is destroyed, characters are hurled through the barrier in a blast of smoke and brimstone.

THE DEATH RACE

WELCOME TO GONE

SPEED KILLS is a big gear change (pun intended) if you've been dungeon delving! Be sure to get a good grip on how to describe and bring to life this junk-strewn, punky race culture, without overwhelming players with numerous characters and loose ends. Keep things moving forward by pressing the gang threat and race start times.

Also, to keep it feeling tight, wave off more modern trappings like money, television, and communications. GONE is a totally illegal scene, an eyesore on the Kerrak culture, and all the trappings of intergalactic society don't apply. It's live or die, trade or be ripped off, go fast, or burn up trying. Limit dialogue to just a few key characters, but freely describe the grungy crowds of junkers gathered to witness the greatest race in the cosmos.

A VIBRANT SCENE

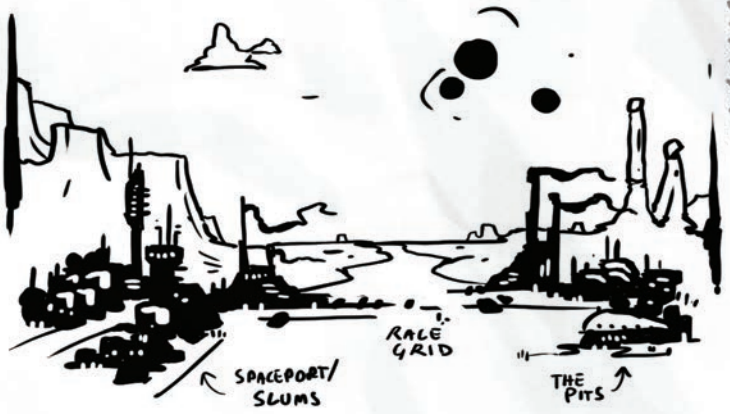
Here are 20 things players might notice when they poke around in the pits, junk piles, and dive bars of the GONE hot rod scene. Choose or Roll...

1: A flickering comm unit with patchy transmit loops of the race layout
2: A tangled heap of hoses, pistons, and scrap that could be used to mod a vehicle
3: Stray prosthetic limbs in a heap
4: Discarded newsvert papers that read 'Mysterious Deaths Continue'
5: A group of wastoids sitting in a drum circle, talking about how Star was the greatest driver
6: A duffel bag stashed in garbage, filled with 1D6 x 1,000 coin
7: A Death's Head junker, drunk, scared out of his mind that 'he's next'
8: A squat alien with a burrito hover-cart, who knows about a secret salvage yard in the desert
9: A bucket of chunky, rusty bolts
10: A makeshift grave/shrine for Star out by the raceway, littered with mementos
11: A weird guy named Gimp who sells cheap nitro...and sniffs it
12: Ancient Zurin carvings in a huge slab of sandstone, showing carts and camel-like creatures racing
13: A cracked, blood-splattered Death's Head helmet in a trash bin
14: A trashed hypercar in a back alley, still crackling with phase energy
15: Ratboy's Garage, where Twitch also hangs out. They're moaning about their lost stash box
16: A nitro bottle that can upgrade a motor from fast to hyperfast for 1 ROUND
17: A de-fleshed desert wolf skull with a stripe of red paint
18: A half-full flask of Kerrakian Clear Gar...the good stuff
19: A junked but awesome grav-bike from the old crystal fuel days
20: Tattered black cloaks, 3 of them, stained with motor lube and burn marks

MAPS

THE DESERT ROADS

The Burning Sands Death Race is a 1,000 mile route through the canyons, needles, and open desert of GONE. When zooming vehicles through this vast space, simply introduce obstacles flashing by, or zig zagging canyon turns, to scramble the action. Red dust, three suns, and the occasional giant lizard complete the unpredictable race terrain.

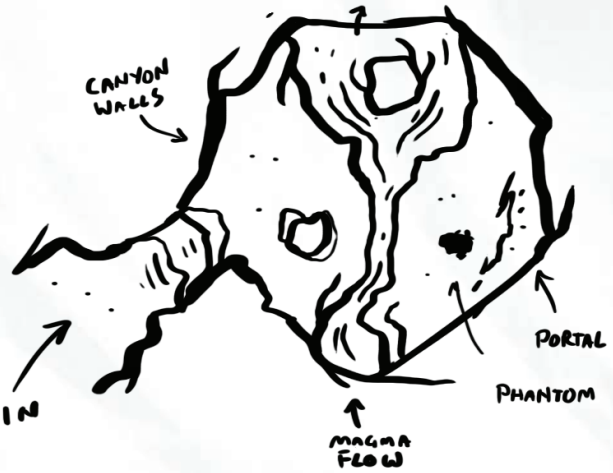


THE PITS

The spaceport on GONE is a chaotic mess of camps and streets that connect to the race start and finish lines, complete with garages, bars, and junk heaps. This area is mostly used to set up the action, meet key characters, and learn about Star's murder.

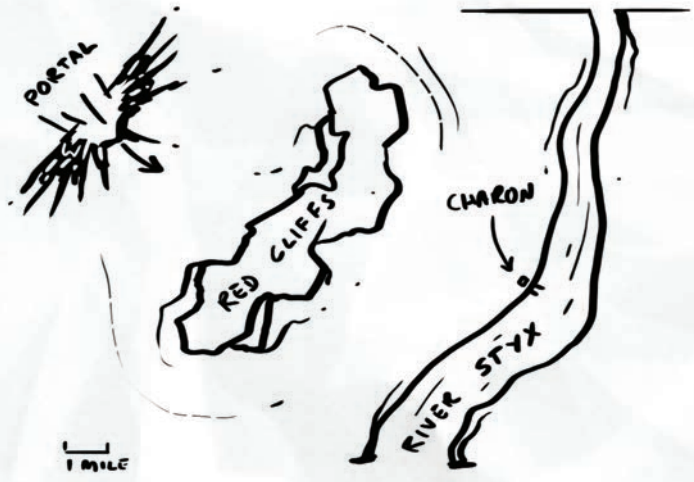
MAGMA CANYON

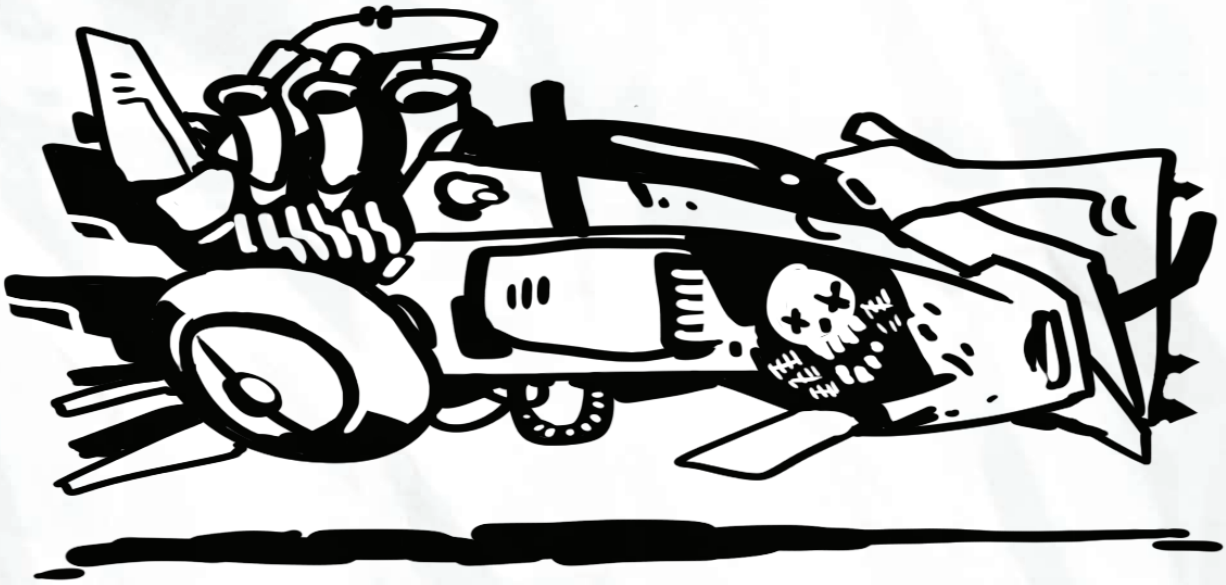
The first big chase ends in this volcanic area, where Star reveals herself at last. Her anger, her grief, and her sadness are so profound, a portal to the Plain of Styx, the afterlife, tears open. Use this confined area to BLEND vehicle and on-foot combat and action. This is your biggest battle, as Death's Head rushes in to steal the Phantom but is pulled in to the other world. Immediately, the two worlds begin tearing apart. They must be stopped!



THE RIVER STYX

Charon, the ferryman of the underworld, wants nothing to do with the living in his realm and will join forces to stop Death's Head. Here's your chance to let a wildly unpredictable ending take shape. Does Star stay in the afterlife? Is Phantom destroyed? What happens to the Death's Head drivers? Your timer can be the tremors in reality. The threat: Death's Head. Maybe their leader is just a brain horror in a race helmet. The treat is Charon himself, the all-powerful ferryman. Let your players make a lovely mess of things, and when its all over, they return to the WARP SHELL once again.





AT HIGH SPEED, EVERYTHING IS DANGEROUS

A lot of SPEED KILLS is spent at high speed, battling, evading, chasing, or just hanging on. Remember in your descriptions, or in crafting table scenes, how deadly speed can be. Simply racing up on a rock formation can spell doom! Have Phantom parked around a blind corner, and a Death's Head grav bike smashes it into a fireball! Phantom is a supernatural hypercar, though, and hovers away from such things unscathed. Here are nine elements to make your highways deadly.

1: Rocks Ahead! OBSTACLES appear! Use DRIVING rolls to evade, or slam into them for WEAPON DAMAGE
2: Ejected! If a vehicle takes more than 10 damage in a single hit, roll DEX or be thrown!
3: Tangled up: If two vehicles are ramming, roll a 1D6. On a 1 they become locked together with bent metal
4: Overdrive: A Slow vehicle can be bumped to Hyperfast for 1D4 ROUNDS, then its engine will blow
5: Collision: Colliding head on or at high speed, vehicles roll 1 ULTIMATE PER CHUNK
6: Tug of War: If two vehicles are grappled or chained together, treat their number of CHUNKS as a STR bonus
7: Overflow Damage: If a vehicle is destroyed, and there's more damage left over, the pilot absorbs it
8: STAT Variety: Use STR, DEX, INT, and CON for various DRIVING rolls, as they fit the maneuvers
9: Cones: Spectators, trees, and other small, weak objects are simply creamed. Vehicles kill them instantly

LOOT

There are lots of chances in THE PITS to score LOOT. Also consider flinging it off of damaged vehicles at speed. If players are strapped for cash to build or modify their rigs, set up a tiny side quest. Have them blast a few desert lizards for a hefty bounty or find a lock box in the sand caves.

VEHICLES

BUILD 'EM, RACE 'EM, CRASH 'EM

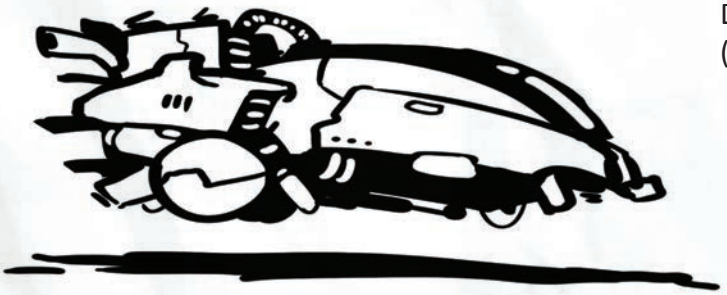
Know your CHUNKS man! Vehicles in **ICRPG**, all the way up to starships, are defined by CHUNKS. A CHUNK is 1 HEART of VEHICLE HP (or 5 HP for battle suits), one key function or weapon, 250 pounds of metal and rubber, and costs 1,000 coin. With this simple system, you can build anything!

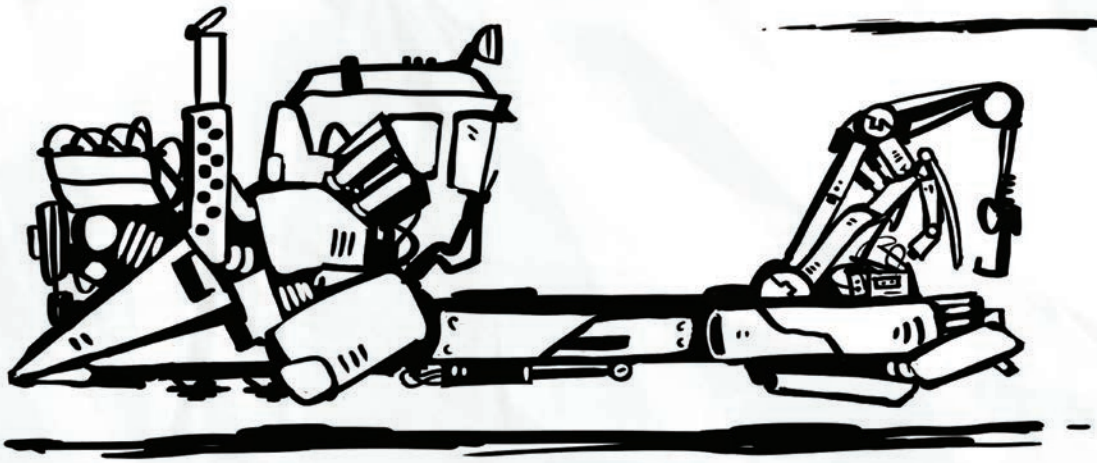
VEHICLES inflict double damage against those on foot. Pedestrians do HALF damage against VEHICLES. Attacking a battle suit with your trusty pistol? Not a good idea.

All vehicles fall into three categories of speed: Slow, Fast, and Hyperfast. Slow and Fast cost 1 CHUNK (big vehicles are never Fast) and Hyperfast Costs 2 CHUNKS (like a Hypercar's Blower).

A FEW EXAMPLES

GRAV BIKE: 2 CHUNKS: Engine (Fast), Ferring (Ram for Weapon Damage)
HYPERCAR: 4 CHUNKS: Engine (Fast), Roll Cage (Ram for Weapon Damage), Chain Gun (Fire for Energy/Magical Damage), Nitro Blower (Allows bursts of Hyperfast)
DREDGE: 6 CHUNKS: Engine (Slow), Haul Crane (Grapple other vehicles), Grenade Launcher (Fire for Explosive Energy/Magical Damage), Ram (Ram for Weapon Damage), Big Cab (Hold up to 8 passengers), Flatbed (carry another vehicle)





BUSTED UP CHUNKS

During the action, if a CHUNK is reduced to ZERO HP, it is destroyed! Remove the ability or weapon associated with that CHUNK. Use a roll to choose what CHUNK, unless the attacker is TARGETING a specific CHUNK. If an already-destroyed CHUNK is fired upon, you've lucked out and taken no damage. Another fun narrative element is having that CHUNK go flying, tumbling, or becoming an obstacle.

THE HUNT IS ON

A chase uses rolls to get outcomes on all kinds of insane action moments. Here are the keys:
AVOID: When obstacles appear, pilots need to roll!
SPEED: Vehicles outrun each other in this much time: Slow: 1D8 ROUNDS, Fast: 1D6 ROUNDS, Hyperfast: 1D4 ROUNDS. AVOID rolls reset outrun timers.
COLLISION: For each CHUNK, roll 1 ULTIMATE DAMAGE when colliding! Dredge vs. Grav Bike? Nope.

CASTING CALL

STAR

She was a promising new driver on the scene, but when she turned down Brutus' offer to join Death's Head, he killed her and her friends in cold blood. Now her silent, vengeful ghost is ripping around GONE, taking out the members of Death's Head one by one. Deep down, she is a good person, but her soul is tormented with anger.

TWITCH & RATBOY

These two nitro-sniffers are your classic gearhead greasers, scared of Death's Head but just want to get back to good ol' racing. These guys are master mechanics, comic relief, and even courageous allies who watch out for each other. Be sure to voice-act these guys with flare.

DEATH'S HEAD

A gang of cowards, cheaters, and scum from all over the galaxy, members pose as undead skeletons by wearing a simple helmet holo. They're mortal, alright, and live in constant fear of Brutus, who leads the gang with a far more evil tone than any of them bargained for. Too late to turn back now, they chose the wrong side. Let your players enjoy blowing their buggies apart, ramming their grav bikes, and seeing them crash into Phantom's impervious skid-outs.

BRUTUS

Chief jerk of the racing gang, Brutus has been hard-wired into a synth body. He has the abilities of a Brain Horror and the driving skill to make it deadly. He's a classic bully: brave with his gang and a total coward in a fair fight. His only dream is to possess Phantom. Be sure to let Brutus get his due punishment to end this adventure with a bang. Charon won't want the living leaving his realm without a price...and Brutus is due for a few eternities in Hell.

CONCLUSION

WIPEOUT!

To give this adventure teeth, it needs to be deadly. Crashing in a fireball is just too cool, and if there's no possibility of it happening, there's no real danger. That means you, the GM, need to be prepared for a total wipeout. Never fear! A wipe just means everyone is DOWN, not DEAD. That difference is key. Here are three scenarios to handle a total wipe. If they wipe a FOURTH time, consider actually killing them all off and bending the session or campaign with new story twists of commensurate epicness.

1: Huh? Whoah, what happened? The heroes wake up in Ratboy's garage, charred and battered, but still alive. They each have 1 HP, and 5 pieces of LOOT each are destroyed (roll or choose). It's been a few days, and Death's Head have stolen Phantom, terrorizing GONE with its incredible capabilities.

2: What do you want with us, scumbag? Regaining consciousness chained to a cave wall, the heroes have been taken captive by Death's Head. They're being held in a sand cave, all LOOT taken (and stored somewhere nearby), and Brutus using them to lure Star and Phantom out for a final confrontation.

3: We fight with you, off worlders. An enclave of Zurin in the deep desert rescues the fallen heroes, salvages most of their LOOT, and brings them back to full health. Incur a -1 CON penalty to all members, though. The Zurin pledge to help the heroes defeat Death's Head and put Star's tormented soul to rest at last.

EYES of SETT

The last hope of a desert village rests far below the sand.
Before the water can flow pure once again, an ancient evil must be cleansed.
Soon, you will learn why men fear the darkness below.

OVERVIEW

WATER IS LIFE

Faced with a perilous crossing of the Koabi desert, you and your company have one hope to resupply: the village of Hal. Doom has touched this place, and poison bubbles in the wells. You've only one choice: purify the water, and end an ageless evil.

- The spring has been poisoned far below, by the presence of the undead
- Rumor tells of the 'Tomb of the Serpent' below the sand and the demon that dwells there
- An ancient servant of the forgotten Snake Gods dwells below. This is Sarvas
- An entrance to the tunnels is known outside of Hal near a set of sand-blanketed ruins
- One brave villager, Liette, dares to follow the heroes, intent on stopping them

Sarvas is, in fact, awakening, but he needs fresh blood to fully rise and is using the poisoned spring as bait.

MOMENTS

EYES OF SETT is a simple, short, trap-laden dungeon run. Be sure to embellish the simplicity with desert flavor, ancient death, and the weird colors and patterns of serpent Gods. This setting is a perfect way to introduce players to the serpent-ruled past of Alfheim.

1: ARRIVAL IN HAL

Hal is a squat, geometric town of cubic stone buildings. The quarry is nearby, but the dark hollows of stone hold secrets that overshadow daily life.

- The citizens look sick, dehydrated, and afraid
- Overhear an argument about the 'blasted water' and notice people pointing West
- A central well is bubbling black goo and odd spore-like polyps

2: STORM IN THE RUINS

Learning of the spring beneath the ruins, embark. The ruins are choked with a sudden, weird mist, and with it come the dead.

- Survive the dead who walk in the fog
- Find the toppled entrance downward

3: HALL OF SACRIFICE

Beyond an endless spiral stair, a long, narrow hall features manacled corpses and four massive snake-head statues. Both ends slam shut. A fine trap.

- Snake heads feature bowls in their mouths, stained blackish red
- A floor plate triggers poison gas! It billows from the snake heads, each spray doing 1D4 poison damage per ROUND to all in the hall (4D4!)
- The far door can only be opened by prying (STR) or decoding a password (INT)
- Gas sprays can be disabled by placing 1D4 HP of human blood in the sacrificial bowl

4: THE LAPIS MAZE

Greenish pillars rise from a foot of standing water in this deep place. A huge hoard of mummified dead wander here in an odd vortex. Stealth is the only way.

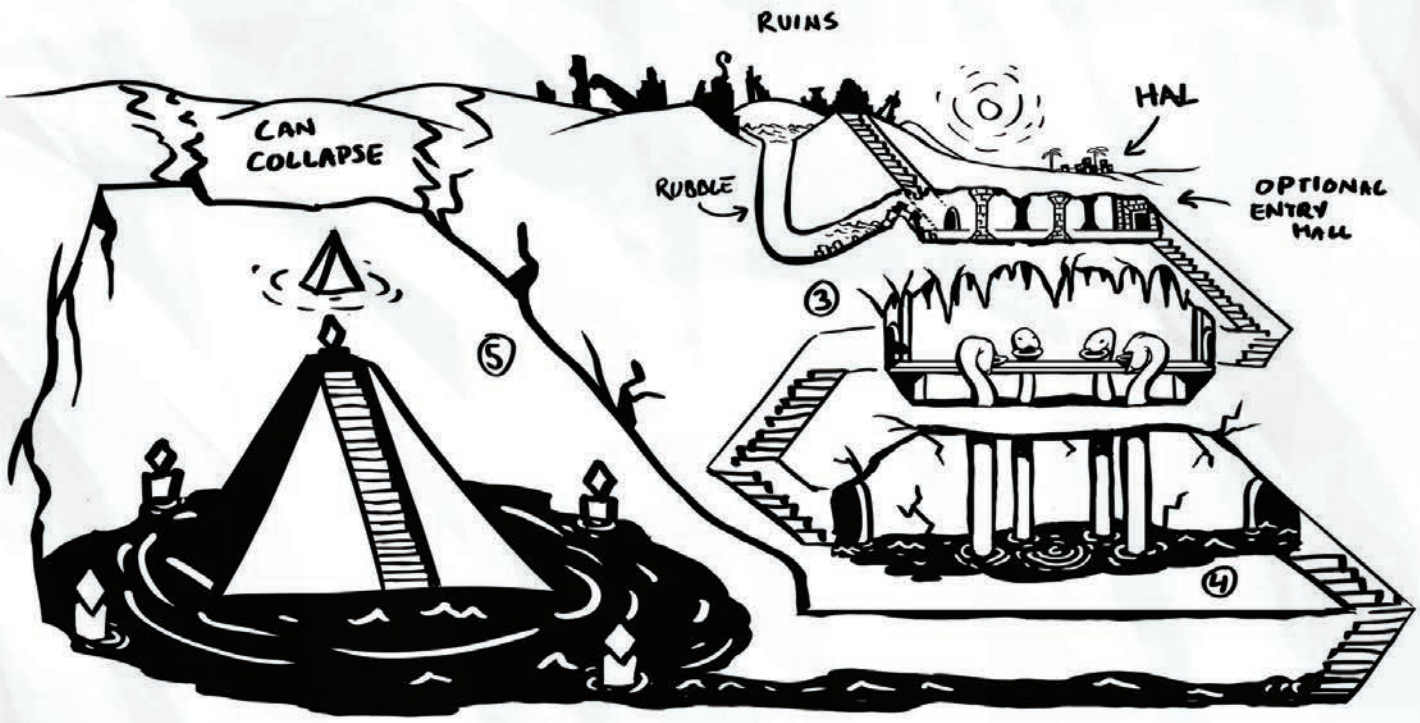
- Combined DEX EFFORT by the party can elude the hoard's attention with a careful route
- Roll a D4 timer. Before it reaches 0, the group needs to muster 1 HEART of DEX EFFORT or be spotted
- Closer looks reveal a lapis pattern on the floor, which the mummies seem to follow. This deduction grants ULTIMATE EFFORT on DEX rolls

5: ENTOMBED

A final chamber contains an underground pyramid, with a tiny door, resting in the aquifer. Within, columns and a central pyramid hold the Eyes of Sett. Evil hangs in the air.

- 4 green gems glow in the corners, and a central gem, atop a stone pyramid, crackles with power
- A deep hum fills the space, creates oppressive gravity, and all those within can only move NEAR
- Ever-shifting slime-cubes slide in concentric rings. Every GM's turn, they will burn heroes with acid and hurl them back to a far wall or grapple them
- Removing the central gem ends the gravity hum, dissolves the cubes, and opens Sarvas' tomb!
- Peripheral gems can be destroyed (1 HP) to rob Sarvas of 1 HEART of HP
- Those who offered blood in the sacrificial hall do ULTIMATE EFFORT against Sarvas

THE MAP



CYCLOPEAN HALLS OF THE SNAKE MEN

Here are 20 details that can be found with a closer look. ROLL or CHOOSE on successful investigations.

1: A satchel of bloody iron coins stamped with a serpent's head, a forsaken currency
2: Four petrified adventurers. Their stories, and their gear, are lost forever
3: A silver chalice with the initials EF amidst the sand, or muck
4: A limitless chasm in the wall and, far out of reach, the glint of gold
5: Weird indiscernible runes. The very sight of them causes your blood to freeze in your veins
6: A blood-stained dagger hidden away behind a loose stone. It's still wet
7: A silk veil, common among gypsies and charlatans alike. What's this doing here?
8: A map of the world before the fall of the Serpentine Empire. Strange, those ruins aren't on your map…
9: Rune and bone and obsidian - the site of a ghastly ritual long finished
10: A tome of dark, unfathomable incantations that no longer work in our realm
11: A torn parchment with an inked pyramid and weird runes depicted floating around it
12: A diary of some hapless adventurer. You dare not repeat its contents aloud
13: A spear, lodged in one wall, covered tip to tip with black beetles
14: Jars filled with rabbits preserved in a thick, gooey liquid
15: A translucent snake skin… forty feet long
16: Dozens of small insectoid statues that seem to watch you
17: Discarded war banners, thin and tapered, dark red with a serpent symbol
18: Streaks of mineral coating the walls like a snake's scales
19: A necklace with over fourteen snake fangs, each two to three inches in length
20: A splatter of perfume. It's fresh

MECHANICS

SARVAS HAS SLEPT LONG ENOUGH

SARVAS is both luring victims and using traps to kill them without lifting a scaly finger. Keep the dungeon simple but the flavor rich. Describe the shadowy arcades, the echoing halls, the alabaster columns. Most of all, reinforce the feeling that SARVAS, an ageless evil, must not be allowed to reach the surface. The age of snake men must not be unleashed again.

1: Hoard: The Lapis Maze features a Hoard. Make this sting, but make it fun to hack through. Each mummified corpse has 1 HP. For their attack, do a normal roll. For each point they succeed beyond the TARGET, roll 1D4 damage! These are the numerous claws and ragged teeth closing in! How many are there? More than can be killed.
2: Drawn to Life: Loud sounds, yelling, or racket will summon 1D4 mummified dead.
3: Gods, what is THAT: Some sights are too horrific to endure. Inflict 1 HP of damage to those who read runes, inspect blasphemous frescoes, or gaze into the eyes of the dead. Three HP inflicted this way ALSO does 1 permanent point of INT damage!
4: Serpent's Touch: Those who make the blood sacrifice bond with the Serpent Gods and take on a subtle serpentine quality by adventure's end: glassy black eyes, scaly skin, or a weird jaw line.

LOOT

Even as a one shot, CHEST-locked LOOT can be fun in EYES OF SETT because of the simplicity of the dungeon. EFFORT-locked chests combined with time pressure in the rooms, and the huge, cavernous feel, makes a turn here and there between action very rich and worth playing out. Don't bother with SHABBY LOOT down here... wonders await!

SHAMBLERS

ROLLS: +1 ALL ROLLS

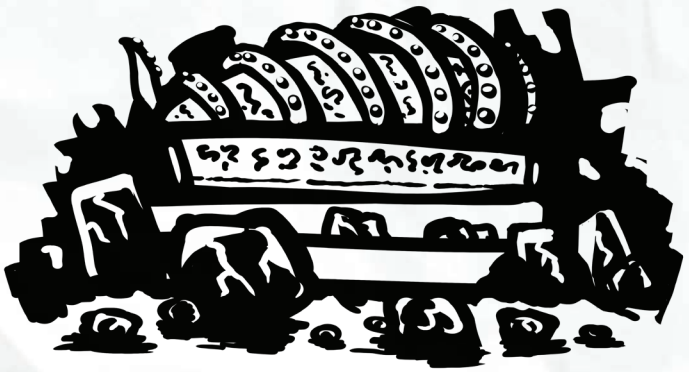
ACTIONS

CLAWING, BITING: A simple WEAPON attack that leaves itchy, burning injuries
GRABBING: In a blind stumble these things grasp and pull at living things. Target is grappled with a STR roll to break free. The grip is terribly cold
MOANING: The airy, hissy moan of these dead things calls their kind and can instill a terrible fear in the living

Be they skeletal shadows in the desert fog, stumbling zombies of the jungle cults, or mummified lords of some blasphemous ancient dynasty, these creatures are mindless, numb haunts driven only by a thirst to kill. They can be easily avoided and deceived, but in great numbers, they are nearly invincible.

BARELY INTACT: The great majority of shamblers have only 1 HP. ANY successful attack against them breaks them in half, tears their dusty heads off, or simply crumbles them.

DEATH IN DISINTEGRATION: Unless burned to ash or pulverized to dust, these things will re-form and stand back up in 1D4 ROUNDS.



UNHOLY LEADER: 1 in 50 of these is an UNHOLY ONE. These Shamblers are blessed with an artifact that makes them immune to ALL forms of harm, save the removal of their sacred amulet or crown.

EASILY TURNED: A holy symbol, honest prayer, or shining light of faith can repel these creatures, but they are not afraid. They simply wait patiently at arm's length for the effect to subside or the caster to tire, and they move in. Time is on their side.

GRAVE SLIME

ROLLS: +3 STR

ACTIONS

PSEUDOPOD: Grave Slimes probe, grapple, and lash out with goopy limbs of shapeless acid jelly. These pseudopods do BASIC damage, or grapple for a normal STR roll to escape

STICKY ACIDIC ABSORPTION: Anything besides stone that touches a Grave Cube becomes stuck to it. In 1D4 ROUNDS, if the object or creature has not escaped, it is absorbed into the Cube's interior. Stuck creatures must roll a higher STR roll than the Cube to pull free. Up to 6 creatures can be stuck at once

ABSORBED: Once absorbed, creatures and objects take Ultimate Acid Damage for each turn inside. Regardless of HEARTS, any living thing trapped inside suffocates in 4 ROUNDS. This kind of death ignores a normal 'DYING' roll. The ONLY way out is for the Cube to be destroyed

Grave Slimes are smaller, less powerful Slime Cubes that are bound to magical stones. These mindless jellies simply probe the darkness for something, anything, to engulf or devour. They also smell of moldering pond sludge or rotting muck.

GEM-BOUND: Grave slimes cannot move at all. They are bound to a nearby power gem and simply convulse and slurp where they sit. Foes that are CLOSE are subject to their attacks. Also, when the gem that gives them life is removed from its perch, or destroyed, the Grave Slime will dissipate into acidic goo.

TRANSLUCENT: The weird, cloudy, see-through material of these creatures can be very hard to see in low light. Where it seems one quivers in the black, there may be hundreds. Treat attempts to spot and count them as HARD.

CORROSIVE: Their smaller size makes Grave Slimes more acidic. On a critical attack, not only does the Grave Slime roll ULTIMATE damage, but it also destroys one randomly selected piece of LOOT in the victim's equipped list.

SARVAS THE AGELESS

ROLLS: +3 ALL ROLLS

ACTIONS (2 PER TURN)

SPECTRAL SLASH: Claws imbued with millenia of death, MAGICAL melee attack

MADDENING HISS: All NEAR enemies must make a CHA or WIS roll or be totally immobilized by this brain-blasting sound. Only injuring Sarvas, or his own will, can end the effect

DRAIN: Using hideous, arcane words from another time, Sarvas makes an INT roll on a target it can see. Success heals him for MAGICAL EFFECT that is taken from the target's HP

PETRIFY: Any creature that looks directly at Sarvas, even on accident, can be turned to stone. Sarvas and his victim make CHA rolls. If Sarvas wins, the victim is turned to stone in 1D4 ROUNDS

Before their fall from the realm of Alfheim, the snake men preserved some of their most powerful kin in underground tombs. Sarvas is one such envoy of his race, now waking, ravenous, filled with hate and a desperate lust to recapture the world.

HORRIBLE FURY: Sarvas will relentlessly attack whoever breaks or currently holds the gemstone that sat atop his tomb, even if it is being tossed about.

EVIL, BUT NOT CHAOTIC: Sarvas is evil, but his will to reignite the serpent empire is not wanton or blood-clouded. He is devious, tactical, and thinks long-term. To this end, he will negotiate, flee, or deceive before fighting blindly to the death.

CONCLUSION

JOIN THE DEAD

If your heroes fall, defeated by Sarvas or his traps and minions, consider turning them into undead servants to conclude the session. Maybe they reluctantly serve him as he rises into Hal, or they agree to use their undeath to sabotage his tomb with their last vestige of human will. Oh, the cruel endings of undead heroes!

WHAT OF LIETTE?

Liette can make a great wild card in this adventure. She can be a clutch ally, avoiding a wipe, or a lying traitor, joining Sarvas in the end. Perhaps SHE is actually Sarvas the Ageless and transforms in the tomb when the gemstones are recovered! At the very least, she can provide back story or be a frightening casualty of the terrible underworld. You may even have a player act as Liette, and give her a terrible secret to reveal in her own way....

RUN!

End the adventure with a SESSION-END roll as Sarvas falls and the tomb begins to collapse. A few suspenseful rolls should be enough to escape. Depending on your tone, you can interrupt celebration in Hal with scores of now-loose Shamblers emerging from the desert! Also consider a powerful artifact, perhaps a custom piece of LOOT, in Sarvas' tomb as they flee.

EVIL UNLEASHED

If the heroes survive but fail to kill Sarvas, he will rise from the tomb, surrounded by an army of undead, and ravage the town of Hal utterly. At the last moment, he will spare the heroes, his saviors, and vanish with a hissing laughter into the black of night. What have you done?

BENEATH THE DOOR

Formless malice invades the mind of an explorer.
In time, his entire family is changed... twisted into visions of horror.
So it is the heroes become entangled in the web of an elder God...

OVERVIEW

A SLOW BOIL

Cosmic Horror is a very special kind of story telling. Slowly reveal the clues, heed the details, and build the gloom! Be ready to have intricate, nuanced NPCs with odd behavior, and be sure to lend gravity to your descriptions. Here are the bullets of this grim tale:

- It's a stormy autumn night, 1894, New Hampshire
- Heroes crash their stagecoach and wind up bed ridden in Ardenmoor Manor
- The staff of the manor are peculiar, and the grounds keepers even more so
- The stage driver, Reginald, and other guests are vanishing, and horrific sounds are heard below
- Lord Arden, long deceased, was an archaeologist vexed by a cursed trapezohedral relic, and darkness has hung over the house since
- Beneath the house, through a door in the floor, are horrors blacker than the gulf between the stars

Use the vanishing innocents to keep the players wanting answers, then take them on an ever-more horrific ride through the doom of this wretched place.

MOMENTS

Remember, this kind of horror relies more on atmosphere than tactics. Consider running this session 'theatre of the mind' with a few visual aids. What you can't see is always more scary than what you can.

1: CRASH ON THE BLACK HILL ROAD

Our heroes ride along in the rain. Suddenly Reginald cries out "Christ, what is that?" then BOOM, and the coach smashes and tumbles!

- CON rolls or black out instantly
- Those who hold on see the horses killed, and Reginald bleeding terribly, then..darkness

2: DAYS OF FEVER

An unknown number of days later they awaken in the eerie old halls. They have full HP, but shaken

- Mention their weird visions of the staff
- Other visitors have been vanishing
- Lady Arden is glad you're okay but insists you rest

3: ORVILLE'S DEMISE

Through a night window, a gardener is seen waving his arms wildly in the rain. He is misshapen in some way. Then Lady Arden appears, walks up to him, and shoots him in the eye socket with a spear gun. He drops dead.

- The peril of this place starts to take shape
- Know your cast and areas and let players guide things forward...there is no set sequence
- Orville's body is missing, and so is Reginald

4: THE GROUNDS

With some evil implied, the heroes will now start skulking about. Now you can start escalating the dangers and revealing more clues. The rain never fully lets up, and dawn seems always a few hours away...

- Mr. Garrett stalks with hedge-shears
- Mr. Stillson is in the house, hoping to electrocute them
- The monstrous plants in the greenhouse wail with the sound of crying children

5: DISCOVERIES AND PURSUIT

Now things tumble out of control. The staff are fake-skinned horrors, there are hidden rooms filled with skeletons, and awful mud seeps up from below. Tumble them from clue to clue, nearing death and madness, and lead them to THE DOOR.

- Use poor Reginald's cries to lure them
- Occasionally scramble space and time to mess with them
- Lord Arden calls them..beckons them to come and see the truth

6: FACE TO FACE

Finally, below the mysterious door, a massive cavern awaits, with descending stairs. There stands Lord Arden is his final, mind-bending form, and he IS THE DOOR...the door to Sothoth...TO FOREVER!

- Roll SESSION END after an opening exchange
- Arden's hate can take a humanoid form as a dire enemy
- AZATOTH has been called and towers over the landscape, as big as a mountain outside as Arden Manor crumbles to ruin!

LOVECRAFT LEGACY

These kinds of adventures can be truly fantastic, especially with imaginative, engaged players. Read a few of Lovecraft's incredible stories for yourself! Feel the emotions he evokes, and aim for that, not simply imitating tropes or themes in his work. Make it yours!

Most importantly, have a strong sense of 'what really happened' or 'what horrors await,' so you can answer numerous questions and create details that all allude to some never-truly-revealed terror just around the next corner. Lord Arden returned from Cambodia half-mad with a trapezohedron artifact that brought pure evil here. He burned the chapel, killed his children, and descended into some cavern below. Now the staff, hidden horrors themselves, gather his victims.

THE RIDDLE OF ARDENMOOR

Here are 20 things found throughout the manor and grounds of Ardenmoor. If your ROLL defies the flow, or the mood, just CHOOSE an item that builds the revelation as needed. In most adventures, this list is for flavor, but here it is the very center of the story!

1: News clippings: 'Arden children killed in chapel fire' and 'Ardenmoor rumors spread'
2: An old science journal featuring log entries from Sir Arden's journey to Cambodia
3: A carved rattan sword-cane, the handle carved with children's faces in a spiral pattern
4: A 10-pound sledge hammer, short grip, caked in dried blood
5: Well-worn old time keys on a large iron ring
6: An oak reading desk with a few scattered works on Cambodian Paleoculture, Jewel-craft, and Prison Machines
7: A large porcelain tub filled with clean water, and a large bucket of chipped ice nearby
8: A colonial news sheet, framed on the wall: 'Arden family saves town'
9: A wax cylinder and wind-up player. One hidden cylinder is a recording of Lady Arden's suicide note
10: A large, metal-bound botany book. Several of the pages have been scribbled out with black ink
11: A family 'Dead Book' with photos of the deceased. Lord Arden is sheet-shrouded in his photo
12: A large piece of wall art featuring several dried starfish
13: A stack of silver nitrate photo negative plates, can be chemically developed, show a blurry THING
14: A small collection of bottled fetuses, each labeled with a cryptic glyph
15: A geological survey of the Ardenmoor plot showing vast limestone caverns below
16: A pair of much-used welder's goggles
17: A 17th century steel shield wall hanging, but it is dented and off kilter
18: A crude spear gun and 3 spears on a small rack
19: A strange, cracked plaster block imprinted with what looks like Sir Arden's face
20: A small brown glass bottle of high grade morphine with a rubber dropper

THE MAP

KNOW THE LOCATIONS AND LET THEM WANDER

BENEATH is a very unique adventure because there is no set sequence of events. Your challenge will be to know the whole truth of this place, what has happened, and what is currently happening. Reveal pieces of that picture as your players surprise you with their next move. If they are ever stumped, chase them or lead them to a location you know you can make exciting. Here are the locations around the Ardenmoor:

1: THE CRASH: Reginald is terribly wounded after seeing something in the road and crashing. Lightning strikes, rain pours. If heroes return, Reginald is nowhere to be found. Subtle clues indicate other stages or wagons have crashed here in recent months.

2: THE BLUFFS: Huge quarried ridges ascend to the manor. Markings on the ground indicate the quarried stone was moved up and into the manor somehow.

3: ARDEN MANOR: A great room, guest quarters upstairs, dining room, and a study with a massive locked door in the floor. Below there is the final confrontation with Lord Arden. Lady Arden wanders, looking to return guests to their rooms or host meals. Once Orville is killed, Lady Arden, Mr. Garret, and Mr. Stillson all stalk all locations with murderous intent.

4: THE SMITHY: A workshop for groundskeepers with metal spikes and chains being made. Skokie, the only surviving servant the heroes encounter, is hiding here. She is deformed, but true of heart, and terrified.

5: THE CHAPEL: Burned to ruins shortly after Lord Arden returned from Cambodia, now haunted with the voices of the children, who he burned alive there, when driven mad by the trapezohedron artifact.

6: THE GREENHOUSE: Here the children's souls have grown into the soil, creating a monstrosity of plant and horror. It lies quietly until the heroes are inside, then blocks the door and tries to rip them apart.

SANITY

SOME THINGS ARE NOT MEANT FOR MEN TO SEE

Every good cosmic horror game has an insanity or fear mechanic. In many ways, counting these points as they tick down is more central to a horror game than actual HP, because the danger is more psychological than combat-driven. **ICRPG** is no different! Each character starts with 1 HEART of SANITY. The deeper they peer into the antediluvian abyss, the more this reservoir of reason is eroded.

Inflict SANITY DAMAGE whenever the scene is too terrible, too close, or too sudden for a character to simply wave it away. Scenes of abject horror, gruesome glimpses of human suffering, realizations of supernatural inevitability, or worst of all, views of the vast uncaring universe in its infinitude all cause SANITY DAMAGE. As the GM, decide if a particular case allows for a CHA or INT or WIS roll to resist or reduce incoming SANITY damage.

EVENT	SANITY DAMAGE
See a person dismembered, beheaded, or die terribly	1
Suddenly discover a corpse or scene of depravity	1
Stare directly at a supernatural entity such as ghost or zombie	1, 1D4 if horde
Have a limb ripped or chopped off (lose all but 1 HP in one attack)	1D4
Witness an object of celestial, antediluvian, or trans-dimensional origin	1D4
Gaze upon an abomination of the world between worlds	1D4, 1D8 if sustained
Assemble clues that lead to dark truths transcending time and space	1D4
Witness the arrival of an elder God such as Azatoth or Ogdru	1D6
Form a mind-union with an elder God or Beyonder	1D10

SANITY	STATUS AND EFFECTS
10	Safe in the veil of daily normalcy
9	Rationalizing away what was just witnessed...it couldn't be...
8	Aghast, on edge, wary of unexplained sounds
7	Shocked, looking for any way to avoid the source
6	Truly afraid, all CHA and WIS rolls are HARD, cannot ATTACK the source of fear
5	Pure, white hot terror, break a cold sweat, ALL ROLLS are HARD
4	No, no, NO! -1 to all STATS, must seek a hiding place or back away immediately
3	Screaming, petrified with fear for 1 ROUND, beg allies to flee
2	Run! Run for your lives! Use 1D4 ROUNDS to flee at maximum speed
1	Tears of denial and realization, fall to your knees, ALL ROLLS HARD is now PERMANENT
0	Catatonic, muttering, clinically mad, seeing the terror again and again forever

CLASSES

SIMPLE, FRAGILE, HUMAN

Heroes in this kind of adventure are not superhuman or well-armed. They're just people. Often, a notion of curiosity can help keep things moving.

PROFFESSOR

Learned, Worldy, Calm

Starter: Aged Pipe (Sanity rolls are never HARD)

You've a gift for research and study. So many new realms of knowledge are opening in this area, and you are fascinated with their synergistic ramifications for metaphysics, anthropolgy, and even linguistics. You've been abroad for weeks, and now hope to reach Allerdale University within a few short days.

VETERAN

Tough, Violent, Unstable

Starter: Silver Ring (Never be forced to Flee)

You've been delayed on your way home from a too-long tour in a bloody foreign war. The front was a nightmare of bullets and smoke, and all you can think of is family back home. Still, in the quiet of each night, you see the piles of dead soldiers, the fires burning, and hear the crackle of rifle fire.

DOCTOR

Nervous, Cold, Wealthy

Starter: Field Dressings (Heal 1 HP 3 times, no roll)

The late 19th century is a golden age of medical learning, and you stand at the frontier. New understanding of organs, tumors, maladies, and their physiological origins has unlocked unimagined vistas of human improvement. Some say your work is ghastly, but you know it is for the betterment of all.

PORTER

Stout, Poor, Spiritual

Starter: Lifter's Belt (STR rolls are never HARD)

Your family has always made an honest living as porters and hired hands. Now, newly arrived in America, you've had no trouble finding good hard work. It's a big world, and you can't wait to see more of it and the good people that call it home.

LOOT

REPLACEMENTS

The list below replaces STARTER LOOT. Starting EQUIPMENT can be left out, specific to a character, or done as normal.

REVOLVER

Loud, Near, 6 capacity, WEAPON Damage

ROSETTA CODEX

A strange book, Do MAGIC EFFORT when translating

BOWIE KNIFE

Deadly, Close, Useful, WEAPON Damage

CHEMISTRY KIT

For tests and more tests

PICK AXE

Heavy, Cannot be Sheathed, WEAPON Damage, Dig

LANTERN

Gas, Luminous, Near, WIS rolls using this are EASY

BIBLE

King James, Well-worn, CHA rolls against evil are EASY

MEDICAL BAG

Make an INT roll to heal 1 HP with a touch

FLASH CAMERA

Takes up to 8 photos on silver plates

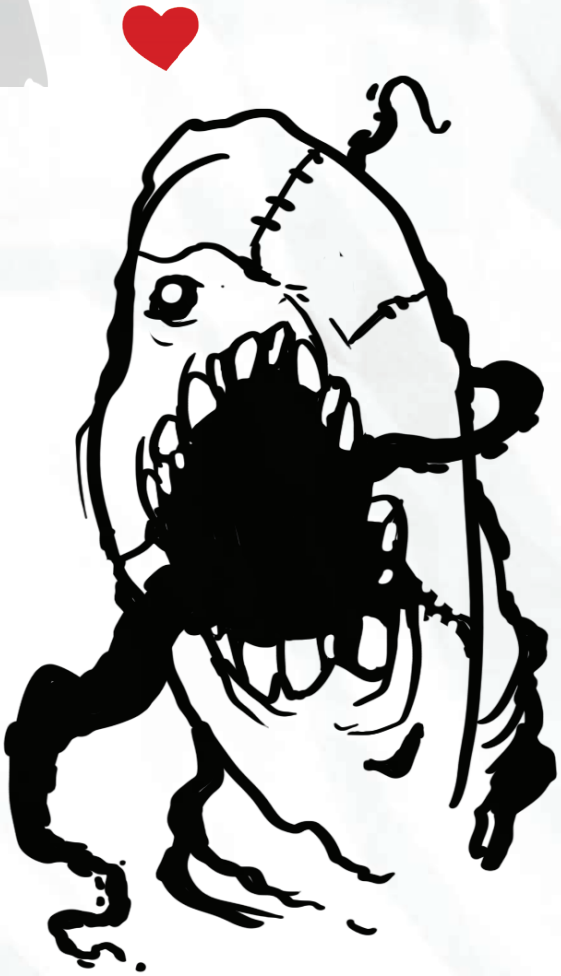
WAX CYLINDER RECORDER

Record up to 1 minute of audio and play it back

LOOT IN DREAD HORROR

Handling LOOT in this kind of game is very different than your common dungeon run. For SHABBY LOOT and all the items on the 'Riddle of Ardenmoor' list, don't even wait for player searching! Simply mention these objects in rooms and spaces. You'll have little use for normal LOOT, as this type of game is more about humanity than equipment. One REVOLVER will be a defining item! The rest is flavor, story, clues, realism, and revelation.

ARDEN MANOR STAFF



ROLLS: +1 ALL ROLLS

ACTIONS

HOWL IN AGONY: Slowly changing into monstrosities, and hiding it with rubber masks, these wretches are in terrible pain. Once revealed, they howl, inflicting 1 SANITY DAMAGE to all who see and hear

SLOWLY DEVOUR: Grabbing and sucking with inextricable evil, these creatures inflict BASIC DAMAGE with tentacles, softened teeth, and acidic spittle. Taking more than 3 damage in this way inflicts another 1 SANITY DAMAGE

Pleasant and calm on the false exterior, the three staff members in Arden Manor are actually hideous mutations. They have been changed by the evil aura of the trapezohedron and live as suffering puppets of Lord Arden's abstract will. Their primary drive is to capture and imprison travelers and guests for Lord Arden to feed upon.

MR. STILLSON: The butler did it. He did it many times and patiently attends the needs of his victims-to-be. He always speaks fondly of Lord Arden and wistfully dreams of the coming of Azatoth, when the world of men will burn.

MR. GARRETT: Once a gardener, he is now a murderous mute. He says nothing and is a craven thing who sometimes steals a victim for his own brain-feeding appetites.

LADY ARDEN: The real Lady Arden killed herself long ago, as discovered on the wax cylinder. This abomination has posed in her stead, soothing sickly guests, hosting lie-soaked dinners, and dragging the near-dead beneath the door.

THE CHILDREN

ROLLS: +3 ALL ROLLS (EXCEPT SANITY)

ACTIONS (2 PER TURN)

NEEDLE WHIPS: Whipping green vines covered in tiny needles thrash about, inflicting WEAPON Damage
HORRIBLE FACES: The Arden children are entangled, melted into this monstrosity. They choose a target and scream at them, begging for the pain to stop. Inflict 1D4 SANITY Damage with no chance to resist
EAT: The upper pod of this shape is a saw-toothed mouth. Any CLOSE enemies can be pulled in and chewed upon. Inflict 1D4 WEAPON Damage until the victim escapes with a STR roll or other means
EXTINGUISH: The children died in a terrible fire and hate to see ANY flame. This action lets the creature instantly extinguish any flames within FAR range

Those poor children, burned alive by the mad Lord Arden in his last days. Now their souls have joined with the soil of the grounds, and they erupt in a most horrific form. In their torment, they crave companions, but they only spread death.

IN THE GREENHOUSE: This creature can appear in the Greenhouse area, writhing and sprouting up from neglected old pots and debris piles. It will overgrow the entrance and trap victims to ensure feeding.

FROM LADY ARDEN: Another scenario can be that this beast bursts its way out of Lady Arden in a phantasmic explosion of offal. She can announce “you’ve awoken the children...no! NO!”

LONG MEMORIES: The Arden children still remember their driven-mad father burning them in the chapel, and their gurgling can reveal clues if it fits the moment. There could even be a twisted exchange between hero and creature just seconds before it goes in for the kill.

LORD ARDEN

ROLLS: +5 ALL ROLLS (EXCEPT SANITY)

ACTIONS (2 PER TURN)

VOICE OF FOREVER: Any time this colossus speaks, the heavens are torn open with the howl of it. To hear this sound requires a CHA roll to avoid SANITY Damage. Inflict 1 with a successful roll, 1D4 if they fail

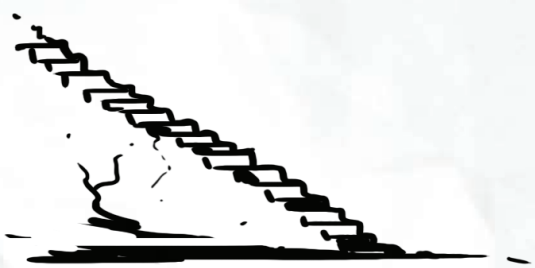
BOOMING PULSE: Each turn Lord Arden takes is ended by a BOOMING PULSE. This low, ominous vibration emanates from the door-mouth and requires a CON or STR roll to resist. Failure results in taking 1 Damage and falling to the ground. Fallen victims can only move NEAR on their next turn

DRAG TO HELL: A coiled tentacle slides forth from the bulging polyps on this structure, searching for human minds to feed on. Evade it with a DEX roll or be dragged into the mouth in 1D4 ROUNDS. This tentacle cannot be escaped, but it can be chopped off, with 1 HEART of HP

Having looked too long into the trapezohedron artifact, Lord Arden went mad, became deformed, and then had this immense chamber built for his transformation. Here he feeds on victims brought by his servants and screams to Azatoth across the dimensions, bidding it rise.

REVELATION: In addition to using his voice as a weapon of terror, Lord Arden provides final reveals.

"Look into me! Into the stars! INTO FOREVER!"
"Ahh-Zahh-TOTH! Come forth, master of dreams!"
"I am almost complete. Come, and join us! JOIN THE FINAL FORM OF ALL THINGS!"
"Run if you must, insects! To lay eyes on me is to know annihilation! All you have ever known is gone! ONLY FOREVER REMAINS!"



CONCLUSION

RETURN FROM BEYOND

A party wipe here is quite likely, especially if injuries are sustained in the stagecoach crash, or a monster fight goes wrong. You could take them prisoner (a common theme), but more fun is to have them fed upon, and awaken in the chaos dimension of Azatoth. A doorway back to Earth can be reached, but at what cost....

RISE OF AZATOTH

No matter what happens, roll your session end die when the time is right. The session end roll is a countdown to Azatoth, a mountain-sized abomination, rising from the pit below Ardenmoor into a luminous gap in the clouds. Inflict 1D6 or more SANITY Damage! Leave the fate of reality in unresolved limbo and end the session with “what the?”

FIRE AND DEATH

Another ending could see the house, and all those within, burn to the ground. This outcome is a fitting and painful end for a family already riven by fire. To conclude your session, describe an epilogue where reports describe the manor intact again, as if nothing happened, and workers diligently quarrying the limestone bluffs.

THE CLOUDS CLOSE

As quickly as Azatoth rises, it vanishes into the sky, and the clouds resume their dark appearance. No one will believe any element of this report from any surviving heroes. The isolation of knowing, of seeing that hideous trapezohedral relic, will send them to a lonely grave or screaming in the asylum. “Let me out! YOU HAVE TO LET ME OUT! Mother of God, IT’s in here! IT IS IN HERE!”

PLANET KILLER

Formless malice invades the mind of an explorer.
In time, his entire family is changed... twisted into visions of horror.
So it is the heroes become entangled in the web of an elder God...

OVERVIEW

PART ONE: THE FALL OF ARNOR

Planet Killer is the story of a cataclysmic conflict between the Imperium and the forces of Krell. The adventure is designed to be played in two parts, with two separate groups of characters. Even if you don't run it as written, be sure to check out the rules additions for space fighters and dogfighting. More detail for running Power Armor can also be found in **ICRPG** WORLDS.

- Arnor is a Krell world that has been decimated by an Imperium war fleet.
- The heroes come out of cryo sleep on Arnor too late, and their battle suit hangar is all but destroyed. They are the last survivors.
- One task remains: to capture telemetry data on the Imperium fleet to find some weakness.
- The heroes must find a way to get this telemetry data off-world before the entire planet crumbles.
- The Imperium is now sweeping the planet for survivors with bio-engineered living weapons.
- In a matter of hours, the planet will be totally destroyed.

Present the heroes with the situation via a looping transmission. They have a few choices to acquire and evacuate the data. They will be hunted at every turn.

MOMENTS

Be sure you have a handle on running Power Armor and using chunks. The danger is everywhere. Give them choices, and be ready for unexpected outcomes and solutions. This is a wild ride.

1: A RUDE AWAKENING

Our heroes awaken in the rubble and chaos of a wrecked hangar. Their mission loops on a damaged screen, and their comrades have been crushed. Mount up, and get to it.

- Five battle suits are ready to power up
- A swarm of Sweepers is on its way
- The fires are spreading
- The other three locations can be plotted on a map console
- The timer for planetary destruction is visible

2: COMMAND HQ

Command HQ contains the telemetry data gathered on the Imperium. It can be downloaded into a battle suit, but a DATA POD must be used to get it off world.

- A crumbling bridge leads to HQ, over a river cluttered with the dead of Arnor
- Sweepers assault the bridge
- A Death Drone prowls the halls of the complex
- As a twist, trap the telemetry in a clunky, bulky mainframe cabinet that must be hauled

3: THE AIRBASE

This ruined facility contains numerous wrecked ships and parts. Destroyed fighters and burning transports are everywhere, but enough parts can be salvaged to rig a jump jet or escape rocket. Sweepers are everywhere, and orbital bombardments hit hardest here.

- Every D4 rounds a bombardment hits
- Heroes find ion drives, fighter weapons, missiles, and the like. Let them improvise!
- If they never visit the airbase, consider letting them find a wrecked fighter elsewhere to build their data pod jump jet
- If you need to give them more clues, have a pilot still alive in the wreckage, who begs them to accomplish the mission before expiring

4: DATA STORAGE YARD

Here, an orange barrel can be found. It is a super-durable pod for transporting data cores. The challenge? Getting it off world. This scene gets very dangerous, so be ready for a crazy fight.

- A cloud of corrosive radiation drifts across the area
- It is a confusing clutter of containers
- A few Sweepers appear here and there
- Finding the pod is not easy in all the clutter

5: IMPERATOR RAX

The Imperium's ultimate weapon will attack the heroes at a moment that feels right. They will likely not survive fighting him, so be ready for some craziness.

- Be ruthless with Rax
- Time his arrival to build a final crescendo with planetary destruction and launching the pod

THE FALL OF ARNOR: BASICS

A DOOMED WORLD

"Arnor will be vaporized in 79 minutes." Use a WORLD TIMER in this adventure. Start it at 8. At each narrative turn in the story, each epic moment, click it down one. When it reaches zero, Arnor is totally annihilated. Players are forced to ask not only 'will we win' but 'will we even survive.'

When Imperator Rax arrives, use him to mock, taunt, and belittle the heroes. He is your chance to actually speak for the Imperium, and reveal their unwavering intention to wipe out all opposition in the multiverse.

Despite this inevitable event, there are many outcomes and paths that can be taken in this struggle. Let it be nonlinear, let them surprise you!

Players build standard 6 point heroes, NO EQUIPMENT.

CRUELTY OF THE IMPERIUM

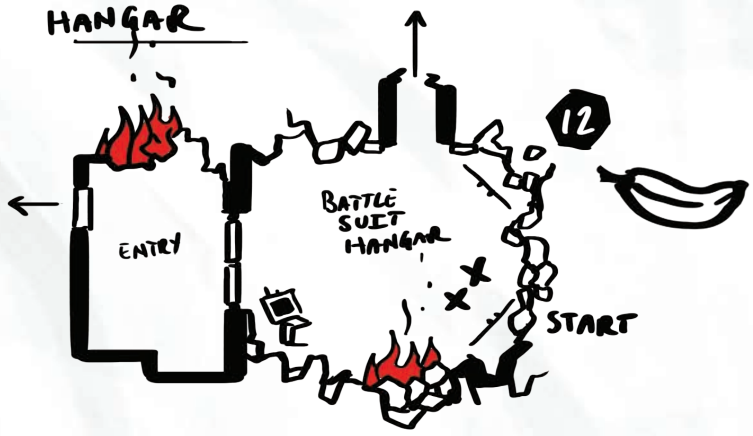
Many of the details discovered during The Fall of Arnor tell the story of the hated Imperium and the devastation they have caused. Also, consider how details can be used to remind players of their imperative mission and its ticking clock. Here are 20 options.

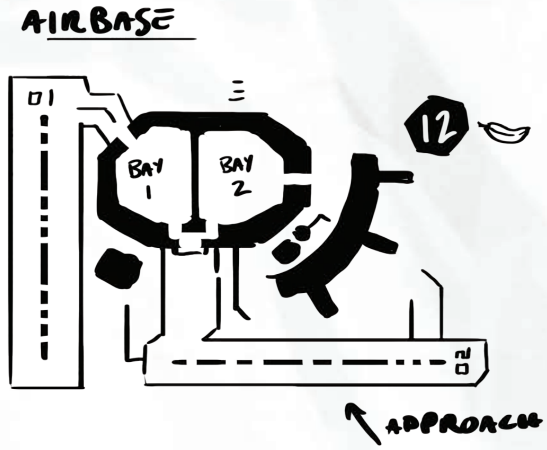
1: A crushed battle suit, crumpled beneath rubble with a pool of dried blood around it
2: A damaged computer terminal. Through the static, a voice repeats 'get that data off world at all costs!'
3: A child's doll, scorched and partially melted
4: A space fighter data recorder box. Its contents reveal a record of the total decimation of Arnor's defenses
5: An unexploded Imperium nova shell. Can function as a massive Ion Grenade if repaired or rigged
6: A battle suit with its upper torso torn off. The pilot is still inside, slumped forward
7: A flickering hologram showing Arnor's core destabilizing and the Imperium planet killer fleet in orbit
8: A Command HQ key card. Can be used to effortlessly bypass any closed doors there
9: A crashed space fighter. 2 of its 4 CHUNKS can be salvaged. Roll for which ones
10: A ruined Imperium Ghost Armor, riddled with bullet holes. It is surrounded by scorched Arnorian skeletons
11: A pile of smoldering rubble. If searched, roll twice on the SCI FI LOOT table
12: A pair of bloody dog tags that read 'Admiral Eelson Kaz'
13: A damaged but operational cargo crane. It is heavy but can be moved by two battle suits with STR rolls
14: A storage locker. When opened, 1D6 Sweepers leap out and attack!
15: 1D4 CHUNKS of a Krell battle suit. Each CHUNK has 3 HP and matches a rolled type used by players
16: The massive chain sword from an Imperator, still functional
17: A field of slain Sweepers surrounding a partially melted Krell battle suit. Its distress beacon still beeps
18: A transport bus, still running, filled with scorched skeletons
19: An unbreakable length of Krellian filament cable, 50'
20: The ruins of a Krell museum. If searched, roll twice on the ANCIENT LOOT table

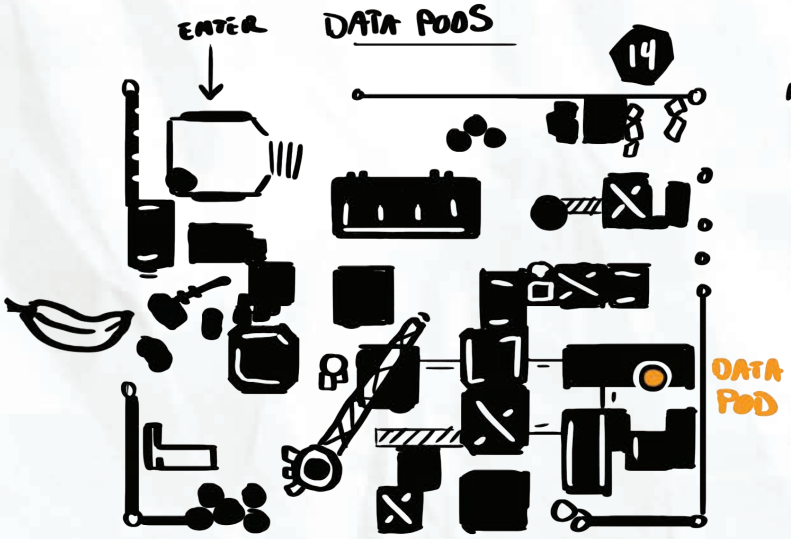
THE FALL OF ARNOR: MAPS

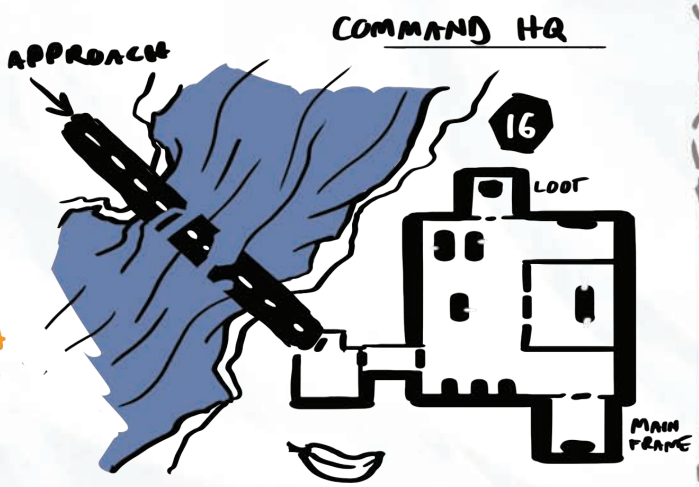
THREE POSSIBLE DESTINATIONS, ANY ORDER

Don't force a solution to this scenario if players are not finding a way to rescue the data. Even if they fail, it can be a dramatic, poetic, and exciting ride to explore, fight, and perish against Sweepers and the Imperator. As a counterpoint, if the players are inventing a way to succeed you had never imagined, let them tell the tale their way. The dice will ultimately decide their fate.









1: BATTLE SUIT HANGAR: Cryo sleep units, battle suit docks, rubble, two exits, mission console. Fires are spreading, Sweepers enter through bulkhead doors at left

2: AIRBASE: Blasted hangar bays 1 and 2, cratered runways, burning fuel depot, and destroyed fighters. Very large, open map space with wreckage and little cover

3: DATA STORAGE YARD: Towering containers, cargo cranes, stacked crates, sub floor tunnels. Corrosive cloud drifts in from the southeast

4: COMMAND HQ: Crumbling bridge, telemetry data mainframes, tight hallways, and dark corners. Interior doors use key card or simply open

THE FALL OF ARNOR: SUITS

CALLSIGN: ALFRED / SPEC: HEAVY ARMOR

Elder knight of the golden order, mentor, leader, veteran
All CHUNKS 5 VEHICLE HP (more about CHUNKS p. 152)
Chunk 1: Ablative Shield (+5 armor, explodes when destroyed)
Chunk 2: Bolt Gun (3 round burst, reload after 4 bursts, explodes if destroyed)
Chunk 3: Repair Unit (repair 1D6 onboard Chunk HP per round)
Chunk 4: Repulsor Shield (+3 armor, deflect all projectile weapons within CLOSE range)

CALLSIGN: TIGER / SPEC: MOBILITY

A psyker knight, fast, devious, unpredictable, maverick
Chunk 1: Slide Jet (Move double normal, explodes when destroyed)
Chunk 2: Pulse Cannon (Single fire then reload, always ULTIMATE)
Chunk 3: Evasion Thrusters (Evade 1 incoming attack of any type per round)
Chunk 4: Swarm Missiles (6 burst, roll to reload, hit 1-6 targets, explodes when destroyed)

CALLSIGN: FIREFLY / SPEC: SUPPORT

Complex demolitions and computer expert
Chunk 1: Repair Crane (repair 1D12 chunk HP)
Chunk 2: Comms Pack (work on computer equipment with ULTIMATE EFFORT)
Chunk 3: Ion Putty (3 uses, remotely detonate to totally destroy anything in a near radius, explodes when destroyed)
Chunk 4: Swarm Missiles (6 burst, roll to reload, hit 1-6 targets, explodes if destroyed)

CALLSIGN: SPIKE / SPEC: MELEE COMBAT

Fearless Torton nutjob, hell bent on revenge
Chunk 1: Duranium Plating (ignore damage of 5 or less, cannot dash)
Chunk 2: Blade Arm (counterattacks any successful near attackers 1 for 1)
Chunk 3: Chainsword (any attack of 13+ earns another attack, any damage of 6+ earns another damage roll)
Chunk 4: Bolt Anchors (when active, the power suit becomes immovable)

CALLSIGN: ACE / SPEC: FIREARMS

New recruit on Arnor, munitions generalist, greenhorn
Chunk 1: Bolt Rifle (Single shot, always EASY, never reload, can't be destroyed)
Chunk 2: Ballistic Mortar (in flight for 1d4 rounds, then does triple ULTIMATE in a NEAR radius, use weapon bonus)
Chunk 3: Needle Gun (ignores damage resist, target a chunk with no penalty, penetrates structures)
Chunk 4: Ion Grenade Launcher (ULTIMATE damage in near radius, 6 total,

SWEEPERS

ROLLS: +4 STATS, +2 DAMAGE

10 VEHICLE HP

ACTIONS

BIOSTEEL BITE: The Sweeper's go-to WEAPON attack. These things can bite through almost any material, and they fear nothing. Sweepers are bio engineered versions of Streakers, making them so big and so durable, they inflict VEHICLE level damage

CLING AND CLIMB: If another Sweeper is already biting a target, they will sometimes climb onto the creature or vehicle and simply latch on with their mighty jaws. Any vehicle or creature with a Sweeper attached must beat that Sweeper with an opposed STR roll to move. If more than three Sweepers latch on, the vehicle or creature cannot take ANY action until at least one is killed or shaken loose. Nasty.

Once the Imperium has destroyed a world, they unleash thousands of Sweepers to eliminate survivors and destroy any remnants of the enemy. They are metal-skinned, feral fiends with only one instinct: kill.

NON-OPTICAL SENSES: These metallic killers have no eyesight at all. They locate prey via sound, smell, magetic fields, and energy emission. If they lack a target or prey, they simply run in packs in random directions frantically seeking something to catch their attention. The longer they remain in this state, the bigger packs they form.

DEAD END LIFE FORMS: To control their numbers, the Imperium has made these creatures entirely sterile. They can never reproduce. Thus, if a population of them can be destroyed, their defeat is absolute.

MINDLESS: These things have no thinking mind at all, so they cannot be reasoned with, communicated with, frightened, or affected by any form of mental duress.

METALLIC: Having metal skin, teeth, and bones, Sweepers can be affected by magnetism and extreme heat or cold like any metal object.

DEATH DRONE

ROLLS: +4 ALL ROLLS

ACTIONS (2 PER TURN)

DURANIUM CLAWS: These ultra-sharp blades are so honed, so deadly, they always inflict ULTIMATE damage. With a well-placed stroke, a Drone can slice solid stone like warm butter

ACID SPIT: At NEAR range, the Drone will opt to spit its atomic acid venom and disappear or retreat into cover. This venom is sticky and does WEAPON damage for 4 ROUNDS once it hits a target. This corrosion also gives off toxic fumes. Any bio-form breathing these fumes must make a CON roll or take 1D4 lung damage

VANISH: If there are no foes within CLOSE range of a Death Drone, it can disappear into its surroundings with a DEX roll. A vanished drone can only be spotted with a HARD WIS roll

RAZOR TAIL: Like a steel-bladed whip, this WEAPON is fast and deadly. So much so, it ignores ARMOR. The drone rolls against the room TARGET, and damage done with the tail ignores any damage-reducing properties of its victim.

The Imperium has created many weapons, but few as insidious as the Death Drone. They are quintessential survivors, stealthy hunters, and merciless fighters. They are highly intelligent and never fight to the death if they have any means of escape.

ACID BLOOD: When slain, Death Drones spray a splash of their acid venom. Attackers must make a DEX roll or be hit. Treat this spray as an Acid Spit attack.

DEVIOUS INTELLIGENCE: These creatures can use technology, set traps, hack keypads, and even imitate voices in some cases. They toy with their prey, separating or frightening to gain advantage.

DURABLE: Any TURN a drone is not in CLOSE combat, it automatically regenerates 3 HP without using an action.

IMPERATOR RAX

ROLLS: +5 STATS, +3 ALL EFFORT

ACTIONS (3 PER TURN)

5 CHUNKS, 10 VEHICLE HP EACH

CHUNK 1: BOLT GUN: A rapid firing conventional weapon. 3 round bursts, reload after 4 bursts, explodes when destroyed, FAR range. Rax can also distribute a successful burst to up to three targets

CHUNK 2: CHAIN SWORD: This huge weapon tears through everything. Any attack of modified 13+ earns another attack. Any damage of 6+ earns another damage roll

CHUNK 3: MISSILE CLOUD: Fills an entire area of FAR radius with missile fire. Anything within that area besides Rax must make a DEX roll or be hit for ULTIMATE damage

CHUNK 4: JUMP JET: A powerful jet that can get the Imperator to low orbit but is not suitable for space maneuvers. This jet can achieve orbit even with 10 tons of cargo or dead weight in tow

CHUNK 5: SPELL STONE: This arcane relic is contained in the torso plating. Rax can use it to cast ANY INT SPELL with a roll. The Spell Stone can only be activated once per TURN

The Imperators are the ultimate weapons of the Imperium. Even when destroyed, their ghost pilots slide away in the ether to a new power suit and continue their dire errands of death. As demented souls, they delight in crushing their enemies and often laugh during battle.

HEAVY: The Imperator's armor is so heavy, it will CRUSH any object with less than 5 VEHICLE HP if stepped or landed on.

REPAIR DENDRITES: Using a nano repair system, the Imperator ignores any damage below 3.

SADISTIC: Imperator pilots will pause before slaying an enemy, just to see them squirm in the face of inevitable doom.

PORTABLE AMMO DEPOT: Imperators never reload.

FALL OF ARNOR: CONCLUSION

TOTAL ANNIHILATION

When the world timer reaches zero, no matter where the story may be, the Imperium planet killers array their full power and vaporize the planet's core. This causes a sudden, violent collapse of the entire surface. The planet crunches inward, becoming a fleeting micro-singularity or unstable black hole. No debris, no explosion, just empty space remains.

THE PACKAGE IS AWAY!

Whether escorting the data pod themselves in a salvaged ship, launching the pod on a jimmy-rigged ion drive, or executing some other far flung plan, be sure to describe in detail exactly how players know they've given the Krell one more chance to resist the unbeatable Imperium with their heroism. Even if they fail, give them each a final moment to describe their last seconds on the shattered planet.

OUTMATCHED

Imperator Rax is vastly more powerful than all five Krell battle suits combined. It shouldn't be a battle so much as a massacre. Force the players to think 'out of the box' to stop Rax, or hold him off long enough to get the data pod into space. Play Rax exactly as written, and let the dice be cruel. Even worse, Imperium ghosts like Rax can only be killed by supernatural means. Thus, even if the Imperator is destroyed, his purple-vapor skull will escape into deep space, cackling with wrathful fury.

OVERLOAD

My players invented a new battle suit mechanic so good, it has to be noted here. A Krell battle suit can be manually overloaded, blowing the micro reactor from within. A pilot who overloads his suit cannot escape the blast. Once initiated, the reactor will explode in 1D4 rounds, vaporizing anything within NEAR range. That roll can be the highlight of an entire session.

THE IMPACT ON PART TWO: DEATH ON KRELL

The lives of these heroes are being gambled on one hope: that a weakness in the Imperium war machine can be found with the data collected on Arnor. You can interpret this impact on your second session in many, many ways. Here are two suggested scenarios to link the sessions and give their lives real meaning and impact.

- **THE POD REACHES THE KRELL RESISTANCE:** With the telemetry gathered on doomed Arnor, the Krell find a weakness in the planet-killer fleet. Proceed with part two as written. Players will have a narrow chance to exploit a known weakness as the Krell fleet fights to defend their homeworld.

- **THE POD IS DESTROYED OR LOST:** If the data pod never reaches the Krell, they must defend their homeworld with their space fleet and search for a weakness DURING the battle. This scenario adds an extra phase onto part two: the battle in Krell orbit. During this extra phase, massive capitol ships do battle while comms officers attempt to hack Imperium schematics. Players, as lowly deck hands, must work this battle despite being terribly outnumbered and outclassed. Hard to believe, but the odds of surviving this version are even worse than if the data pod is delivered. Exactly how it all plays out is up to you and your players. Make it epic.

DEATH ON KRELL

PART TWO: DEATH ON KRELL

Part two takes us to the Krell homeworld, which is under attack by the Imperium fleet. Rather than heroic warriors, the heroes are a ragtag handful of deck hands aboard a Krell fighter carrier called the *KRS Nemesis*. As the *Nemesis* is being destroyed, the action explodes.

- The Krell fleet is destroyed already
- With so many personnel lost, our heroes are forced to consider flying what fighters remain to accomplish the desperate mission
- Space fighters must be used to cross the outer orbit of Krell, reach an Imperium planet killer ship, and find a way to sabotage it
- Imperium fighters are everywhere
- The *Nemesis* is breaking in half

Use a captain's P.A. announcement to call the heroes to action. Launch! Launch! Save Krell at all costs!

MOMENTS

Take a little time to test-run the dogfighting mechanics. Also, as heroes struggle to launch any fighters they can, be ruthless! Force them to be inventive as the *Nemesis* is consumed by fire and breaks apart into deep space.

1: LAUNCH! LAUNCH!

As the *Nemesis* arrives at the battle, disaster strikes. You can make this happen immediately or have the carrier torn to pieces by enemy fighters. Either way, the flight deck is compromised, and our heroes must find a way to keep hope alive.

- A few fighters can be launched
- Wrecked fighters block the runways
- Fire is spreading everywhere
- A pack of Sweepers lands in the flight bay
- One battle suit, callsign Tiger, is still intact on the flight deck
- A massive piece of debris hits the *Nemesis*, and it will break up in 1D4 ROUNDS
- Be sure the players are clear on their desperate mission: to fly across space, find a planet killer capitol ship, and find some way to destroy it

2: DOGFIGHT IN SPACE

Between the *Nemesis* and the planet killer are several SECTORS of space, swarming with Imperium micro fighters. If the heroes are destroyed in space, be sure to describe the total annihilation of the Krell homeworld.

- Imperium micro fighters move in squads of 10. If all 10 are destroyed, remove that token
- They spread out, both running overwatch on the planet killer and attacking the heroes directly
- The planet killer begins to charge its main gun. Use this as a WORLD TIMER to press the heroes forward

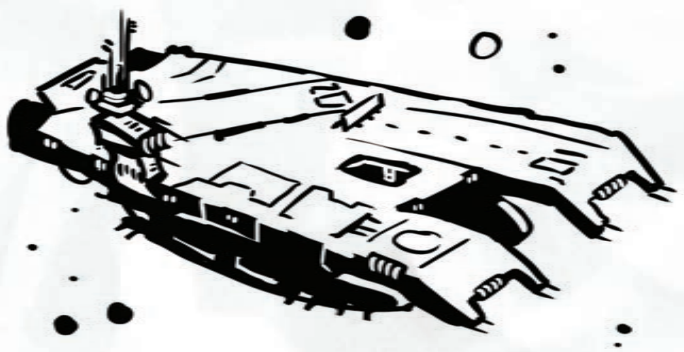
3: ABOARD THE PLANET KILLER

By whatever means possible, even simply crashing into it, the heroes must get aboard this massive Imperium ship. It has a huge flight bay, a series of corridors, the main reactors, and a captain's shuttle. One catch: Death Drones and Imperator Rax are here to stand guard.

- Once the reactor powers up, Krell will be destroyed
- Death Drones are hiding on the seemingly empty flight deck
- Loot lockers each hold 2 WARP SHELL LOOT rolls
- Rax will hang back, guarding the reactors
- Reactors can be blown up, sabotaged, or hacked to overload. Let players be inventive!

4: SURVIVE?

Make a huge ending of this epic! Even if Krell is destroyed, do heroes escape? If the planet killer is destroyed, is the Imperium even fazed? What could be next, and how does this battle affect YOUR WARP SHELL world?



DEATH ON KRELL: BASICS

CHOOSE A DECK HAND

All deck hands are 10 point builds, NO EQUIPMENT. They will have to work together to escape the *Nemesis*, much less accomplish their mission! Players may use INT or DEX for their piloting roll.

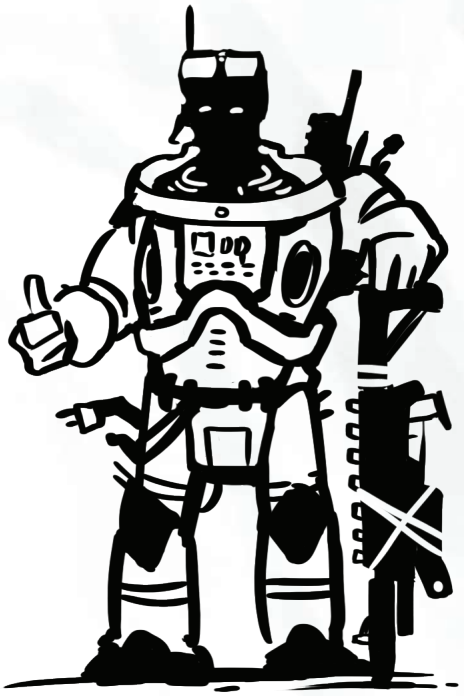
HANGAR CHIEF, LT.
- Commands flight deck personnel, coordinates fighter scrambles
- +2 CHA
- Advanced Sidearm (D8 Energy Weapon)

FIGHTER MECHANIC, CPL.
- Deck technician for repair and rebuild of damaged fighters
- Mechanical rolls are always EASY, Piloting rolls are always HARD

PILOT (RESERVE, SECOND BATTALLION), CPL.
- Standard fighter pilot, 1st class
- Piloting rolls are always EASY, +1 DEX

FUEL TECHNICIAN, PVT.
- Grungy deck hand, low rank, hard workin' son of a gun
- +3 CON, Roll 19 OR 20 when DYING to pop up

WEAPONS DECK TECHNICIAN, PVT.
- Arms, maintains, and reloads fighter weapons
- Does double EFFORT with all weaponry, personal or vehicular



<u>8 Details to Discover aboard the Nemesis or Krell fighters</u>

1: A high tech fire extinguisher, 4 charges, covers a FAR radius area in slippery suppressant foam
2: A wheeled toolbox, with everything needed to repair or modify a KR-4 fighter
3: A rack of 40 swarmer missiles, capped with safety plugs
4: A heap of wreckage, littered with scorched boots, broken helmets, and small fires
5: A malfunctioning console showing chaos on the bridge as the Imperium attacks
6: An ever-worsening rip in the outer hull, screaming with loss of atmosphere
7: A spare flight suit with helmet and air pack
8: A wound up steel cable and chuck wedges used to park or pull fighters on deck

<u>8 Details to Discover aboard the Imperium planet killer</u>

1: Storage lockers with WARP SHELL LOOT rolls
2: An acid scar that has partially melted the flight deck surface
3: A data console revealing 'the informant' within the Krell betrayed his own kind, causing the fleet massacre
4: A parked squadron of micro fighters
5: A control station used to fire deck autoguns at any incoming fighters
6: An Imperium battle suit. HARD to pilot, 4 CHUNKS, Treat as a miniature Imperator
7: An energy cage of Krell prisoners who have all been terminated
8: A console showing a massive countdown to the planet killer's main gun firing

DEATH ON KRELL: FIGHTERS

SPACE FIGHTERS AND CHUNKS

Like all VEHICLES, space fighters are built in CHUNKS. A Krell SF-4 fighter is built from four standard 10 HP CHUNKS common to many fighters, but you can design and build all kinds of war machines for space combat.

Chunk 1: Cockpit (Life support, canopy, instruments, and controls. Seats two. If destroyed, the fighter can no longer be operated. Pilots still in a destroyed cockpit have 1D4 ROUNDS before death)
Chunk 2: Ion Drive (Enables deep space/sector travel and maneuvers. If destroyed, fighter is crippled and can only taxi or limp at retro thruster speed)
Chunk 3: SR missile pack (Explodes when destroyed, destroys 1d8 micro fighters or inflicts D8 DAMAGE against CHUNKS, 8 bursts until empty)
Chunk 4: Chain Gun (Destroys 1D4 micro fighters or inflicts 1D6 Damage against CHUNKS, does not require reload. Optional: high output module, fire again on any roll of modified 13+)

SPACE FIGHTER MANEUVERS

All maneuvers require a PILOTING roll to execute. Failed rolls simply have no effect.

- **PUNCH IT** (Move to any adjacent SECTOR, take fire from enemies in current SECTOR)
- **ZERO** (Lock onto a single target and automatically follow them even if they PUNCH IT)
- **ENGAGE** (Fire a weapon! On a success, roll for CHUNK damage or quantity of micro fighters destroyed)
- **BREAK OFF** (Stay in the current SECTOR, but elude all enemies that TURN)
- **DITCH** (Eject! Make your roll to safely eject. On a failed roll, take WEAPON DAMAGE as you fly out)
- **FORM UP** (Track one or more allies wingtip to wingtip. Enemies in that SECTOR choose targets at random between you and all other allies. If you fail your FORM UP roll, inflict 1D4 CHUNK damage on 1 ally)

PILOTING AND CO-PILOTING

If two players are in a single fighter, that fighter can be maneuvered on BOTH their TURNS. Having a co-pilot makes a fighter twice as effective and far more tactical than a pilot-only craft, enabling strategies like having the pilot execute maneuvers while the co-pilot gathers intel or executes repairs.

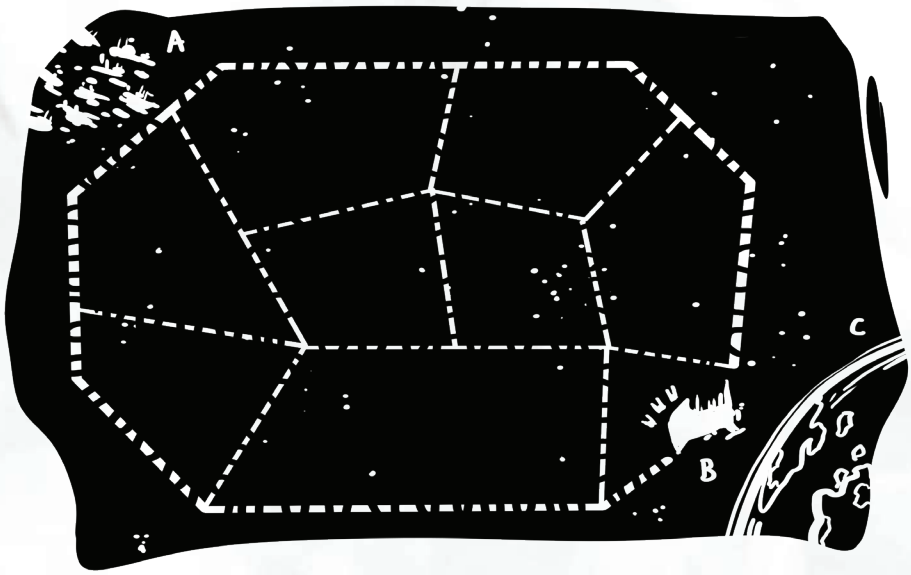
DEATH ON KRELL: DOGFIGHT

SECTORS OF SPACE

Distances in a space battle are huge. Exactly where a fighter is has little importance, but the SECTOR matters because all fighters in a shared SECTOR are potential targets. Thus, pilots should think in SECTOR travel, and elude, chase, or engage by that increment. Use a SECTOR MAP to run your space battles and the maneuvers above.

SQUADRONS VS. FIGHTERS

As the Imperium micro fighters close in, the heroes realize they need to make a focused effort to reach the planet killer ship in one piece. Generally, Krell fighters far outmatch Imperium micro fighters, which are disposable. Your role as GM here is to wear them down, destroy their fighters, and force them to board the planet killer in ragtag shape. Utilize the MANEUVERS to pick at them as they cross space. Use this SECTOR MAP or create your own.



A: KRELL FLEET (IN RUINS)

B: PLANET KILLER SHIP

C: KRELL HOMEWORLD

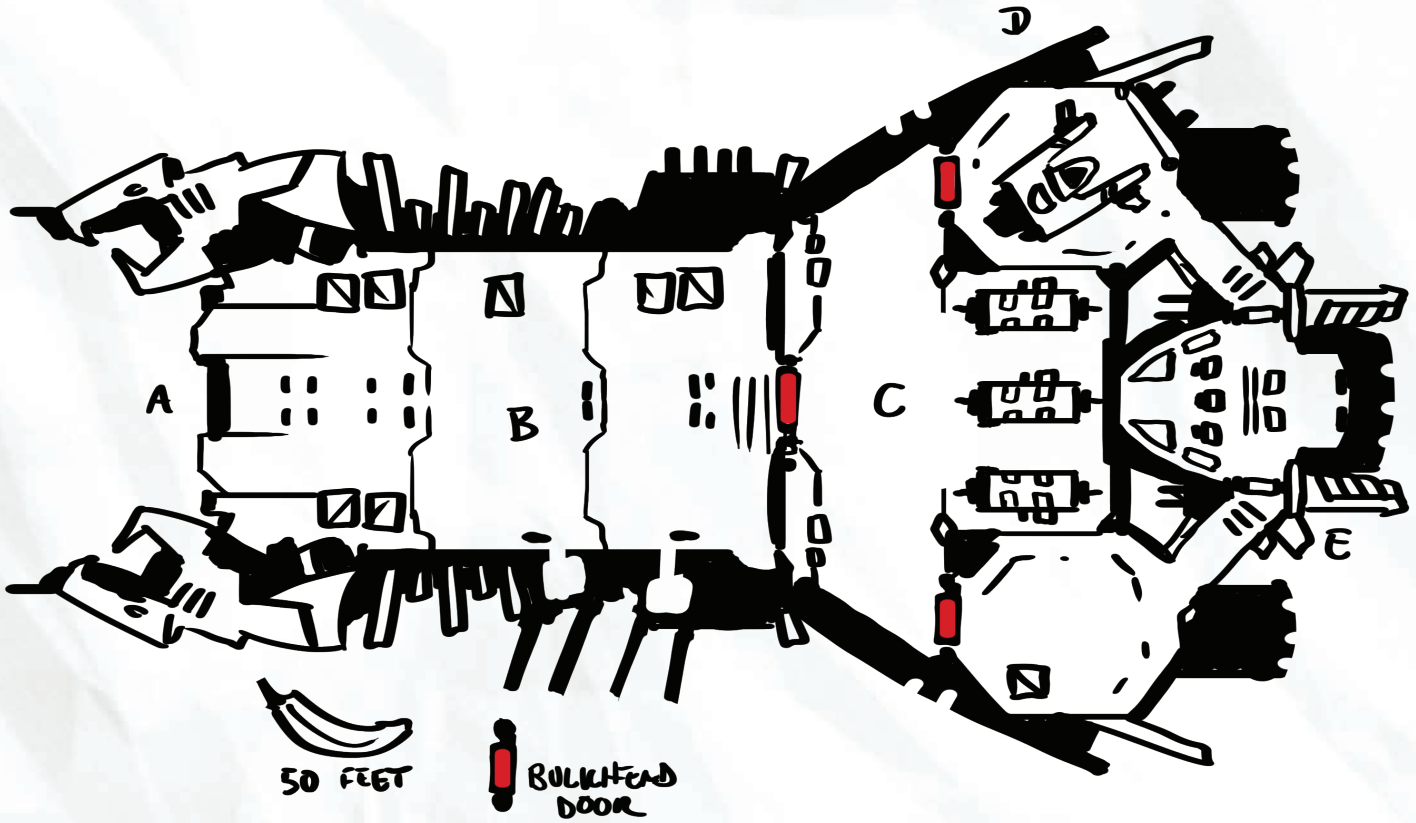
BOARDING THE PLANET KILLER

By whatever crazy means, the heroes must get aboard the planet killer alive and ready to fight. The giant ship does have a landing bay, but who knows what other wacky schemes your players may devise. Use defensive weapons and fighters to rob them of their more powerful weapons, so they must proceed inward on foot. Here comes the really dangerous part, and the clock is ticking.

DEATH ON KRELL: CONCLUSION

VAPORIZED!

Somehow, the heroes must find a way to destroy or disable the main reactors aboard this massive ship. They will be stalked by Death Drones, will face Sweeper packs, and finally, will be stopped by Imperator Rax himself. There is LOOT laying around, but shutting down this weapon is NO EASY TASK. Be up front with players that their chances are slim. They need to out-think this brutal scenario, and their chances of survival are even slimmer than victory. This is where heroes are made.



A: LAUNCH BAY ENTRY B: HANGAR DECK, SUPPLY LOCKERS
C: REACTOR ROOM D: ESCAPE POD E: BRIDGE

THE FATE OF KRELL

To keep the story going, use the outcome of this adventure to further push your Imperium storyline. If Krell is destroyed, move to a new chapter with that grim truth, and create new heroes to continue the struggle. If the heroes survive, they continue to lead the Krell in an all out war on the Imperium or discover a traitor in their midst! The possibilities are endless, especially when a rogue WARP SHELL materializes from subspace, the crew all dead. What evil forces are at work here?

THE MERCURY DALE

When a strange object collides with the towing freighter Mercury Dale, parked in high orbit in the argon clouds of Aster, all Hell breaks loose. Is survival enough?

OVERVIEW

DM'S BULLETS

The absolute, bare bones key facts to remember, understand and improvise all the astounding details of the adventure:

- A huge empty freighter is parked in a gas cloud
- A chunk of the HARBINGER, mixed with ship debris, arrives and collides
- The freighter secretly carries the MAINFRAME
- The fungus-infested crew of THE OBJECT must retrieve the MAINFRAME to save the multiverse
- The adventure can be played with players as either side, attacked or attackers

These raw bullets should ignite your curiosity, and spawn a thousand new questions. As we answer those questions, and let these two forces clash, the action unfolds.

MOMENTS

There are many ways this conflict can play out, and that lets players guide the action! No matter how, here are some key moments that can happen almost anywhere, anytime.

1: COLLISION

THE OBJECT slams into The Mercury Dale, rupturing the hull in Bay 6. The deformed monsters from THE OBJECT begin to flood in.

- The intruders are Xill Drones and Mykonoid Pirates, all ravaging the freighter seeking the MAINFRAME
- THE OBJECT is a tentacled, living mass of Xill stone mixed with ship debris

2: CONTACT

Regardless of what side the players choose, the opening engagement is a chaotic, messy battle in Bay 6. Neither side plans on dying.

- Begin to drop clues about who and what is going on here
- Hint at the details of the intruders, revealing the Mykonoid menace
- Kill a ton of NPC's

3: BOARDING MAYHEM

The intruders come from several angles, and their incessant ramming threatens to destroy The Mercury Dale.

- Spawn enemies or rupture hull cracks to keep players on the move
- Emphasize the ravenous, chaotic searching behavior of the invaders, and the panicked terror of the Mercury crew.

4: MAINFRAME

This small cubic computer is hidden somewhere on The Mercury Dale. It is VERY heavy, requiring a STR roll by anyone attemtping to move it, except in zero gravity.

- Randomly roll its position
- Choose a hidden, devious position
- Allude to the captain's knowledge of this event

5: FIREFIGHT

At some point, the players, on either side, will need to overwhelm the enemy forces. Give them clues as to fortified locatoens where this could occur, or force it with a timer.

- Remember to shatter The Mercury Dale over time
- Invaders break out swarms of Drones
- The Myknoid infection takes hold

6: BREECH

Past the halfway point of the adventure, The Mercury Dale will begin to break up. Detroy the map.

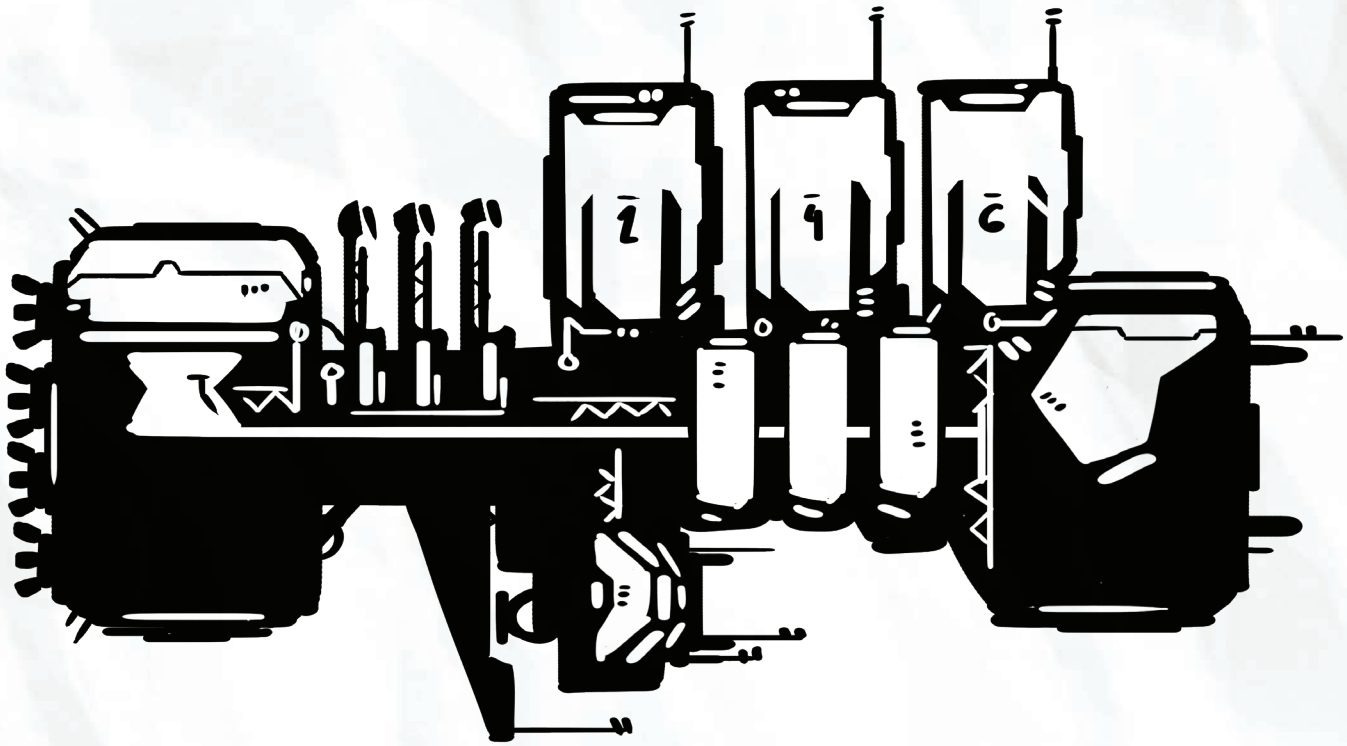
- THE OBJECT is intact
- Take note of the ESCAPE PODS
- Vacuum is deadly

7: CHARLIE

The captain of the invading crew is Charlie, a hurdy-gurdy player from Alfheim in an alternate timeline. He is a Mykonoid skeleton, sadistic, patient, and hell bent on taking the MAINFRAME at any cost

- Is Charlie good or evil?
- He needs the MAINFRAME to save the cosmos from THE DEVOURER. Does it matter?
- Kill Charlie to break their will... or does it?

THE MERCURY DALE



DEVIL IN THE DETAILS

As players begin to explore, they're bound to be curious. Here are 20 details that can be found with a closer look. ROLL or CHOOSE on successful investigations.

1: Stress cracks and hull ruptures are appearing throughout the Mercury, some catastrophic
2: A crew terminal, flashing messages about system outtages and required use of at-location controls
3: A shard of greenish stone broken off from THE OBJECT. It is a shifting, living stone similar to Xill armor
4: Chunks of fungal material, like dessicated mushroom or mold, but pulsating
5: A length of barbed anchor cable from THE OBJECT. The barbs are razor sharp
6: A cracked human skull, identity unknown. A mysterious fungal growth has begun to break the bones apart
7: A crewman of the Mercury Dale, deceased in a locker room. He has ended his own life
8: Captain's data pad. It indicates a top secret cargo, taken on Aster 6, called 'The Mainframe'
9: A secured comm terminal left open. Last messages are between crew and Bation, keyword: Harbinger
10: A pile of photo print outs showing THE OBJECT at extreme range with tyllemtry data
11: A pile of mining saws, concrete breakers, and arc-rivet tools
12: Duranium strong box, unlocked, contains 3 SCI FI LOOT rolls
13: Power Cell. Can be used on any tech to DOUBLE its conventional effect 1D6 times before spent
14: Power grappler tool. Can shoot to and pull vehicle sized objects up to FAR range
15: A lab-coated crewman, deceased and torn to pieces. In his pocket is a tiny vile of pulsating fungus
16: A lab manifest data pad with full data on 'The MYKONOID Phenomenon' (see p. 13)
17: Ship's main comm dish. It has been disconnected, partially destroyed, and discarded here
18: A bloody VAC SUIT. It is still functional, but holds a hidden MYKONOID colony seeking a host
19: A set of dog tags, Imperium issue. Codename: Mole2. On the chain is also a fragment of THE OBJECT
20: A secured locker, left open. Inside is a suit of IMPERIUM POWER ARMOR

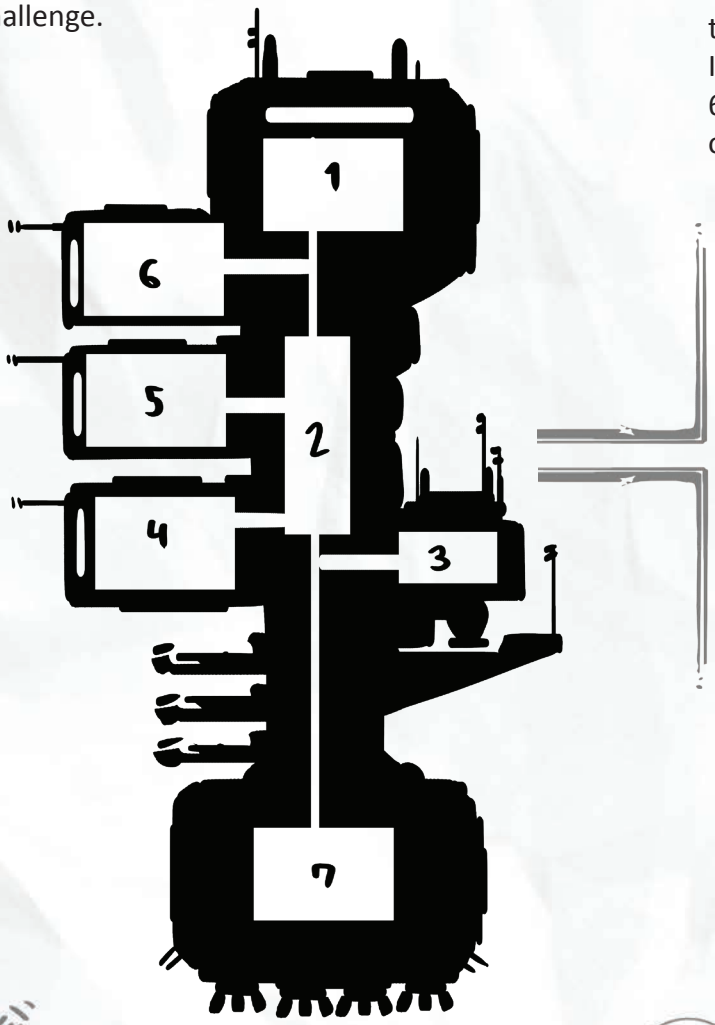
THE MERCURY DALE

CREATING THE TABLE

To build your versions of The Mercury Dale and THE OBJECT, start with a base of black felt or black cardboard roughly in the shape shown below. This gives the players a lay of the land, but the details are all in shadow. As they enter spaces and move about, add INDEX CARDS, terrain sets, or shape-cut printout rooms for each section.

Once explored you should have something like the map here. Don't get too hung up on the details, and keep things moving. Make sure you have a good command of the setting so you can handle unforeseen questions and situations with ease and speed!

Destroy your terrain! As the adventure unfolds, rip or cut your ships into pieces, and let them slowly spread into deep space. Getting around in the chaos is half the challenge.



THE MAINFRAME'S WILL

What is the MAINFRAME anyway? That's up to you! This small cubic machine transcends time and space, and seems to bend reality and alter mortal minds. If your adventure needs an adrenaline shot, have the MAINFRAME accelerate timers, cause destruction, or bend the laws of physics.

PACE AND RHYTHM

Plan a 4 hour session for the adventure. To speed things along, reduce NPC's to 1 or 2 HP, accelerate the breakup of The Mercury, or set the engine core on a world timer like a giant bomb. Another way to insure you can reach an ending in the time allowed is be sure your intro sequence is FAST. Describe the setup, then BOOM, THE OBJECT collides and things go haywire.

In the craziest circumstance, be ready for the crew and the invaders to negotiate a cooperative arrangement. If they work togethet to take the MAINFRAME to Aster 6, use THE OBJECT as a rampaging, sentient entity bent on death. The damn thing is like an evil WARP SHELL!

1: CARGO PRIMARY
- Massive cargo chamber
- Hangar doors

2: MAIN CORRIDOR
- Long, narrow catwalk
- Girders, trusses and power lines

3: BRIDGE
- Computer banks and observation deck
- Captain's desk

4: BAY 4
- Fuel, chemicals and other hazmats
- Tow carts

5: BAY 5
- Vehicles, parts and tow equipment
- Light damage

6: BAY 6
- Empty cargo area
- Heavily damaged

7: ENGINEERING
- Reactor core and thruster access
- Secondary bridge con center

THE OBJECT

STRANGE AND SINISTER

The HARBINGER is a mysterious Xill creation, and home to ten thousand horrors. This chunk has seen too many corners of deep space, and become melded with the legendary ship HELEN'S REVENGE and a star freighter called the ISS TIGER. Here are 20 details to be found on its surface and inside its confusing inner chambers.

1: A length of writhing, whipping grapple cable. It is barbed with razor-sharp spines and seems to be alive
2: A bio-conductive control terminal being operated by a disembodied Xill hand
3: A hovering medical module, dutifully seeking biological lifeforms to assist
4: A doorway suddenly appears in a seamless wall surface, shortcutting normal layout to a random chamber
5: A pile of Xill Drone body parts, being neatly stacked by a crane-like structure
6: A set of XILL ADAPTIVE ARMOR hanging in a bio-sync tank
7: A rack of PULSE RIFLES. They are adaptive, occupying no inventory space when equipped or carried
8: A laboratory table. ABove it, a Torton has been dissected, pinned and sectioned. Terminals nearby scan it
9: Large screens in a bank all show data on locating and ramming The Mercury Dale
10: A set of spherical data units showing plans to contain and harvest a DARK STAR
11: 1D6 small tablets of living stone, each with a strange glyph in green luminesence. Each contains a SPELL
12: A tiny implant, inserted in the ear. Instantly teaches the Xill language
13: A data pad describing the SPELL CREATE DEVICE. Those who learn it no longer need HEARTS for this SPELL
14: A bizarre, brain-like container. Within are 2 EPIC LOOT rolls
15: A pair of headphone-like objects. Donning them enables complete control of THE OBJECT
16: A sliced-off segment of WARP SHELL biomatter in a suspension vat
17: A modified Chemrail weapon. This exoskeletal version never needs reload
18: A Xill maintenance suit. This exoskeleton serves as any form of TOOLS you choose
19: A smear of fungal matter, pulsating. Roll 1D6. On a 1-3, the matter leaps out at the nearest living thing
20: A hull fracture that is slowly getting worse

THE OBJECT

CREATING THE TABLE

Use your proven method to build this 'ship' with black cardboard and place rooms or index cards as needed. It is basically a improvised vessel that has traversed the cosmos, partially on accident, in a desperate search for the MAINFRAME. By means unknown, Mr. Tate and Charlie have discovered the MAINFRAME has the data to un-make THE DEVOURER, but in their trvels they have acquired a ravenous infection of Mykonoid bio matter. This matter is not inhernetly evil, but when merged with Xill, Xill Drones, or murderous pirates, the resulting organisms are hideously homicidal.

Combine this with an unstable vessel, and times are indeed desperate.

ABSORBED IN WARP

As THE OBJECT has jumped across time and space, it has merged or melded with two other ships: the Helen's Revenge and the ISS Tiger. Helen's Revenge is a pirate galleon from Alfheim, and the Tiger is an Imperium space cruiser. Use this detail to flavor your OBJECT in ways that allude to the sinister mystery at play here.

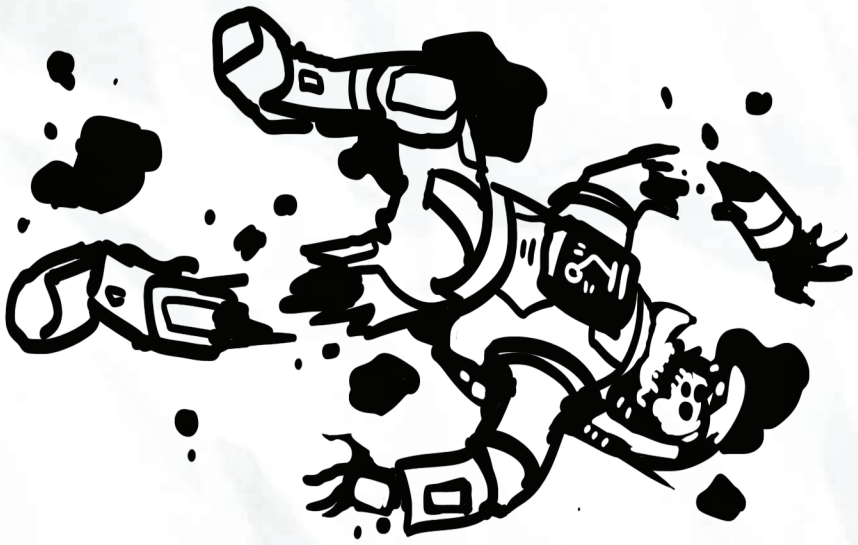
Players react to such details in VERY unpredictable ways, so be ready for some erratic behavior or sudden moral swings. The situation gets complex when players aren't sure what they're dealing with. And then there's the damn Mykonoid matter to consider...

Space. Never a dull moment.

BUILD YOUR OBJECT WITH 6 RANDOM INDEX CARDS FROM ICRPG VOLUMES

FREELY SHIFT CORRIDORS, OPENINGS, AND ROOM SHAPES WITH EACH TIMER

MECHANICS



TO THE DEATH

No matter what side the players may be on, be vivid with your descriptions to enforce the unavoidable, deadly conflict between the Mercury's crew and the invaders. The beings aboard THE OBJECT have been to hell and back for this chance to get the MAINFRAME, and cannot afford mercy. The crew simply fights to survive. Use MECHANICS to drive this conflict home.

1: Hull Breech: When a GM timer runs out, roll a 50/50 chance of a catastrophic hull rip
2: Another Ram: THE OBJECT slams into The Mercury again. Roll DEX or fall prone, losing your next MOVE
3: Power Loss: The Mercury is losing power! For any action using ship's power, there is a 1 in 4 chance it works
4: Grapple Cables: THE OBJECT lashes at The Mercury. On a GM timer, another cable comes ripping through
5: Bridge Systems Down: The Mercury can only be controlled or altered via stations AT LOCATION
6: They Just Keep Coming: EVERY ROUND spawn 1D8 Xill Drones or Mykonoid Pirates in Bay 6
7: Breakup: On a 12 ROUND WORLD TIMER, pieces of The Mercury float apart FAR
8: Vacuum: Catastrophic hull cracks cause vacuum pull. Roll STR or be pinned to the leak
9: Mykonoid Biomatter: When CLOSE to such matter, roll DEX or be infected. Become a Mykonoid in 1D4 ROUNDS
10: Argon Cloud: Fire and combustion in general does not burn here once the argon enters The Mercury Dale

LOOT

Keep 1 LOOT in each chamber (7 total). Mix these between SHABBY and SCI FI tables. Use lockers, strong boxes, or gear racks to explain it all. Be generous. If your MECHANICS are deadly enough, they'll need it.

XILL DRONE

ROLLS: +4 STATS, +2 EFFORT

ACTIONS (2 PER TURN)

LASH: Drones swipe and slash with barbed whips and sharp leg appendages. Weapon attack

LASER SPREAD: The luminous eyes of these things emit a 180 degree spread of slicing lasers. All targets in that area, up to FAR range, must roll DEX or take MAGICAL DAMAGE

FACE EATER: As a CLOSE attack, the Drone uses its face tentacles to attach to and devour an enemy's face and head. A STR roll pulls free, otherwise take ULTIMATE damage and be paralyzed for 1 ROUND

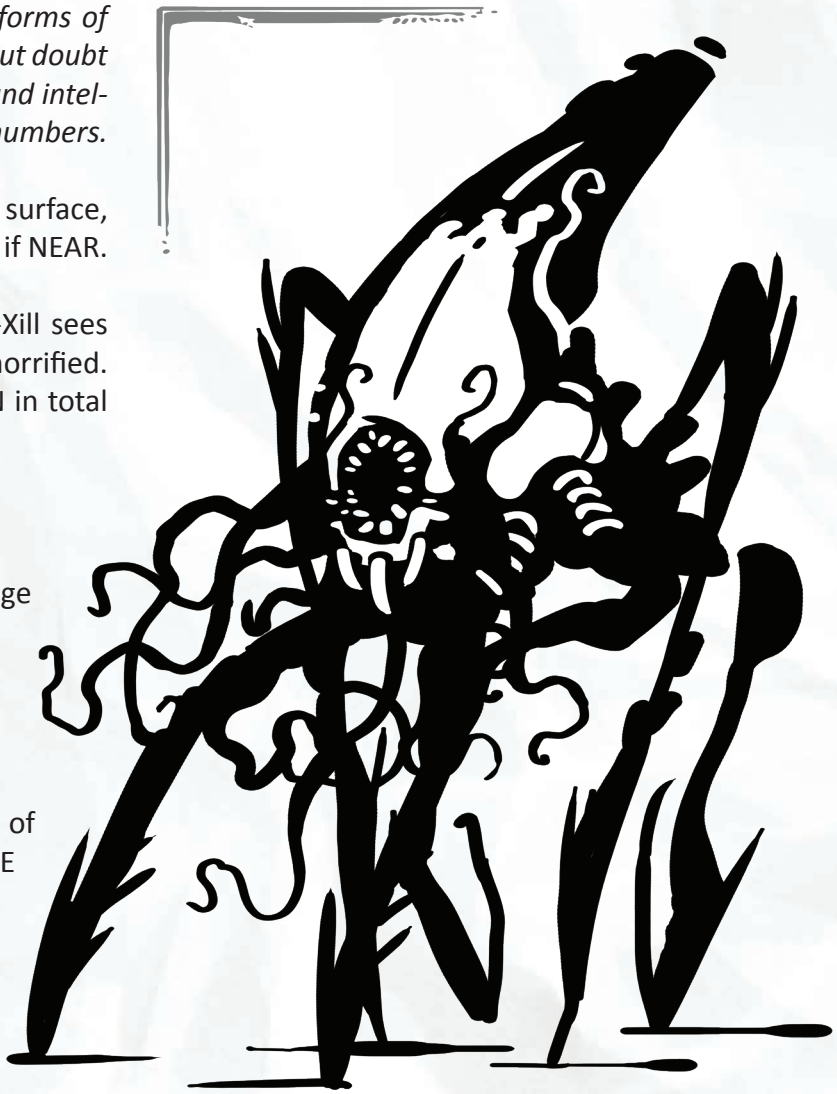
Grown in Xill bioforges to defend the higher forms of that race, the Drones are devoted killers, without doubt or remorse. Though simple, they are devious and intelligent, making them formidable even in small numbers.

FAST AND STICKY: Xill Drones can walk on any surface, with or without gravity, and they move FAR as if NEAR.

TERRIFYING: The first moment that any non-Xill sees a Xill Drone, they must roll CHA or be utterly horrified. This effect causes a paralysis, wasting 1 TURN in total fright.

TECH INTELLIGENT: Xill Drones can operate terminals, keyboards, switches, levers and computer systems in general. They can sabotage machinery, booby trap doors or airlocks, and cut power lines. They execute these types of actions any time a GM timer runs out, whether that timer is about them or not.

MUTANT: In every other group of Drones, one of them is a mutant. Use the MONSTER UPGRADE table in the **ICRPG** CORE (2E p. 195).



MYKONOID PIRATE

ROLLS: +2 ALL STATS

ACTIONS

PIN DOWN: The degenrated bones and fungal matter are driven to immobilize enemies with sheer body weight. A STR roll can push them off, otherwise their victim can take no actions

FLAILING ATTACK: The creature, baffled by its tormented state, attacks randomly with whatever weapon its host possesses, from swords to blast pistols

FUNGUS TENDRIL: One limb, usually an arm or tongue, distends to FAR range, lashing up to three targets with WEAPON DAMAGE. If this attack is a critical success, the target is infected with Mykonoid biomatter

SPORE CLOUD: A burst of microscopic spores clouds the air wth yellow. Those NEAR make a CON roll or become infected, also absorbing WEAPON damage from the posionous agent

The former crew of the Helen's Revenge or ISS Tiger have been infested and overtaken with Mykonoid biomatter. They are driven by whatever final impulse that humanoid had, but usually it is a desire to spread the spores and biomatter that infected them.

TORMENTED: When rolling a 1 on any roll, a Mykonoid Pirate wastes its turn thrashing and scratching at its own body in agony.

STILL HUMAN: Once the fungal infection is complete, these creatures stabilize and can think with complex reason, personality, goals and team work. They are not beasts.

POOR SENSES: All Mykonoids have limited vision and hearing, rolling HARD on scouting or investigation. This makes it EASY to hide from them. Their sense of smell, however, is undiminished.

NUMBERS: Mykonoids of all types prefer to move in tight groups. They will not break apart from their group if they can help it, and they follow cues to attack in a group, or move in the same way.

MYKONOIDS

A RESILIENT ORGANISM

Mykonoids inhabit any sentient being, and completely take over, REPLACING the original sentience in 1D4 HOURS. They inherit the basic STATS of the host, adding their own below. Theirs is a strange, shared intellingence, and little is known of their origin or intention as a species, beyond an urge to spread across the universe

They are a hearty race, able to quickly heal minor wounds, stave off infections and resist toxins. CON +1

All Mykonoids can regrow limbs and injuries. If at 1 HP or higher, they have a 50% chance of regenrating 1 HP each TURN.

These creatures have a way of finding weak points, gaps, and tiny seams in enemy armor and machinery when they enter combat. ULTIMATE +2

STRETCHY AND RUBBERY: Mykonoid flesh is an odd, stretchy mixture of flesh and fungus. They can extend limbs to NEAR range rather than CLOSE.

WATER HEALERS: Any water source can serve as a healing nurishment for Mykonoids. If they spend a TURN absorbing water, they heal 1D6 HP.

SYMBIOSIS

Here is a 1D8 list of things that motivate Mykonoids in their travels through the cosmos.

1: Spreader: This creature seeks, mainly, to spread Mykonoid spores everywhere. It can perform other functions, but only in a devious ruse to do this.

2: Knower: These Mykonoids gather data for their kind. Once per day they enter a trance state, transmitting all they know to the common mind.

3: Defender: If threatened by other species, the Mynoids send these warriors to end it. They choose a single enemy type and kill relentlessly.

5: Assimilator: When ancient or extreme tech is discovered, Mykonoid Assimilators arrive to study and steal it for their kind, returning it to a fungus homeworld if possible.

6: Envoy: Some fungus beings seek to make peace with other species.

7: Lure: In a truly sinister lie, this Mykonoid makes friends or allies, then lures them to a fungus homeworld to be infected, usually as part of some wider agenda.

8: Seeker: When the common mind of Mykonoids has need of a piece of tech, individual, ship, or even planet, they send these formidable agents to see it done.

CONCLUSION

IS SURVIVAL ENOUGH?

If the crew of The Mercury Dale can defend themselves against the intruders, and survive the breakup of their ship somehow, ask two questions:

1: Where is the MAINFRAME? Without this indestructible little machine, the universe has no hope of stopping THE DEVOURER. IS it floating through space? Lost in wreckage? Do they even care?

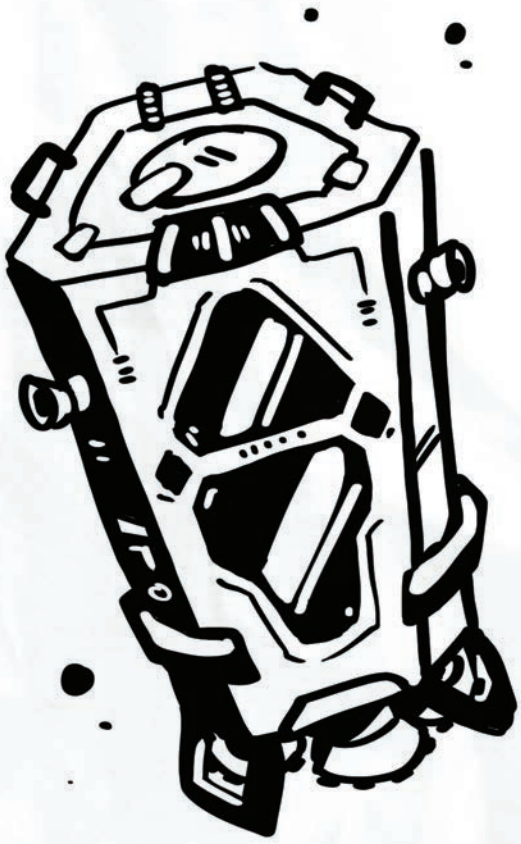
2: What next? With the MAINFRAME in their possession, what will the survivors do now? Sell it to the highest bidder? Follow its clues to THE DEVOURER? Deliver it to the Imperium? To Krell?

CHARLIE'S CREW

Charlie, once 1st Mate on the Helen's Revenge, has taken command of THE OBJECT. If he and his motley crew acquire the MAINFRAME, they will use it to get coordinates and pursue THE DEVOURER in its nascent form, in the distant past. They could also rally Mykonoid allies on a fungus homeworld, or limp their way to a superior starship before proceeding.

They could even take a HARBINGER class ship as their own, or dare to command the Xill fleet itself!

Maybe the MAINFRAME simply melts their minds for its own devious reasons...



BLACKBIRD

A gigantic flying machine darkens the sky.
This will be the final battleground.
Don't look down.

OVERVIEW

ROOM INTRO

The true power of a supreme villain is revealed when a gigantic airship appears from a rumbling storm cloud. It is the BLACKBIRD, a colossal, winged galleon in the sky. The dwarves can only launch our heroes AT the massive thing, using a catapult of sorts, hoping to land them on a wing for the final confrontation.

ESSENTIALS

You almost slide off the huge metal and wood-planked wing as you land, scratching and clawing to gain your feet. The YOG colliders thunder behind you, the wind screams, and from the whipping mist a mechanical nightmare appears. Its coal-eyes glow. It means to end you all. No one boards the BLACKBIRD.

TIMERS: The danger level here is hard to overstate. It is a very, very long way down.

- Gusts of wind blast the wing, scraping away the heroes to a long fall
- The BLACKBIRD rolls side to side, piling all combatants on opposite sides of the battlefield
- Afterburners suck anything NEAR into fiery oblivion

THREATS: The CUSTODIAN that our supreme villain has employed is specially built to defend the airship

- A huge mechanical boss
- Alternating immunities based on hero attacks
- Swarms of drones keep heroes busy

TREATS: The danger of this area can also be its advantage, but at great risk

- Shove enemies off the wing or into the colliders
- Wing plates can be peeled up as shields or anchors

MECHANICAL

1: THE LONG FALL

- If a character or creature falls off, they can roll DEX. A success gets them 'hanging by a finger.' In this state, they are stable, but cannot climb up without help from an ally.
- Failed rolls when falling off lead to a complete fall. Treat this as a DYING timer. When that timer is up, they have fallen too far to rescue, and die on impact.

2: YOG COLLIDER

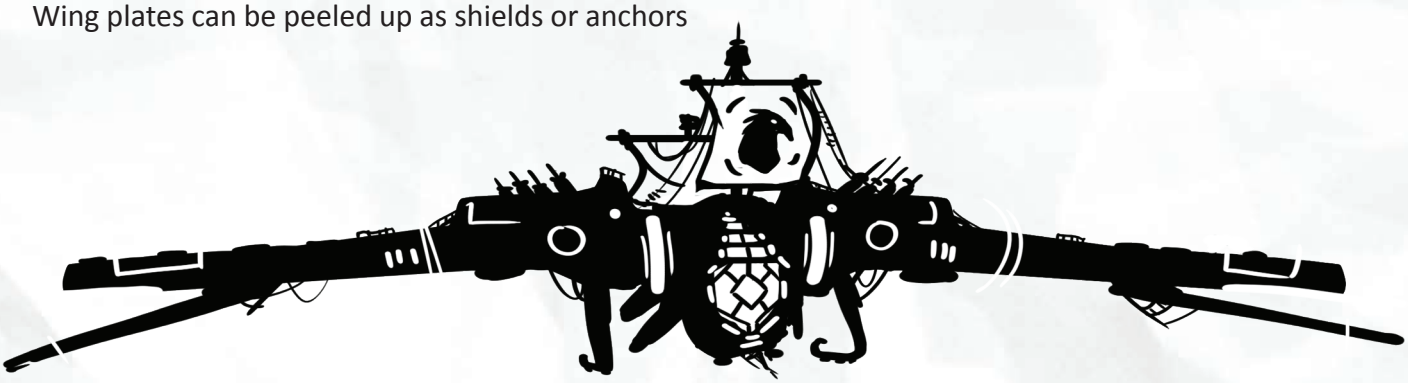
- Every TIMER, the engines fire on afterburn. They pul at EVERYTHING on the wing. Unless somehow anchored, roll STR or be pulled in. This reduces a creature to 0 HP instantly, and ejects them into thin air for a fall.

3: METAL SALVAGE

- Plates of metal are peeling up here and there on the wing, and can serve as improvised terrain, anchor points or even line-of-sight shields for resourceful players who notice.

3: DEMON MACHINE

- This jet-powered CUSTODIAN (see below) has one function: to kill or remove intruders.
- If the DEMON MACHINE is defeated, heroes may enter the crew cabin of the BLACKBIRD to confront their supreme villain, or a high ranking minion
- Be sure to note safegaurds against 'control machine' dominate machine' and the like, and demonstrate to players how this monster fights using flight



LOOSE PANELS
DEMON MACHINE DEPLOY HATCH
YOG COLLIDER
ACCESS HATCH
16+

THE DEMON MACHINE

ROLLS: +8 STR, +4 ALL OTHERS

ACTIONS (3 PER TURN)

DRILL CLAW: A whirling steel auger on an articulated arm. Always does ULTIMATE. IF a target takes 10 or more damage, they are pinned to the wing surface and cannot move until making a STR roll

PULSE WAVE: A sonic blast of energy from steam powered horns. All enemies within FAR roll STR on are pushed away FAR distance

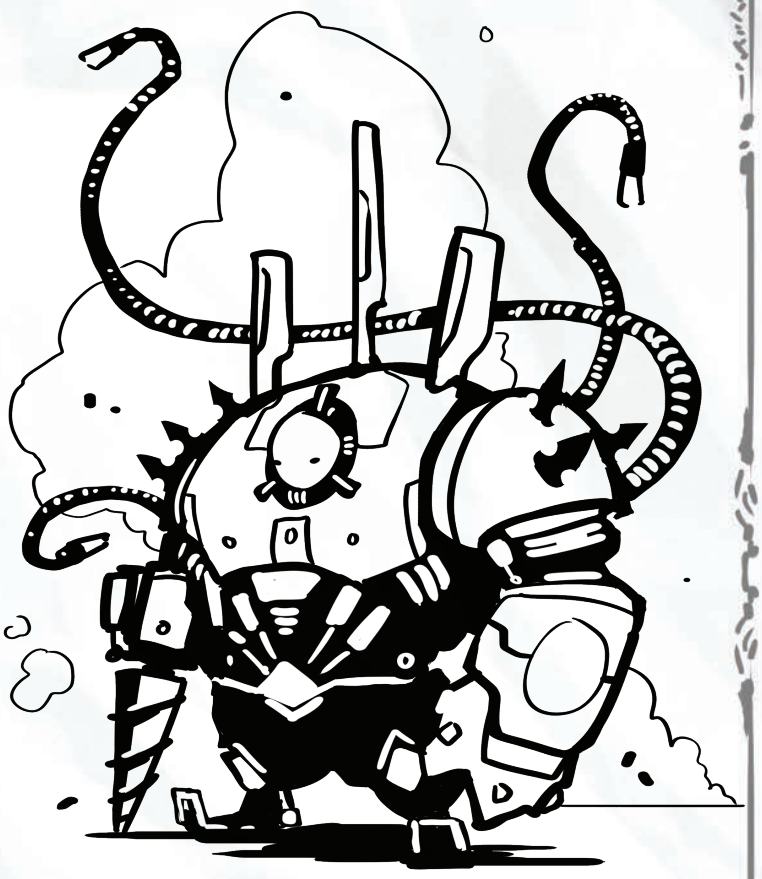
GRENADE CANNON: An explosive missile that does ULTIMATE to its target and any CLOSE to that target

COILERS: The machine sprouts a tangle of metal whips, each with a sharp pincher. This is one melee attack roll, but attacks all enemies within FAR

STORM OF DARTS: A stream of tiny steel darts shreds a single target. Damage done with this weapon also degrades armor by the same amount

SHIELD REPAIR: The machine spends a ROUND dormant, taking this as its 3rd action. With a massive shield around itself, it is immune to all forms of damage, and recovers 1D12 HP

COUNTERATTACK: If the machine is attacked with any melee WEAPON or attack, it instantly responds with an automated blade weapon for D6 damage, no roll



A massive construct of clockwork and armor plates, powered by a coal forge engine and magical glyphs. The machine is autonomous, but can also be controlled at the bridge of THE BLACKBIRD if needed.

SWEEPER PROTOCOL: The Demon Machine's primary directive is to 'sweep' or remove intruders or debris from the wing surface. With this in mind, run the monster in its most dangerous way: not trying to kill heroes but simply toss, blast or push them off to a long, deadly fall.

PARTS BONANZA: If defeated, the Demon Machine can be stripped for some wondrous parts. It contains 3 sci fi LOOT rolls, enough duranium to craft two suits of armor, and its attacks can be salvaged as CHUNKS for another vehicle.

HARD TO KILL: This machine is immune to any damage from fire, and any common metal weapons used against it do half their normal damage. Lightning or electrical attacks do double damage, as they interfere with its inner controls.

WHAT NEXT?

THE CRASH

If the heroes can survive or triumph on the wing, a series of hatches allows entry to the main cabin. This huge, windowed space could serve as a spectacular battle ground, perhaps destroying the controls and leading to a cataclysmic crash.

THE STEAL

Another great outcome players could pursue would be to take BLACKBIR for their own. This would unlock a an entirely new landscape of adventure and responsibility for the heroes. There may even be royal repercussions as Kings and Emperors demand the ship be placed in government hands.

A NEW WEAPON

The BLACKBIRD is not only a mighty acquisition for world travel, but its weapons systems are formidable, including cannons, battle armor, clockwork tanks and whatever conoctions the GM throws in. This makes it a potent threat to kingdoms, dragons, or extra-planetary threats. Will the heroes use the weapon? Destroy it? Hide it?

THE DOUBLE CROSS

A final move to keep the story arc going could be use an NPC 'on the inside' who steals or sabotages the BLACKBIRD at a critical moment. This will especially sting players who have claimed the ship as their own, and they will stop at nothing to repair/re-acquire it and avenge the traitor.

THE HECKOON CARAPACE

Every 400 years, one of them awakens.
Its long, ponderous journey to the sea is doom for all.
We are the foolish few who hope to stop it.

OVERVIEW

DM'S BULLETS

The absolute, bare bones key facts to remember, understand and improvise all the astounding details of the adventure:

- A gigantic crustacean-like creature has awakened in the moments, and is heading slowly to the sea
- The creature has an entire 'dungeon' in its interior
- Many towns and villages will be flattened
- A cult worships and nurtures these creatures, and will do anything to protect it
- An evil wizard has overtaken the creature, in part, and is using it as a war machine
- The heroes are sent to investigate and, if possible, stop this thing from destroying half the realm

These raw bullets should ignite your curiosity, and spawn a thousand new questions. As we answer those questions, and let these two forces clash, the action unfolds.

MOMENTS

No matter how long or detailed your carapace game, the following elements are what makes it unique. Scramble, discard, or explode any given piece to make it YOURS!

1: THE OMINOUS INVESTIGATION

The heroes are sent to investigate a town of corpses, a swath of destruction, and vanished royal envoys.

- The devastation is far greater than imagined
- Parasitic symbiotes are combing the ruins and rubble for food

2: REALIZATION

When the party reaches its destination, a royal embassy or enclave in a leveled town, they find only death. One dying diplomat describes the horror.

- The diplomat is Karris, a high born half elf, back broken, who describes a scene from nightmare
- The symbiotes continue to press the action, but they are less active at night
- Karris describes hooded men who preceded the attack. They announced the creature's coming, and said it won't stop until it reaches the sea

3: TO SEE IT IS TO DIE

Just after the encounter with Karris, the heroes spot the creature on the horizon, moving slowly in a cloud of dust, smoke and debris.

- The carapace moves 10 miles per day, with at least a dozen towns and villages in its path
- When heroes are anywhere within 10 miles of it, The Heckoon Dawn attack in full force
- In the time it takes to pursue or plan, the heroes witness an entire town destroyed and devoured, then swarm with symbiotes

4: DETAILS, DILEMMA, AND DEATH

The death toll mounting, the heroes must act. A group of defeated knights adds gravity, but how can it be stopped? Can it be reasoned with?

- It must be stopped, but is it evil?
- Closer investigation reveals the carapace is being used, even controlled, by an evil wizard called Specter
- The Heckoon Dawn reveal more powerful agents

6: ON BOARD

No matter their plan, the heroes will need to get on the carapace to affect it. It is a huge, hollow, dungeon like structure (naturally).

- Interior chambers house organs, cultists, symbiotes, and treasure from consumed victims
- The final chambers are the brain room and the weapons platform
- A magical goo system enables Specter's control
- Specter's master plan of world control is revealed

7: DUBIOUS VICTORS

Whatever players do, the ending can open up lots of new world changes and story hooks.

- If they kill it, the Heckoon Dawn will ravage the countryside
- If it reaches the sea, it will escape and potentially attack again soon, in any coastal area
- If they befriend or control it, the kings of opposing nations will vow to destroy them
- Is there a way to come out victorious?

A TITAN AWAKENS

SIGNS OF THE DEEPER TRUTH

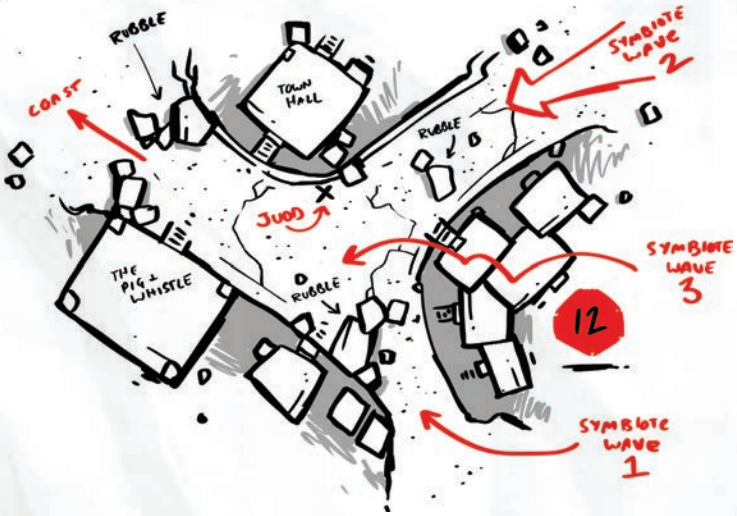
As players begin to explore, they're bound to be curious. Here are 20 details that can be found with a closer look. ROLL or CHOOSE on successful investigations.

1: A flattened house is pancaked at the bottom of a gigantic footprint. A child's arm is crushed under a stone
2: A torn piece of dark green cloth is found, featuring embroidery like ripples in sand
3: A broken spike of barbed crab shell, or chitin, lies in a huge scrape on the land. It is greenish, hard as iron
4: Debris and possessions are strewn in a long line where a family's cart was dragged and destroyed
5: A dying knight of Nordheim lays mostly crushed in his flattened armor, mumbling in terrified shock
6: Huge rivers of gore flow from a crushed stable, where no less than a hundred horses have been killed
7: A small village smolders with dying flames. Among the smoke, a shocked boy wanders
8: A doll filled with pins is found. It is a weird, bulbous shape with a dozen legs
9: A huge piece of carapace lies skewered by an iron spear. The spear is bent to ruin
10: A group of bodies is found, peppered with strange arrows made from a coral substance
11: The ground is broken by fissures and sinkholes. Some huge hollow has been vacated far below
12: A wafting smell of seawater and warm fish meat drifts on the wind
13: A dead symbiote is found, belly up, dead in the sun. It has been gutted and mostly eaten
14: A lone survivor runs terrified through the woods, babbling about the end of the world
15: A shattered trebuchet lay in wreckage outside a small village
16: Gigantic arbalest bolts, each 12 feet long, are stuck in the landscape in a wide pattern
17: A strange mace made of crab shell or tusk is found. It is a ragged, huge weapon
18: A massive flock of gulls is seen at altitude, flying inland, against the wind
19: A leather pouch of scrolls contains drawings and writing about the awakening, but are hard to decipher
20: A leather cord holds a strange insectoid gland or organ... it gives off a potent and alien smell

A TITAN AWAKENS

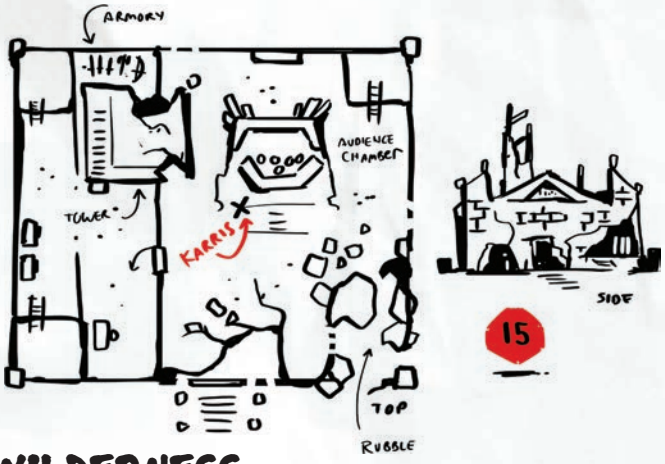
THE FLATTENED VILLAGE

Place Wurtstown anywhere in your game world, but it is the largest town destroyed, and home to the embassy where Karris can be found. One key encounter in all this can be Wurtstown or any destroyed village, where a swarm of SYMBIOTES attack.



THE EMBASSY RUIN

Cultists or SYMBIOTES will be pursuing and harassing heroes continuously. Use the embassy ruin as a stronghold or defensive fight. Once heroes are there, hit them hard with enemies.



WILDERNESS

Whether in pursuit of the carapace, seeking clues, or hiding, heroes can find Ulswitch in the forest, and learn much more about the dilemma presented by the giant monster. Just as the revelations unfold, the Heckoon Dawn wage a brutal surprise attack.

OLD JUDD

Judd is an elderly man from a destroyed village near the foothills.

"It emerged from the Green Mountains. It ate horses and splintered trees. It cannot be stopped."
"Every twenty generations one of these things appears. It must be some great and terrible cycle..."

KARRIS THE DIPLOMAT

Karris was once a high-ranking member of the elven Nordheim elite, but recent years have demanded his attention here on the frontier. Now he lay, crippled with a broken back, in the rubble of Wurtstown.

"It... it just walked through us all, eating and whipping and crushing... Gods, what a monster."
"As it approached, we could see a tiny human figure atop the colossus. They were just hovering there, above it all."
"The world will fall! There is no stopping such titanic evil! Flee for your lives!"

LADY HELENA

Helena's company have been killed by the carapace. She is a plate-armored knight of Shipshelm.

"I will see the creature killed at any cost. If only I could get inside its ugly head."
"Rumor tells of a dark wizard behind this. I'll have his head or die trying."

THE DRUID ULSWITCH

A female small folk has been watching the situation unfold from the forests. She believes the Heckoon should live, and bring the world back into balance.

"That which nature creates in seclusion can never be evil. The carapace must not be destroyed."
"It is Specter who is our enemy, but the carapace and the wizard are linked somehow. It is beyond my magic."
"If you choose to harm the carapace, I'll have no choice but to call you my enemies."

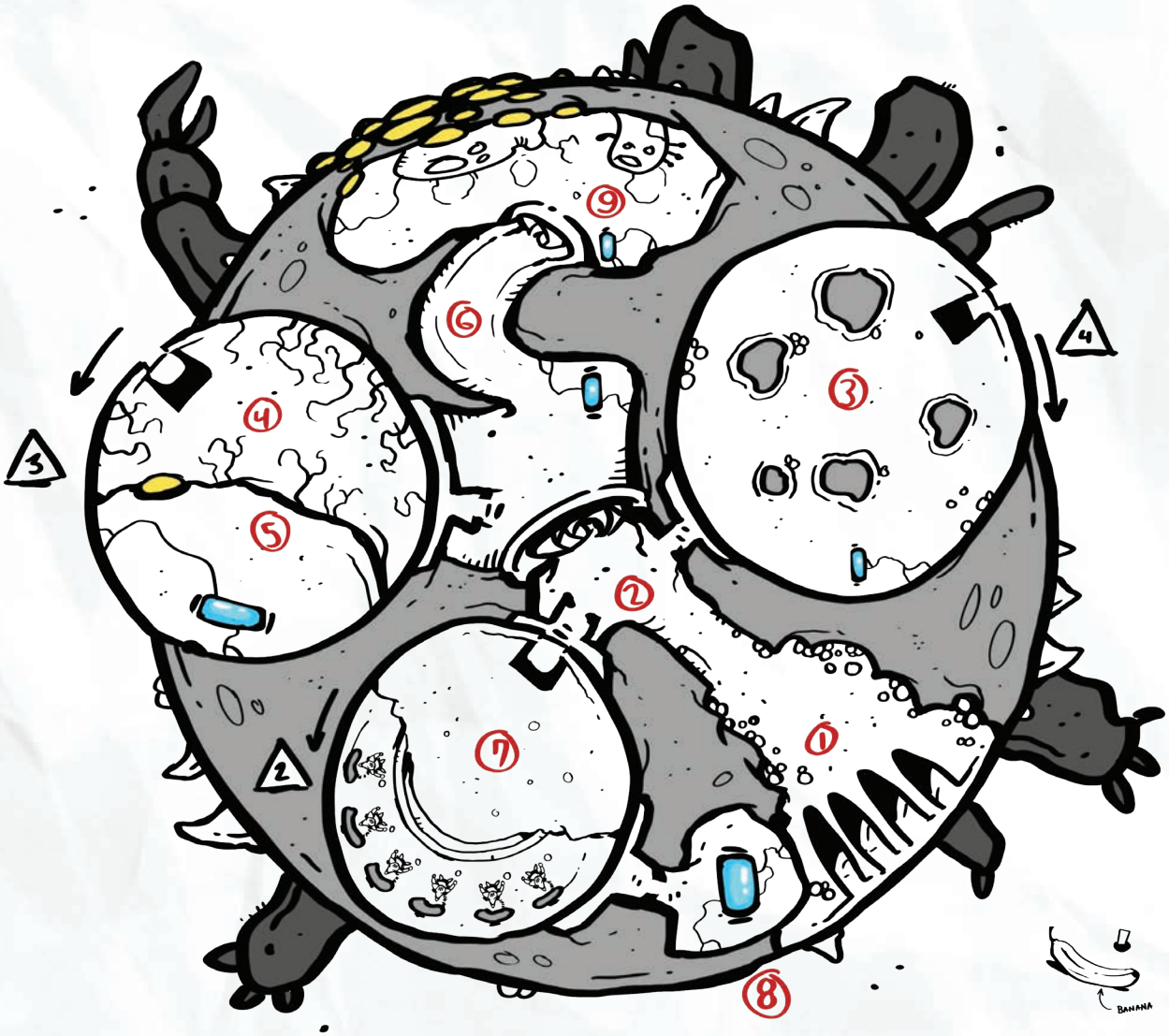
A TITAN AWAKENS

CARAPACE MAP

These maps show the three levels inside the carapace. The trick to capturing its unique feel is the moving room spaces, and their intelligent relationship with Specter and the SYMBIOTES.

THE STRANGE LINK

Specter and the symbiotic creatures aboard the carapace communicate with it via a glowing blue ooze that runs in tubes. If cut off entirely from this ooze, neither Specter nor SYMBIOTES can communicate with it.



1: Trachea Exhaust: Area where gusts of breathed wind rush out. STR roll to resist gusts every TIMER
2: The Junction: Heavily guarded with SYMBIOTES, openings align with dome chambers every TIMER
3: Lung Chamber: Huge crustaceous pillars absorb fresh air. Room rotates to align with door every 4 ROUNDS
4: Psilia Room: Digestive tendrils grab at debris and foreign matter. HARD STR to escape, translucent door ahead
5: Goo Module: A large tank of blue mind goo protected an tended by a high powered SYMBIOTE
6: Guarded Spinal Corridor: Ridged spinal tunnel packed with SYMBIOTE guards, door to Nerve Center locked
7: Pilots Chamber: Revelation that the carapace hosts human pilots. Room contains 6 carapace vac suits
8: Hidden Goo Room: Aligns with Pilots Chamber every 2 ROUNDS, contains largest mind goo tank
9: Nerve Center: Translucent eye-windows and monitoring organs for carapace functions

CARAPACE MECHANICS

BREATHING

The Lung Chamber and Psilia Room both rotate to allow huge volumes of air to be taken in, metabolized, and exhaled. This huge, rhythmic rush of air is the main sound scape of the carapace interior, but also forces air out the giant vents in the trachea. Creatures who are not SYMBIOTES are pushed out the vents, resisting with a STR roll. Not the offset timers on these 'organs.'

PSYCHEDELIC MEMORY GEL

The blue ooze in large tanks serves as a communications medium between the carapace, the SYMBIOTES, and Specter. Players can cripple the SYMBIOTES, and remove Specter from control, by interfering with this system. The gel can also be used to commune with the carapace, functioning much like a hacking terminal or 'virtual reality' jack-in point. GM's should have a field day with this concept.

SYMBIOTES

The interior is crawling, literally, with SYMBIOTES. Bring them on in waves, constantly trying to rid the area of foreign organisms. One strategy against Specter might be to get the 'foreign' classification on her, and turn the SYMBIOTES against her. Either way, keep these monsters coming in strong numbers as the primary time pressure.

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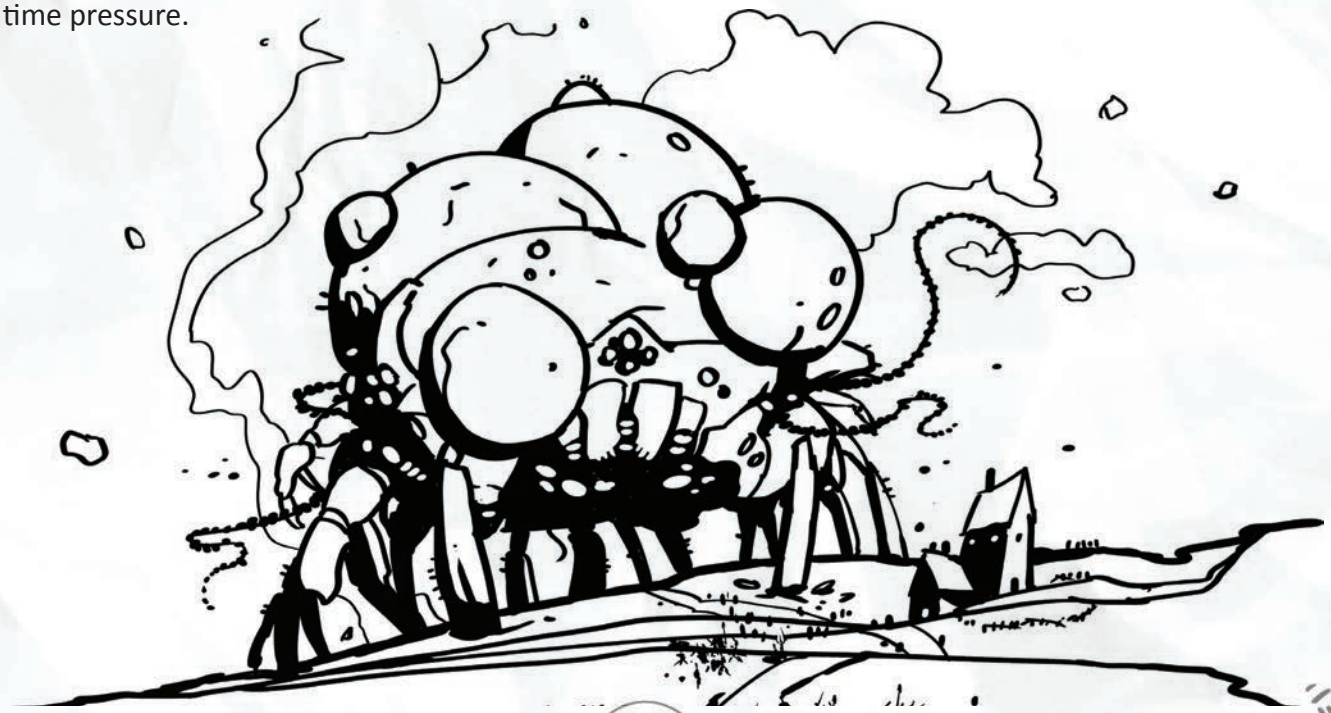
MOVEMENT AND JOSTLING

As the carapace walks along, crushing towns and villages, the entire dungeon space should shift and sway. This can send characters tumbling, make them nauseous, or make normal movement clumsy and difficult. Be sure to remind players with your descriptions that this is moving, and destroying.

ORIFICE DOORS

There are two large doors dividing these areas. They are organic, spiral orifices. Make these challenging locks for players, requiring either gel, psychic communication or biological irritant to open. These doors are your chance to greatly slow players while SYMBIOTES pursue them.



THE SYMBIOTES

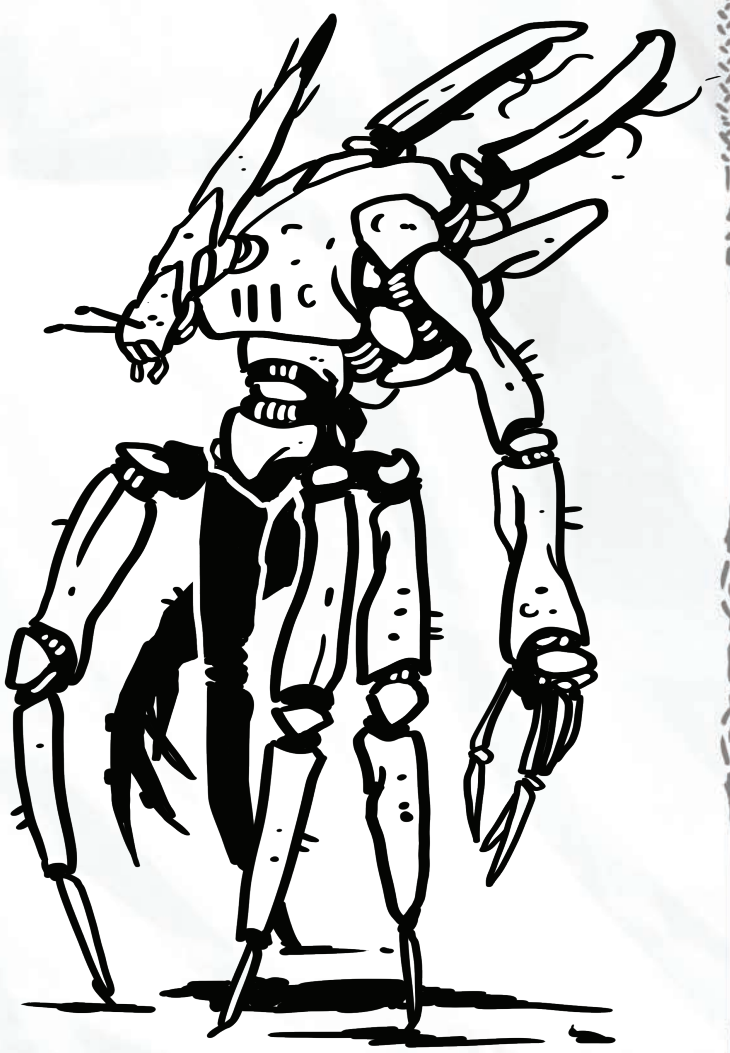
ROLLS: +4 STATS, +2 EFFORT

ACTIONS (ROLL 1D6)

BITE ATTACK: A ripping attack, tiny transparent teeth
STICKY FLUID: The SYMBIOTE spews out a cone of clear goo. Those entangled must make a HARD STR to escape the mess
STITCH: One SYMBIOTE uses its mouth to close wounds on another, healing for 1D6+2
CORRODE: The creature latches onto a piece of equipment, then secretes a solvent. IF inflicting 4 or more WEAPON EFFORT this way, 1 piece of gear is destroyed.
THROW: To simply remove intrusions, SYMBIOTES hurl their foes NEAR, preferably off the carapace
REGROW: This action allows a SYMBIOTE to regenerate 1D8 HP on its own

Wherever the Heckoon Carapace goes, these creatures appear in great numbers. They are the custodians and sentinels of the titan. They spawn in vast numbers from glands in the carapace interior. The alpha, seen at right, features 4 HEARTS.

NUMBERS: Spawn 1D4 SYMBIOTES every ROUND. If only 1 spawns, it is an alpha. If 4 spawn, the roll 'explodes,' roll the 1D4 again.



RE-PURPOSED: With some investigation, heroes can discover a terrible secret. The SYMBIOTES are, in fact, human beings that the carapace has consumed and reformed into these hybrid beings. This can be found out by detecting a human brain in their anatomy, finding half-formed SYMBIOTES that look human, or seeing vaguely familiar features on their faces. If players discover this grim secret, the gravity and dilemma of their mission should become truly horrible.

THE HECKOON DAWN

ROLLS: +2 ALL ROLLS

ACTIONS (ROLL 1D6)

DAGGER: Typical WEAPON attack
DARTS: Cultists hurl tiny steel darts from their sleeves, staying at range
MOB: The hooded figure leaps forward, grabbing a foe with STR and simply pinning them, mumbling and chanting about 'one of us'
HYPNOTIZE: By removing the hood, a semi-insectoid face is revealed. Those looking must roll WIS or be transfixed for 1 ROUND. If transfixed for 3 ROUNDS, a victim is hypnotized and works for the Heckoon Dawn until finding a way to snap out of it
HIDE: This is no army! The cultists run off and cower
MARTYR: One hooded figure hurls itself into enemies, fire, weakening structures or the like to cause harm with suicide

A group of mutated people have always hid in the deep mountain places, wearing dark red, with faces like crabs or lobsters, and a subsonic humming chant. It is not known if they call the Heckoon, or simply worship it. There motto is 'to see is to die.'

ATMOSPHERIC: The primary function of The Heckoon Dawn in this adventure is to be weird, spooky, and add atmosphere to the scenes. Sometimes, they just dwell, in great numbers, just beyond bow-reach of the heroes... staring and motionless. Other times they are driven berzerk by the carapace, or a solitary one leaps from an unseen shadow with a bloody dagger. Be dark, be messed up dark with them, and constantly allude to the half-crustacean hell these poor souls exist in. Are they evil? It is unclear, for their only true purpose is to awaken and protect the Heckoon on its long, slow journey.

OFTEN COHERENT: Although the cultists of Heckoon are part insectoid under their hooded robes, many of them still speak common, and are lucid. They are aware of their role in life, and act as environmentalists or druidic worshipers of natural balance. They see the Heckoon as a force of nature, and will even converse with normal folk in an odd, trilling voice.

SPECTER

ROLLS: +4 ALL ROLLS

ACTIONS (2 PER TURN, ROLL 1D6)

STAFF OF BOLTS: Ranged arcane missile attack, greenish shards of raw energy
SHOCKWAVE: Specter raises her staff. All enemies within FAR make a DEX roll of take ULTIMATE damage
TRANSLOCATE: With an INT roll, Specter switches places instantly with one ally or enemy
ANTI-MAGIC: With an INT roll, Specter blasts a foe, nullifying their magical gear and spell use for 1D4 ROUNDS
BLOOD MIST: She draws blood from a foe or ally and drinks it herself, recovering D8 HP
SPELL RING: Choose any CORE SPELL at random and use it to deadliest possible effect

No one knows where Specter came from, but she has been lurking in the mountains for four centuries, waiting to harness the carapace for her evil schemes. She is a cowardly, devious foe who will use disguise, traps, and legions of minions to build her domination of Alfheim.

DARK DRUID: When role-playing Specter, or planning her actions and appearances, treat her a druid turned dark. Her intentions are to restore the balance of nature, to protect rare forms of life, and scour the smoke and bother of industry from the natural world. Here are a few things she would say.

"Fools! You struggle to kill a demigod! What can you pitiful fleas know of the elder titans?!"

"The destruction before you is the cost of your greed! The Heckoon is a harbinger of justice!"

"So, another band of plunderers dares to set foot on holy ground. I will teach you about real power."

A HUMAN CARAPACE: It may or may not have a chance to be revealed, but Specter is actually a Heckoon herself in human form. She is one of the oldest of the titans, and sacrificed her true form to serve as a guardian for her kind. Now that so few Heckoon are yet living, she has turned against the world, not only protecting but seeking to dominate a world she sees and murderous and wanton.

CONCLUSION

DESTRUCTION

How many villages, towns or cities are destroyed before the carapace is diverted, destroyed, or controlled? What will be the ongoing ramifications of the destroyed landscape? Will the heroes be associated with the monster, or considered saviors?

Not lightly should you employ this adventure in your game world! Entire nations can be flattened by this titan! Be sure, throughout the adventure and especially wrapping it up, to describe the destructive effect of the Heckoon migration.

There should be no shortage of adventure, tragedy and dark revelation in such a ruined landscape.

WHAT NEXT?

When the smoke clears, your player may want to continue this thread for more adventuring. Here are a few follow-up concepts to keep the spark going.

- The Heckoon Dawn must be decimated completely, and a king's ransom awaits anyone who can destroy them.
- Specter escapes, and plots revenge against the heroes.
- The carapace is spotted off the coast of a neighboring realm, and it threatens to come ashore, but no one knows why.
- Another gigantic creature, far more sinister and destructive, appears. It is eventually revealed that the carapace has awakened to stop it.

INTO THE SUNSET

Every 400 years, one of them awakens.
Its long, ponderous journey to the sea is doom for all.
We are the foolish few who hope to stop it.

OVERVIEW

THE DOOM OF HATT MARTINS

Hatt Martins set off to find Ghost Mountain, and save his family. What he found was a place in a shadow of evil, and our heroes are his only hope.

CAMPAIGN CHAPTERS

THE BUCKSKIN STAGE: Players are waylaid on their usual coach route by a standoff at the Gallows Crossroad.

SHOWDOWN: The Dyre Gang, and the Slayer, depending on Chapter 1, want the heroes killed dead. It all comes to a head outside Buckskin, on the slopes of Hatchet Mountain.

A DEAD ROCK LOVE STORY: Dyre's operation is headquartered in Dead Rock. Problem is, every damn soul is falling in love with the same woman: Mistress Diamond. Things are about to go haywire.

HELL AND HIGH WATER: At one point or another, the heroes may wind up in Dead Rock. The Dyre Gang sets up a brutal ambush, unleashing Coolie Dam and flooding the town. This can happen at Buckskin too.

THE MUNSON MINE: A series of events lead our heroes to the deepest mine on the mountain, where the Dyre Gang has been transporting wagon loads of TNT. They mean to open a tunnel straight to the Hollow, and release a legion of demon kind.

EDGE OF EVERYTHING: Stumped in the Munson Mine, or shunted from there to the only way deeper, heroes wind up spelunking the crumbling edge of Ghost Mountain, looking for a way in or out of the Hollow.

FRIENDS IN LOW PLACES: Here's one *hell* of a crawl.

INTO THE SUNSET: The Dead Pinnacles are the location for a climactic showdown with Azael the Butcher. Once the heroes return to town, if they do, the many threads of family, friendship and revenge tie together. Hell of a thing.

THE WHOLE TRUTH

Though presented as a somewhat linear story here, there is no telling how *your* Ghost Mountain adventure will go. Plan one night at a time, and give players opportunities to choose where it's all headed next.

The big truth at work here is that the One God has torn Ghost Mountain up to take it away from Lucifer. Why? Because within the mountain lies a colossal deposit of YOG crystals. If they were to fall into the Devil's hands, his power would be limitless. While the forces of good pull the mountain ever closer to oblivion, demons and darkness crave to save it, mining feverishly in the hollow. This is the terrible irony of the full truth: that the only hope for Ghost Mountain is destruction, and so the lure of Lucifer's agenda holds sway over so many.

In such times, what can a few heroes do? That is for *you* to discover...

THE YARN

THE BUCKSKIN STAGE

Players begin with their heroes working as guards, stage drivers, wranglers, hunters, stowaways, pursuers or missionaries on a stagecoach route from Dead Rock to Buckskin. Try choosing one hero to play the stage boss and hire the others for this perilous supply run.

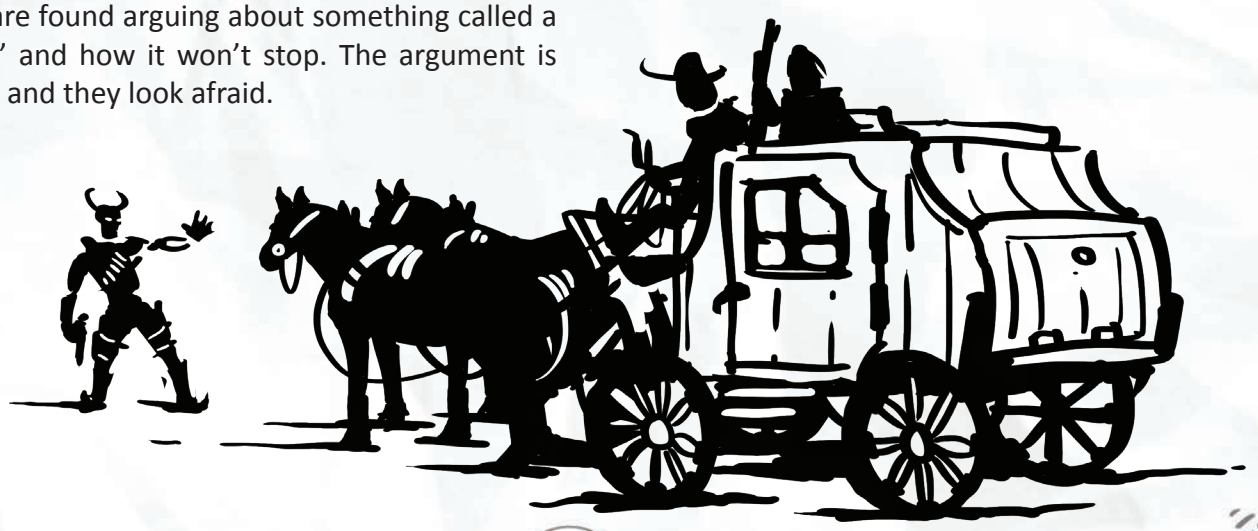
Halfway along, at Gallows Crossroads, they encounter the Dyre Gang, in the middle of terrorizing a family. A few of the outlaws are men, but two of them are Infernal. They have a father, mother and their daughter waylaid and hogtied, rifling through their possessions. These are the Martins family, minus Hatt.

- A gunfight at the crossroads: Provide a cover-rich approach, but remember how lethal guns are here, and warm players up to a good ol' shoot out.
- Two paths to Buckskin: Heroes can travel north to Buckskin, but they learn that it is blocked by a landslide. This landslide is actually a Dyre Gang trap. They can go south, but that takes them close to the Edge and will take twice as long.
- A town being bullied: Buckskin, when they arrive, is being bullied and brutalized by Dyre's men, who are loading a wagon of TNT and hounding the citizens.
- Emma: The mayor of Buckskin is a woman named Emma, who is pure of heart and stout as an oak. She wants to fight back, and will help the heroes any way she can.
- The Slayer Argument: Just outside of town, two residents are found arguing about something called a "Slayer" and how it won't stop. The argument is heated, and they look afraid.

CLUES AND CHOICES

From the little town of Buckskin, heroes will have several choices of how to proceed. Don't try to out-plan your players, just propose threads of adventure at session-end. Be fluid!

- Wagon tracks and TNT: Heading east from Buckskin are a set of well-worn wagon tracks. This is where the gang has been shipping TNT to Munson Mine.
- Smoke rising from the Henson Ranch: Off to the west, a plume of black smoke marks the old Henson place...looks like a very big fire just burned there. Turns out the Dyre demons just blew his place to bits when he stood up to them, but he knows about their TNT operation at the landslide outpost.
- The Canuska Burials: Up North, weird standing stones mark a magical place. A Canuska shaman skulks there, and has cosmic answers for odd questions. One catch: this shaman is actually The Hunger in human form. This can be an epic, brutal, LOOT-rich encounter, or used to alleviate CONDITIONS heroes might have.
- Ending the Slayer's Curse: The Slayer is a creature born when a wrathful soul digs up a Slayer Root in a dense wood called The Tangle. The only way to stop this rampaging beast is to kill it and re-bury it there.



SHOWDOWN

Whether it's outside Munson Mine, or somewhere near Buckskin, the heroes are going to come face to face with Dyre and his best men. Sure it's a tough fight, but it also unfolds the next chapters of the story.

- Hard to Kill: Dyre is part SMOKE, so he is immune to all non-MAGICAL attacks. Make him extremely resourceful, fast, and hard to fight. He and his men, though, have key information when it comes to what's *really* going on in Ghost Mountain, ie: the YOG mining and Azael the Butcher.
- The Righteous Play Their Hand: Coming up from Thomson Gulch is a small squad of highly trained religious gunfighters called The Righteous. They wear black, have silver crucifixes, silver guns, and mean to end the demon plague once and for all. Finding one dead, or meeting one in The Tangle can be a good way to introduce them. Can they be trusted?
- Humble Help: Don't forget your Buckskin townsfolk, who want to beat Dyre. Maybe they can create a distraction, hide up in the rocks with rifles or put on a ruse to lure the gang in. Part of the fun of weird west is the humble, regular folks.
- The Hunger: This creature can be as much or little as you want for your game. It can manifest as a giant mouth in the ground, a huge bear make of black smoke, or a Canuska Shaman in infernal form. It is the native response to fight back everyone who has come to Ghost Mountain, and it is angry.

CLUES AND CHOICES

Whether or not Dyre is defeated during the showdown, these clues can lead players in a few directions.

- The Munson Map: At this point, drop a crude map of the mine as a clue. It indicates ways down that make no sense, and infernal markings and glyphs.
- The Henson Brand: If the players never chose to check out Henson Ranch, place a little brand or mark on the TNT or wagon that an NPC recognizes. The ranch is where the demon gang has been mining Sulphur, and they have left poor Henson's entire family as wrathful muertos.
- A Letter to Mistress Diamond: A strange letter can be found, proclaiming undying, almost psychotic love and loyalty for a woman named Diamond. It's addressed to Dead Rock, and signed by Dyre himself.
- Splinters of YOG: Tiny fragments of red YOG crystal can be found here and there as players begin to sniff out the mine. You can also make them FIRE STONES or priceless gems. They are hints at the biggest part of the story: that Ghost Mountain is a colossal growth of YOG, thus its cosmic importance.

A DEAD ROCK LOVE STORY

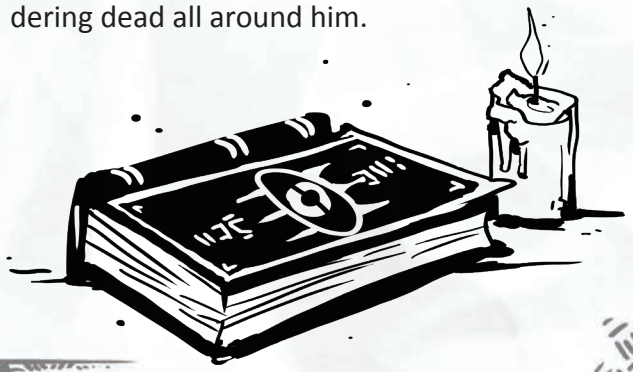
Either to collect supplies, pursue Dyre, or fall back from a tough defeat, the heroes may find themselves in Dead Rock. One problem: the whole town has gone bonkers. Her name is Mistress Diamond, and she's got everyone in a chaotic violent frenzy of jealousy...and you just walked right into it.

- Whoopin' and a Whompin': When heroes arrive here, the town is in chaos. Cowboys and drunks are running wild, shooting, fighting, flying out of windows, or being dragged by spooked horses. Just to get in and figure things out will be no easy task.
- The High Horse Riders: One group is thriving in the madness, a posse from up north. They're horse thieves and killers, no ordinary yokles with guns, and they mean to be Mistress Diamond's top men. They're holed up in the Gilded Goat saloon. No one gets to the mistress without going through them.
- Diamond's Lair: In the vast store rooms below the Gilded Goat, Mistress Diamond has a posh boudoir. It's really more of a demonic shrine, where she is casting the magic that has everyone going nuts. Here she only has two guards: blind horrors from the deep. She is a powerful sorceress.
- Azael Revealed: If Diamond is engaged, or pressed to a limit, or even defeated, she reveals her true form: that of Azael the Butcher. This is an archfiend from Hell itself, but only appearing in astral form. It is enraged, and marks the heroes as its next victims. This can't be good.

CLUES AND CHOICES

You can use Dead Rock to do lots of different characters and story threads, or simply play it as a chaotic battle. Either way, the next chapters will escalate the story to a final confrontation with the demons operating the Munson Mine. If your players never go to Dead Rock, these clues can be placed as options anywhere.

- The Red Diamond: You find a gleaming, purest red jewel the size of a fist. It is pure, uncut YOG. It will heal anyone CLOSE to it for 1D6 every ROUND, it is priceless, and could even power a starship. A close look at this crystal reveals faces, swirling in a red mist, and they are the faces of men you have killed. The red diamond can be identified by almost anyone on Ghost Mountain as coming from the Munson Mine.
- Is This the God You Worship: A deep talk with an NPC of your choice leads to a staggering truth: that the One God is the cause of the maelstrom that ripped Ghost Mountain from Earth. It was done to keep the YOG deposit from Lucifer's legions, but it still places blame for this entire mess on the so-called righteous god.
- The Righteous: These gunslingers eventually reveal their true purpose: to kill Azael. They know ways down to the Dead Pinnacles, or perhaps one of them is a shapeshifter in disguise. You can use them in all kinds of ways to lure, guide, or compel heroes to action.
- Book of Eyes: This magical tome includes 12 pages. Each can be read at a location. An eye is placed there. From that day on, the user can turn to that page and see what the eye sees. One page is already functioning, and shows Azael feeding on raw YOG, growing bigger and bigger, with piles of smoldering dead all around him.



THE YARN

HELL AND HIGH WATER

Just when it couldn't get more lawless in Dead Rock, whatever is left of the Dyre gang blows the Coolie Dam and floods the town. This will either drive heroes out of town, or wish them into a sinkhole. The question is: can anyone be saved?

- Rumblin': As your Dead Rock segment winds down, a terrible rumble can be heard just outside of town. This is Coolie Dam being blown, and the town is about to be wiped out. Here's a TIMER for the ages!
- Total destruction: When the flood hits, nothing can withstand it. Entire buildings are smashed, poles and timbers go flying, crowds are crushed and drowned. It is a deadly day. Only high ground is safe.
- Bastards at the High Ground: Once/if heroes reach Cemetery Hill, the innocents there are being pushed back by a group of cowards with guns. One of them kicks a poor old woman into the torrent. Take 'em down.
- Blue Canyon Falls: Where the flood drops off a cliff, at Blue Canyon, the whole town is smashing and colliding, then tumbling down *the edge*. If swept away, the heroes can take this route into the Shallows of Hell, or the depths of Munson Mine. The odds of surviving such rapids are very, very low.

CLUES AND CHOICES

Survivors are the real measure of this catastrophe, and heroes should make every attempt to save the innocent. This is a time to get biblical with your descriptions, and personal with your clues.

- Horace Walters: An old farmer who survives the flood will take the heroes in, equip and feed them. Moreover, he knows a secret route into the Munson Mine that can bypass the eye beast halls. One catch: it's a 2 mile climb straight down.
- Ada Ardagast: This attractive schoolteacher has been secretly studying Azael and the legions of hell. She has detailed information on their powers and weaknesses. You can homebrew these as needed, making Azael especially nasty to confront. She may also know of a certain artifact or incantation that will lower the archfiend's defenses, or make an eye beast vulnerable to bullets.
- The Lord's Church Choir: This group of kids can be rescued from the flood. Their gratitude grants the heroes each a MILESTONE PATH REWARD.
- Ol' Jeb: The legend of Jeb goes way back. Seems every few decades an old man appears with this name, and he's sort of invulnerable or proof against infernal powers. He can be led down into Hell, as a sort of Virgil or holy ward, and used to confront even the most powerful fiends. Thing is, he sure moves slow.

THE MUNSON MINE

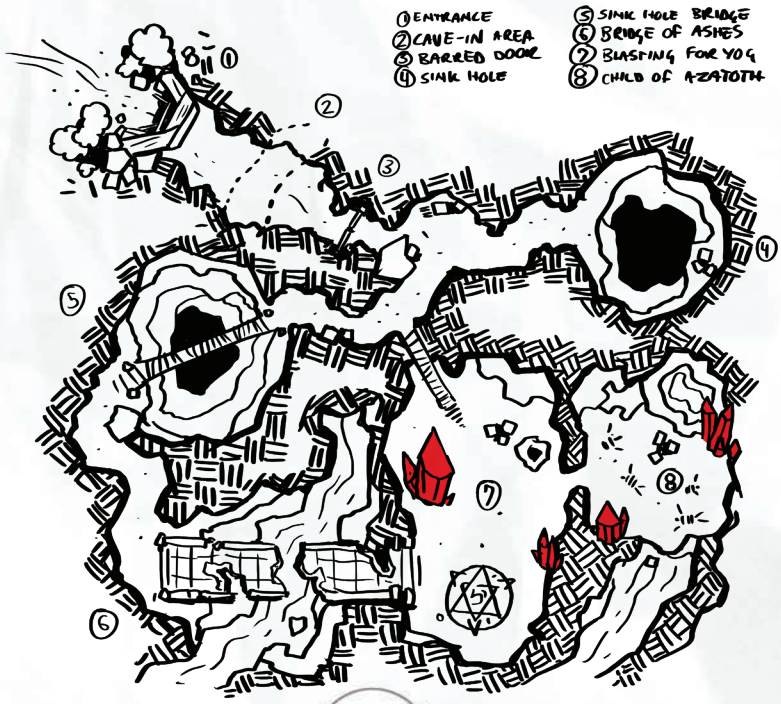
Here is your first real dungeon crawl of the campaign. It can stretch out or compress to fit your table's style. Dyre and his men are using TNT to blast their way down to the hollow, unleash the demon armies, and aid Azael in finding the YOG vein. Do-gooder heroes will try to stop it all, but any sane person would run for it when they see the doom that awaits here.

- The Big Collapse: A ways into the mine, the tunnel collapses, blocking exit and alerting the denizens within. On a bad roll, a hero or two might even get caught in the rubble as the shadow wolves attack.
- Diggin' Pits: Dyre's men have been digging downward, trying to make an opening to the shallows, which are the upper layers of the hollow interior, where Hell begins. These pits are crossed by precarious plank bridges (naturally).
- Bridge of Ashes: One great stone bridge in the caverns is crumbling with age. It shows signs of ancient gothic architecture. From a fiery chasm below, the ash-black skeletons of lost souls are crawling upward, confused and seeking living flesh.
- Blast Site: Deep in the mine, the men are blasting with TNT. This will knock everyone down, break concentration on SPELLS, or make rolls HARD. These pits can be used to descend further.
- Shallows of Hell: One corner of the caverns holds a child of Azatoth. It is surrounded by the dead, and piles of bones. The heroes are drawn to it, and their doom. If it can be defeated, EPIC LOOT awaits. The LOOT is from Alfheim, for so far-flung are these accursed beings.

CLUES AND CHOICES

After encountering the bridge of ashes, blind horrors and eye beasts, the players are likely to seek safer passage or simply flee. That's when things get interesting.

- The Righteous: If the 'men in black' haven't appeared in your campaign yet, consider placing one way down here, fighting back the hordes all alone. He can be used to frighten, inform, or guide heroes onward.
- Dyre's Way Down: The TNT pits can be climbed, but at risk. Be ready for brutal falling rolls, hero death or even a party wipe out. If this happens, they awaken deep in hell, stripped of all gear, in bars.
- Touched by Evil: The child of Azatoth can be used in very insidious ways, even secretly turning a hero to pure evil, sending them the wrong way, or alerting Azael all too soon. Be ruthless. Be arcane.



EDGE OF EVERYTHING

The edge of Ghost Mountain is a crumbling place, where gravity and thunderstorms are all twisted and volatile. This location can be reached at a few times in your campaign, but no one goes there deliberately. It can serve as an escape from the hollow, or a long way 'round the avalanche on Hatchet Mountain.

- The Lonely Tracker: However or whenever your players come this way, a lone tracker, part infernal, will defend his camp here. He is a sniper-style sharpshooter who hides in the rolling clouds, aiming for vitals and dropping heroes one by one.
- Shadow Wolves: These dimension-phasing predators are the tracker's pack. They will fight to the death once anyone comes too close to the tracker's campfire.
- Storms: Use a giant sliding cloud to represent limited visibility here. Even consider using lightning strikes, driving rain or wind gusts. Giant boulders raise into the air here, and the void itself is visible out in the distance. Heavy stuff.
- Dead Men in the Dirt: Lead players along by placing skeletons here and there. Load them with SHABBY or Ghost Mountain LOOT.

CLUES AND CHOICES

Heading onward from the edge is a simple matter of knowing the area, providing roadways, and keeping a tight watch on SUPPLIES. Out this far, it's all too easy to get stranded, lost, or simply starve.

- Native Traders: A good random encounter in this wilderness can be Canuska or Hepawa traders. They have LOOT, but are slow to trust. They can also be used to inform, guide, or trick heroes.
- The Road to Buckskin: It's a long way up Hatchet Mountain. Remember to press SUPPLIES. Force heroes to hunt, search or scavenge.
- The Road to Dead Rock: Heading back is an option, past Gallows Crossroads, but Dyre has dispatched a squad to investigate what happened there, and it will be tougher than last time, with MUERTO gatling gunners on site.
- The Cliffs to the Hollow: One way to reach upper Hell is to climb down *the edge* with ropes and such, but it is a dizzying, unstable scene with floating rocks and infinite drop-offs. This can make an epic scene for an encounter with The Hunger or a floating eye beast.

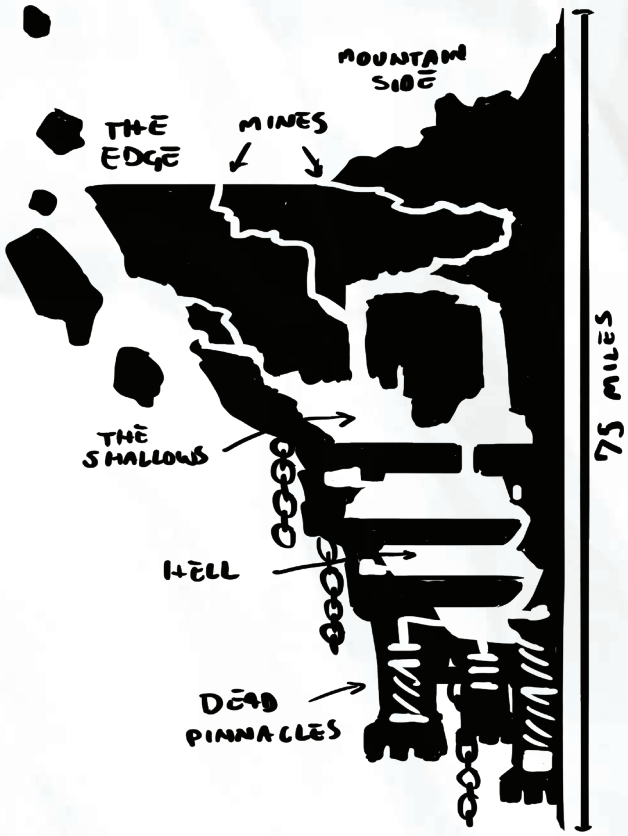
THE YARN

FRIENDS IN LOW PLACES

Below Munson Mine, in the great hollow within Ghost Mountain, the upper levels of Hell are contained. Also here is the largest deposit of YOG on Earth, and there is no overstating the importance of keeping this power from Azael, and Lucifer himself.

These halls are the shallows of Hell itself...an endless tangle of streets and caverns, spiked fences, fields of spears, roaring fires, towers and pits, all teeming with lost souls, skeletons burned to ash, demon torturers and archfiend overlords.

- Rings Upon Rings: Like in 'Dante's Inferno' Hell is arranged in a series of descending, concentric rings. Use this as a guiding design principle as you lay out your dungeon. The further down, the worse things get, and each ring is hemmed by a massive wall.
- A Pilgrim Unburnt: Whether it be Ol' Jeb or a more mysterious character, introduce a 'pilgrim' who is incorporeal, but seeks to aid the heroes. Imagine a robed figure with a lantern ... like a holy ghost in Hell's red shadows.
- Flayers of Souls: The task masters of Hell are these 4-armed demons, whose only work is to whip and smite the damned, and drive lesser demons to similar deeds. They will work tirelessly to stop the heroes.
- The Dead Pinnacles: Finally, there is an upside-down fortress that hangs from below Ghost Mountain. Great stone towers and tangled chains. Imagine an upside-down tower adventure with Azael himself at the nadir of it all. Beyond epic.



CLUES AND CHOICES

All roads here either lead to the Dead Pinnacles, and Azael's lair, the Crystal Caverns, or the pits where souls burn.

- A Secret Door: By whatever means, heroes discover a secret entrance to the Dead Pinnacles that will take them straight to Azael for the final battle.
- The Dig: A huge area of the shallows is occupied by demons hard at work to uncover the Crystal Cavern, and reach the YOG. Heroes should be tempted to destroy or cripple this huge operation.
- Forges of Hell: Near the Dead Pinnacles, a smoky domain of molten iron holds these forges. This is where the great chains are made that bind the pinnacles, and all Hell's armies are equipped. Consider placing EPIC weapons and armor here.
- Gravelands: One way to lead heroes around, or inform them, is a vast swath of land occupied by etched grave stones. All kinds of clues and possible directions lay there written.

THE YARN

INTO THE SUNSET

However your campaign may conclude, here are some ideas to give an epilogue to all that has happened. Be poetic, let it all hang on the edge of a knife, and be ready to rewind time, end the world or worse.

- Into the Light: One way to end things is to have all of Ghost Mountain sort of fade into sunlight. Yes, everyone 'dies,' but the YOG are safe and Lucifer defeated. A sunset to end all sunsets. Even winning is sad up here.
- Crashing into Hell: A heavy metal ending might be using the massive chains, or some form of powerful magic, to 'crash' Ghost Mountain into Hell below. Like a giant missile or starship, Ghost Mountain could be thrust into Hell, destroying *everything*.
- Morning, Again: A classic way to move on is have the heroes go black, then sort of 'wake up' on the morning of their departure to Buckskin, all the way back at the beginning. They look at each, baffled, afraid, trapped forever in this nightmare.
- Thomson Gulch, the Night of the Maelstrom: A more triumphant ending could be coming-to in Thomson Gulch before the mountain was ever torn up. A game of cards is being played, and storm clouds are brewing. The world has been given a second chance, thanks to the mighty heroes.

CLUES AND CHOICES

Ghost Mountain has two connections to the other WORLDS: the Wizard's Door and the Crystal Cavern. Here are ways to make that bridge, and continue the saga far beyond the mountain.

- Wizard's Door: The Hunger has a small hut wherever he appears in your story. Within, he has conjured a gateway to ALFHEIM. This could be used to pass back and forth, call monsters or heroes, or anything else you imagine. One problem: The Hunger hates all living and unliving things.
- Crystal Cavern: So dense is the growth of YOG here, its raw power has opened a sort of wormhole or dimension gate into the remote future of WARP SHELL. Maybe a ship comes slamming into Ghost Mountain, or weird west heroes are swept up in a WARP SHELL ship for more adventures. The possibilities are endless.

VILLAINS AND ALLIES

NOBLE HEARTS

Good folk are still around, still willing to fight. Make friendly like, these are your only hope.

- The Red Lady: Long the guardian of lost souls in Hell, her charge is to stop Azael. She takes the form of a giant, silent, sphinx-like creature with greenish feathered wings and a necklace of pure green YOG.
- Emma: The mayor of Buckskin, Emma watches over the upper reaches of the mountain. She's really no more than a farmer, but with a heart as true and stout as any ever were.
- Big Bear: This young man was raised Canuska, but born to a pioneer family in Thomson Gulch. He has fully embraced the native ways, but most folks just think he's crazy.
- Reginald Henson: Owner of one the largest ranches over near *the edge*. Here's a classic good guy, and ought to be made sheriff.
- Hatt Martins: Just a kid looking for his family, who unwittingly opened the depths in Munson Mine.
- Raleigh Watts: The roads are patrolled by this sharp shootin' lady. Rumor has it she's hunting Dyre and his gang, but she is seldom seen in any town.
- Scrap: Just a weasel trying to survive? Nope, this critter is a totem animal ... a shapeshifter from the ancient days, and those who believe the stories will tell you he's our best hope to win this war.

NASTY BUGGERS

Easy thing, being nasty in dark times. These snakes took the low road, and deserve a bullet.

- Dyre: A half-smoke outlaw with a whole gang at his command. They take what they want, kill anyone who gets in their way, and seem set to unleash hell's armies. Dyre does have a soft spot, though: he used to be a man, and though he's all but forgotten, his family is still alive somewhere out near Dead Rock.
- The Hunger: This mysterious being takes many forms, mainly of a defiled Canuska shaman or a gigantic toothy mouth opening up in the earth. It seems to be drawn to burial grounds, and what it wants is unknown.
- Black Jack: Some kind of supernatural card player. Some folk don't think he's real, but he'll appear, run a town dry, kill off the women folk and even kids before he's done playing. Then he just disappears.
- Azael the Butcher: In the shallows of hell, an archfiend called Azael tortures lost souls or fools who mine too deep. He has no love of Bae-Al, thinking himself hell's real prince.

CONCLUSION

LET'S DO THIS

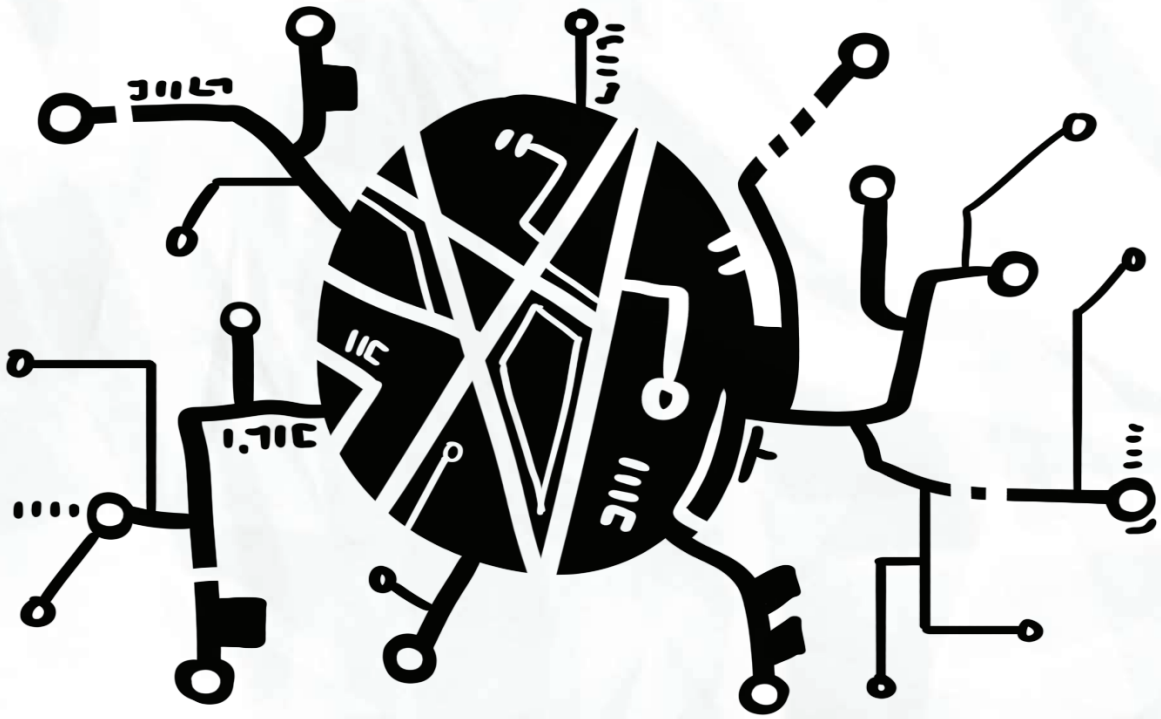
Now that **ICRPG** has grown to have a robust community, a best-selling CORE book, and WORLDS, we are truly ready to boldly go. There are too many stories already, and so many yet to come. I owe it all to the incredible, talented, creative, totally nutty players and readers out there making it all possible.

The next milestones for **ICRPG** include a SECOND EDITION CORE Set with all of the PDF updates up to 1.3.5. A Special edition of this book will also be available on AMAZON in 2018. Also coming are two more books to complete the set: GOOD and EVIL. These books will deliver loads of new material for all you deep divers out there. Stay tuned.

As we went through the process of playtesting WORLDS, we discovered how intertwined these different themes are, how robust the ruleset can really become, and how **ICRPG** has improved all of our games and game-mastering styles. I hope you have the same experience.

May your dice roll high.

-HF



DEVIOUS DIMENSIONS

The scarecrow calls for the black sky's return
Dead men make food for the servants of night
Arc-white clouds spinning on the hub of forever

OVERVIEW

A COSMIC ROLLER COASTER

Blast through the multiverse in pursuit of The Traveler, an escaped wizard set to unleash the prisoners of Splinter. The Traveler is going to release the vile prisoners of Splinter. The magical PORTAL she summoned to escape you is closing; following him is your only chance to stop this madness!

- During transport, The Traveler escapes into an astral gateway. Your team gives chase a second later!
- The Traveler tries to lose you dimension-hopping
- Get to each PORTAL before it closes
- Confront the Traveler on Splinter and stop an UNLOCK spell

MOMENTS

The Traveler moves through the dimensions below, wreaking disaster to slow the heroes. Each time the players arrive at a new dimension, roll a TIMER for how long the PORTAL stays open there.

1: PYROS

You chase through the Traveler's PORTAL into heat so extreme you can barely breathe. Ash and cinders rain onto a blackened stone terrace. A blue PORTAL shimmers ahead, across a churning river of lava dotted with floating rocks.

- The Traveler is seen vanishing into the blue PORTAL, which begins to shrink. It will close in 6 ROUNDS
- The heat is deadly, dealing damage every ROUND. Roll CON to avoid
- 1D6 Flame Kin boil out of the lava each ROUND
- Cross the shifting rocks to reach the PORTAL

2: ASTRAL PLANE

The Astral Plane is an abstract place. Gravity, time, and distance all shift and distort here, posing themselves as the primary obstacle. Heroes materialize in a baffling labyrinth of nonsensical shapes and shifting floors

- The Traveler is seen dashing off into the confusing spaces, conjuring a Phase Hulk
- Phase Hulk pursues them, replicates at 1 HP
- Use dice to generate randomized passages and walls leading to the PORTAL

3: HELL

You appear in an echoing hall of obsidian pillars and demonic gargoyles. Before you, a robed imp flanked by two horned fiends sits at a desk. A shrouded, dusty PORTAL shimmers behind them.

- The imp, Hazeriath, allows each player passage in exchange for "a customary toll"
- He accepts things of great value: magic LOOT, souls, permanent SPELL loss, a life, STATS, and the like
- If the players attack or displease him, he disappears in a puff of smoke and the Fiends engage
- The Fiends cannot be harmed IN ANY WAY until Hazeriath is stunned or killed. He is casting an IMPERVIOUS SPELL on both of them from a hidey hole nearby

4: SHIFTING SANDS

A blast of sand hits your face and ululating screams fill your ears. Raiders on mangy Raptors thunder past, chasing a titanic worm plunging through the dunes. In its spinning mouth, you glimpse the crackling glow of a gray PORTAL.

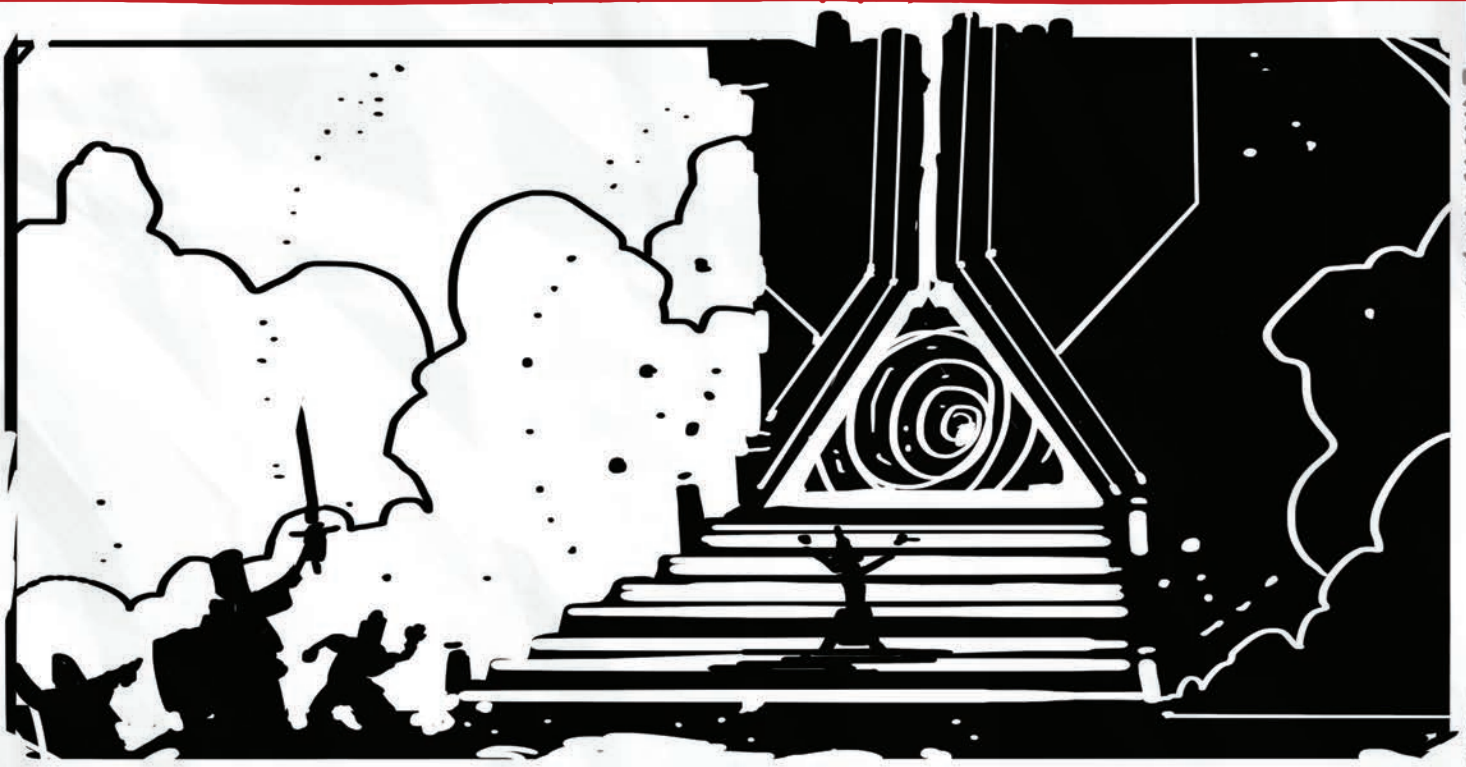
- Ruthless desert raiders want to be the first to reach the worm; they attack anyone trying to "steal their blood harvest"
- Raptors move DOUBLE FAR each turn but need a CHA roll to be controlled
- The worm moves FAR each TURN. It is so big, treat it as a room. The PORTAL is in its mouth (see below)
- The worm can be climbed with a STR roll

5: SPLINTER

The endless storms and stone cubes of Splinter make a harsh welcome. Traveler is casting a grand spell that will unlock all cell doors in the prison dimension in 6 ROUNDS

- The Traveler uses a Hellion and Imp Swarms as guardians while casting
- If he hasn't been stopped at 5 ROUNDS, one of Durathrax's lieutenants appears to fight the Hellion, revealing Durathrax's interest in maintaining Splinter
- Keep the climax/conclusion open ended!

PORTALS



DIMENSION HOPPING

Dimension shifts do strange things. Each hero rolls on this table when using The Traveler's PORTALS.

ROLL 1D20	PORTAL SIDE EFFEC
1	Your personal gravity reverses for 1D4 ROUNDS
2	Pass a CON save or be too dizzy to MOVE on your TURN
3	Your soul flickers; you can't cast SPELLS or use MAGIC LOOT for 1D4 ROUNDS
4	You are overwhelmed with visions of parallel realities. Your next ATTEMPT is HARD
5	Your senses invert. Creatures without a strong odor are invisible to you for 1D4 TURNS
6	Pass a WIS save or laugh hysterically and take no action on your next TURN
7	Raw CHAOS energy makes you berserk; for 1D4 ROUNDS, you must attack something
8	An atomic tear randomly destroys one of your LOOT
9	Between Portals, you see the folded infinity of space. Gain +1 INT permanently
10	Raw DARK energy turns you into a shadow for 1D4 TURNS; attacks against you are HARD
11	Age 20 years in seconds. Gain +1 WIS and lose -1 STR
12	What the? Appear on the other side with 1D12 tiny Phase Goblins climbing all over you
13	Psychic energy grants you swiftness of mind; on your next TURN, take an extra action
14	You are weightless and can fly for 1D4 ROUNDS
15	Destiny falls into your hands! Roll on the MAGIC LOOT table
16	Raw energy courses through you; your weapons deal MAGIC damage for 1D4 ROUNDS
17	The echoes of an angelic chorus heal you to full HP
18	You glimpse the near future. Your next ATTEMPT is EASY
19	You surge with cosmic power; your next EFFORT roll is ULTIMATE
20	You gain a temporary HEART that fades in 1d6 ROUNDS

CORNERING THE ENEMY

THE TITAN WORM

It's a dimension of endless sand. There's bound to be colossal worms probing the deep desert. This is the biggest of them. As the GM, treat the Titan Worm as TERRAIN, not as a monster. No power known can destroy a thing of such scale, or even harm it. The raiders merely want to harvest its blood and keep tabs on its movement. The Traveler, devious as he is, has conjured his next PORTAL in the spinning death-spiral of the thing's mouth. Players face locating and accessing this deadly location as the main challenge.

- Every other ROUND, the worm lunges upward, gulping. Save with DEX or fall inward
- If injured, the worm will spin or burrow for 2 ROUNDS. It cannot be ridden during these maneuvers
- Falling off of, being crushed by, or being bitten by the worm reduces a character to 0 HP instantly
- If gravity or bite action leaves a 0 HP character in the throat, they tumble past the PORTAL and meet a terrible end, torn to pieces and digested
- After 6 ROUNDS, it becomes irritated and goes underground, disappearing
- Yes, it's this bad. Players will need to get creative

WHO IS THE TRAVELER?

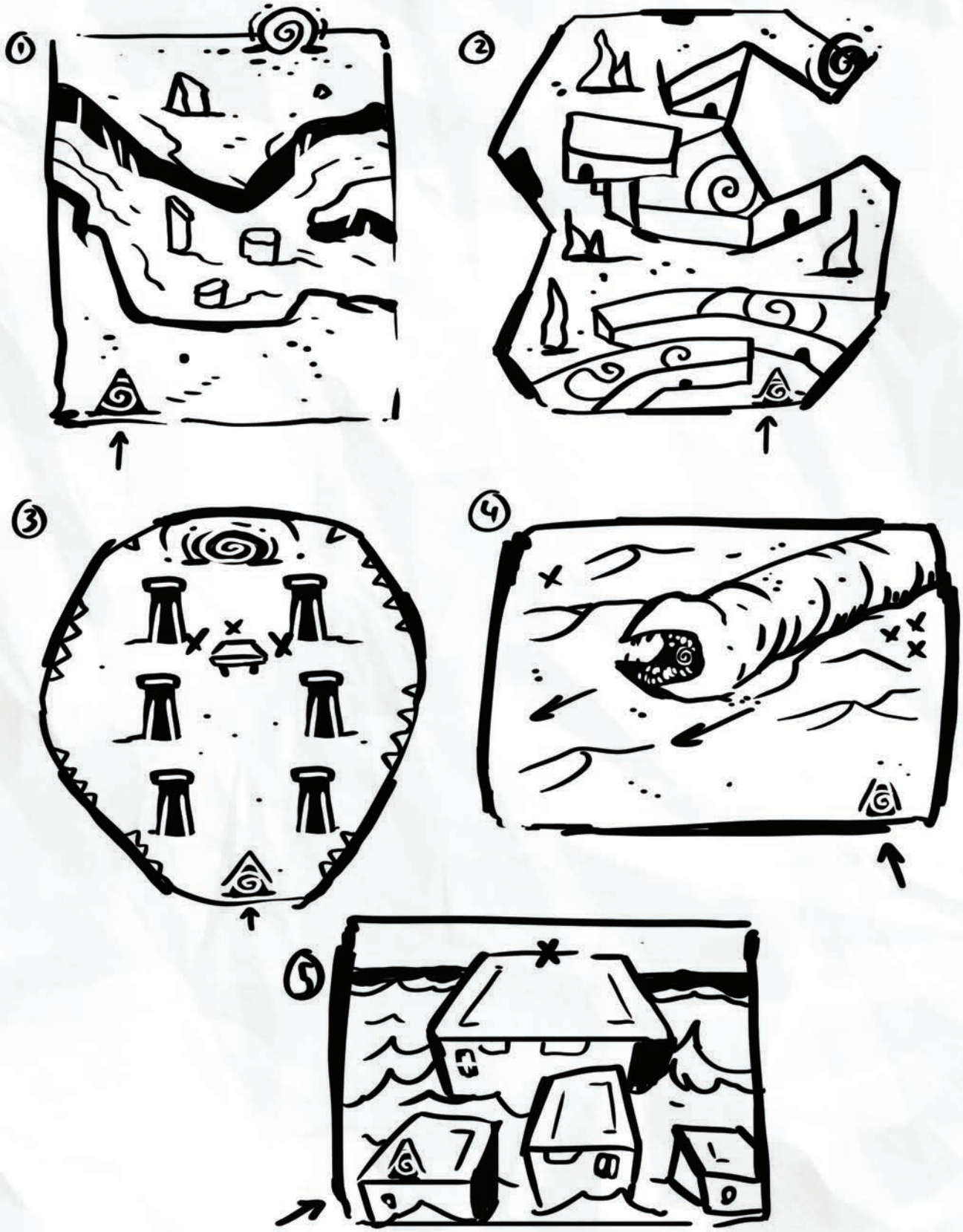
To prepare yourself to role play The Traveler, or answer player questions, you'll need the key facts on this devious villain. These answers are huge in their implications, so be prepared for entire side campaigns to spawn from these shocking truths and clues.

- Milo Underbottom, a halfling who drank the water of life eons ago. He has achieved an endless, lonely immortality. He has outlived the stars. This perspective has driven him mad, and he moves through time altering events for his perceived version of what 'should' be.
- The Traveler has merged with a Dark Star, perhaps against his will. Dark Stars are incredibly powerful, evil entities in deep space. For more, see 'Flight of the Red Sword' in ICRPG Core 2e.
- The being commonly called 'The Ogdru' is a misnomer. This chaotic, tentacled god is actually one of The Traveler's many forms, used to inspire mortals to dire deeds.
- WARP SHELL know all too well about The Devourer. This is the most destructive force in the cosmos. The Traveler has decided that any means are acceptable to stop this being, including harvesting entire planets for magical energy.

DIMENSIONS AND ROOMS

As this adventure unfolds, the heroes will jump from environment to environment. Each dimension may be its own world, but this romp treats each as a single, small, manageable play space or 'ROOM.' Keep everything focused to one space, keep the action moving, and players won't be tempted to stop and explore. If they do, that's ok, but they will lose The Traveler and be trapped until they can find or conjure a PORTAL to escape. Maps for each of these 'dimension rooms' are on the following page.

DIMENSION MAPS



RAPTOR RIDERS

ROLLS: +5 STATS, +3 EFFORT

ACTIONS (1 PER TURN)

SPEAR THRUST: A simple WEAPON attack with NEAR reach. If rolling a natural 18 or higher, a second thrust is attempted instantly

SPEAR THROW: These master riders never miss. A single target rolls DEX to avoid or takes ULTIMATE damage

RIPPING JAWS: The raptor itself is a weapon. Roll WEAPON damage, and 'explode' a natural 6

POUNCE: The Raptor leaps onto its prey, pinning it down. ULTIMATE damage, escape with a STR roll

BRACE: If using a TURN to brace, the rider and its mount are immune to damage for 1 ROUND

The raptor riders of the Shifting Sands have been hardened by their environment into brutal pack hunters. They are one of the only living things in the dunes, and abide no intruders of any kind.

THE PACK: Raptor Riders never travel in small numbers. If appearing, at least 8 ride together. Roll 1D100 for their number when they emerge from the horizon.

SURVIVAL INSTINCT: Raiders do not fight to the death. They will regroup, perform first aid, and attack again if possible. If routed, they will vanish into the dunes.

BLOOD DRINKERS: The Titan Worms have wondrous healing properties in their thick, amber-colored blood. The blood can only be harvested with a DEX roll, and then very little. Each raider will have at least 1 dose in their pack.

HIDDEN SKELETONS: Beneath their head-wraps, goggles, long gauntlets, riding boots and armor, Raptor Riders are nothing more than sinew and bone. The worm blood keeps them alive somehow, if what they are can be called life at all. This makes them immune to BLOOD SPELLS, disease, poison and fear of all kinds.

HAZERIATH INFERNUS

ROLLS: +8 STATS, +5 EFFORT

ACTIONS (2 PER TURN)

BITE: Normal WEAPON attack. Bitey
FLAP AROUND: If Hazeriath takes to the wing, he can barely control his flight. Any rolls for enemies CLOSE to him are HARD as long as he is flapping
FWOOP: He makes a weird whistling noise and recovers to full HP instantly
SILENCE: Hazeriath yells 'shut up!' or 'quiet you!' and his target must roll INT or be unable to speak (including saying power words for SPELL casting) for 1D4 ROUNDS
SNIKT: At lightning speeds, this imp can zip around and slash up to 8 targets in an instant, doing WEAPON damage to each with no roll
CAST SPELL: Hazeriath can cast any LEVEL II SPELL at no cost with a roll

Hazeriath is one of the oldest imps in existence. He has survived through trickery and wicked intelligence for millennia. His skills have outgrown any common imp, and his love of mortal misery is beyond compare.

SMOKE WALKER: Hazeriath can cast a teleport SPELL without using his ACTION, and reappear anywhere within 1 mile instantly. He can also use any cloud of smoke as an instant Doorway SPELL.

HEALED BY FIRE: Any fire magic or natural flames heal Hazeriath for the damage dealt or 1D8 per ROUND he is exposed.

DURABLE LITTLE BUGGER: This creature cannot be harmed by non-magical means, and ignores any hit of 5 or less.

DEFEATED? Even if killed, a laughter is heard, and a swarm of normal IMPS spawn instantly. Hazeriath marks his killer down on some infernal list, and swears revenge.

CONCLUSION

CONCLUSIONS

No true adventure is ever binary in its outcomes, especially when the dimensions are concerned. Nevertheless, here is a look at victory/defeat outcomes for the events of Devious Dimensions. The Traveler is not a thing to be directly confronted, at least not by mortals. Nevertheless, his plans can be thwarted, forcing him to rethink and recede to his cosmic sanctum.

THE TRAVELER IS DEFEATED

If the plan to throw Splinter wide open is stopped somehow, The Traveler will vanish, with a dire warning that some greater doom is yet to come. To give it some teeth, The Traveler can dispel any PORTALS in or out of Splinter instantly. The heroes become trapped, and are forced to reckon with a possibly greater menace: the prisoners themselves, and a dimension made to never be escaped.

THE HEROES FAIL

If the UNLOCK SPELL is fully cast, the heroes will be neck deep in magical super criminals. This will be a momentary problem, as all of them will be using PORTALS to escape. The Traveler laughs and vanishes. This may seem less hazardous than a victory, until the characters return home, finding their world or worlds ravaged by super-powered magical vigilantes, psychos and tyrants. Things just got a lot worse.

RED FANG

The sword called Ruin was already old, already storied
Bathed in the blood of Aras the Undead,
it became so much more...

OVERVIEW

THE DARK BELOW

After the fall of Aras in Dur Moro (Runehammer Novel #2, '*The Shield of Hannar*'), a series of dark events take place in the dwarven depths. Find a way to stop Aras from returning as the enemy of all Alfheim.

Zelb the Fisherman has stumbled on a crystal cavern writhing with eels of Iridess. Save Zelb and root out the servants of Aras Red Fang that fester in the dwarven tunnels!

- When Aras was defeated in Dur Moro, his blood seeped into the hidden Bloodlit Grotto
- A cabal of dwarven blood sorcerers have secretly studied the grotto for centuries
- Aras regenerated in the grotto, along with eels of Iridess, and killed the sorcerers
- Stop Aras before he gathers his strength and storms Dur Moro!

MOMENTS

1: ZELB'S DISCOVERY

A grizzled, breathless dwarf holding a fishing pole bursts from a tunnel at full speed. He looks behind him in terror as a fifteen-foot, barbed eel writhes into view! Zelb flees the crystal cavern; the eels of Iridess chase him

- Two more giant eels appear in each ROUND
- The eels flail violently, knocking rubble loose
- Zelb explains how bad fishing is here, but extensive caverns below
- Zelb mentions Aras Red Fang, and the fate of the world if he should return

2: CRYSTAL CAVERN

A subterranean stream winds through endless tunnels and glittering caves before emptying into a cavern of red-veined crystals. Stairs lead to an iron door in the wall. Eels of all sizes wriggle in shallow puddles

- Moving in the water requires a HARD DEX check to avoid disturbing the eels
- Once alerted, the Eels of Iridess attack the players each ROUND in full force, filling the chamber
- The iron door is cleverly locked and takes one HEART of work to release

3: CHAMBER OF CRUSHING STONE

This round chamber has four stone doors, each hewn in dwarven style. Rows of tiny holes dot the walls, and narrow gutters run to a grate in the center of the room.

- With a grind of stone clockwork, the ceiling descends. It crushes for ULTIMATE in 1D4 ROUNDS and resets to crush again
- Three doors are false (detect with an INT roll). Opening them triggers a volley of needles: ULTIMATE damage! Avoid paralyzing poison with a CON roll if struck by the needles

4: SORCERER SANCTUM

Old books and scrolls fill the stone shelves, and strange alchemical equipment litters the desks. A tall, red crystal sprouts from the floor, casting a soft glow.

- Three CHESTS of MAGIC LOOT are in this room
- If someone touches a CHEST, the crystal blasts everyone for MAGIC damage (DEX roll to avoid) every ROUND
- From the dusty books, 1D6 GHOSTS appear... Aras' sorcerer servants researching his return

5: RITUAL ROOM

Red water seeps beneath a door to fill a ceremonial pool in the center of the room. Five dwarves in torn, red robes lie dead around it, arcane tattoos visible on their bald heads.

- The sorcerers are Demons in dwarf form
- In 1 ROUND, the dwarves awaken to attack
- Drinking the red liquid recovers 1 HEART, but also turns the drinker into a Demon in 1D4 days

6: THE BLOODLIT GROTTO

Four hovering crystals float above a blood-red pool. In the center of them, Aras kneels with arms outstretched. He smiles, revealing curved fangs. A terrible glow starts to build inside the crystals!

- Each intact crystal has one HEART. Aras cannot be harmed as long as they are intact
- Every 1D4 ROUNDS, if any crystals remain, Aras casts WITHER at POWER IV as a free action
- Aras can submerge for his TURN to recover two HEARTS

THE MAP

CAVERNS OF THE BLOOD CABAL

20 details that can be found inside the halls built by the cabal of dwarven blood sorcerers.

ROLL 1D20	DETAILS IN THE DEPTHS
1	Dwarven runes chiseled on the wall with the cabal's Oath of Secrecy
2	A patch of dried blood running from a thin crack in the ceiling
3	A shriveled eel of Iridess with dagger wounds
4	A tiny set of stone cogs and gears that turn with a handle
5	A stained needle stuck deep in the wall
6	Red crystal fragments growing out of the stone
7	The body of a dwarf in crimson robes, blood drained by neck bites
8	A map depicting a wizard's lock carved in the floor of the Bloodlit Grotto
9	A partially completed chalk summoning circle
10	Notes: "Mastering the mightiest blood magic requires death and rebirth…"
11	A rig of alchemal equipment with several half-made concoctions
12	A lockbox containing a family ring for a powerful dwarven clan
13	A drawing indicating four tall crystals as the Bloodlit Grotto's power source
14	A crushed pair of wire-rimmed spectacles
15	A perfect red crystal with a note: "For payment to V.F. of Kath"
16	Spell scorch marks on the walls
17	Research notes about the Bloodlit Grotto's properties of healing and rebirth
18	Long claw marks in the stone at human height
19	Note: "Research day 873. Strange noises heard overnight in the grotto…"
20	A hidden treasure! Roll MAGIC LOOT

EELS OF IRIDESS

ROLLS: +2 STATS, +2 EFFORT

ACTIONS (1 PER TURN, PER HEART)

MULTIPLY: With a single action, a swarm of Eels will add 1 action and 1 HEART to their mass
ATTACK: The Eels envelop any group of targets with a NEAR radius. Anything within takes damage based on the swarm size. 1 HEART=BASIC, 2-3 HEARTS = WEAPON, 4+ HEARTS = ULTIMATE. Eels do not roll to attack
BIND: Using a roll, Eels can grapple an enemy, pulling them to the ground. A HARD STR roll is needed to escape them

These twisting, rubbery whips of flesh are abominations born in the depths. They have no will or mind of any kind, and simply obey Aras' murderous intentions.

BOUND TO ARAS: If Aras of Iridess is killed, the Eels dissipate and die within 1D4 ROUNDS.

ACIDIC POISON: Any target harmed by Eels of Iridess continues to feel their sting, taking WEAPON damage for 2 ROUNDS after bitten. This acid also disfigures its victims any time more than 6 damage is done per ROUND.

NOOKS AND CRANNIES: Eels can emerge from any tiny crack or space in any location. They will continue to grow in number until killed or the tide is somehow stemmed.

INFESTED: If more than 3 separate swarms are present in an area, or a single swarm reaches 6 HEARTS or more of mass, that area becomes infested. It is utterly untraversable by any means. Those caught within are trapped there until the swarm is cleared or reduced below 6 HEARTS. Infestations of this nature are sometimes already in place when adventurers arrive, clogging a doorway, filling a sewer tunnel, or completely engulfing a room or chamber.

GIANT: Anytime Eels are present, there is a 1/10 chance a GIANT EEL will be among them. Treat this as a GIANT TENTACLE from Core 2e, but with the properties of an Eel of Iridess.

ARAS THE RED FANG

ROLLS: +8 STATS, +4 EFFORT

ACTIONS (2 PER TURN)

MIND PRISON: Roll CHA against the CHA roll of a victim in sight. If they fail, they obey him for 1D4 ROUNDS
FORCE WAVE: No roll. All creatures within FAR resist with STR or are hurled FAR from Aras, taking WEAPON damage upon landing
TENTACLES: With a roll, Aras inflicts the plague of eels on a victim he can see. They must roll CON or grow 1D4 tentacles from their body. Each tentacle does WEAPON damage as it tears out, and continues to do so until destroyed. A tentacle has 5 HP
REGENERATE: Aras rests a moment and refills 1D4 HEARTS with a roll
DEADLY DART: With a roll, Aras hurls a meteoric missile of magical fire FAR. Its target drops to 0 HP
RED FANG: Aras will use the mighty blade, once called Ruin. It has a NEAR reach and strikes up to 3 foes in one attack, doing ULTIMATE damage that is magical in nature

From the dead city he came, and there he sends his victims, to join a vast army of the doomed. He is driven by madness and hate of the living, especially Elves, who he sees as cowards and traitors to their own destiny.

SUPREME UNDEAD: Aras is immune to poison, lack of air, heat, cold, and mental effects as well as all common weapons. He can only be harmed with MAGIC and SILVER weapons.

SPELL SLINGER: Any time Aras rolls a natural 15+ on Mind Prison, Regenerate, Deadly Dart or Tentacles, he is granted a free action.

MIRROR OF HATE: If Aras is struck for 10 or more damage in a single attack, he retaliates instantly with half the damage he takes. This requires no roll, and is MAGICAL in nature.

BLOOD DRINKER: If any creature is at 0 HP CLOSE to Aras, he sends their DYING timer to 1 and refills to full HP by drinking them dry. This takes him 1 action of time to perform.

ILLUSORY: Any time Aras is touched, struck, or attacked in any physical way, his location is revealed as somewhere else. His location can be treated as actual until his next TURN.

CONCLUSION

JUST LYING AROUND

The rooms of the blood sorcerers house odd trinkets and arcane devices left behind by careless dwarves and fallen warriors. Use the table below to generate TREATS as needed:

ROLL 1D12	DUROSIAN TREATS
1	A cache of wavy-bladed daggers. With a WIS roll, find a MAGICAL one
2	A clockwork frog that comes to life for 1D6 ROUNDS if given a drop of blood
3	An EMBER SCROLL with the BLOOD MIST SPELL
4	An empty iron chest as big as a dwarf with an open padlock
5	Glass vials with congealing goop that is highly adhesive
6	A mirror that creates an illusory body double for 1D4 ROUNDS
7	A jar of steel ball bearings
8	A demon trapped in a glass bottle
9	A book that shoots razor-sharp leaves of paper if shaken
10	1D6 thin, red crystals that each restore 1 HP if snapped in half
11	Goodberrry moss. Harvest 1D6 berries that heal 1D6 when eaten
12	Roll once on the MAGIC LOOT table

CONCLUSIONS

Finding an end in the deep below Duros is no pleasant thing, no matter what that end may be.

ARAS RED FANG VICTORIOUS (AGAIN)

If the heroes are cornered, torn to pieces, or simply can't find a way, Aras Red Fang returns to full power. Do the players become his dark servants? Does he imprison them as a perpetual source of blood? Are they the subjects of some new experiment to bolster his evil army, or will the depths remain silent and forgotten? Keep playing to find out.

REPRIEVE FOR THE LIVING

The dice were kind? The players defeat Aras and Alfheim's greatest enemy is dealt with… for now. Will his incorporeal spirit live on? Will he be confined to Splinter for eternity? Bound in a cursed object? Not easily is Red Fang kept dead. How will the players ensure a brighter future?

A PLACE OF POWER

Destroying the Bloodlit Grotto: Aras is hard to defeat without doing so, but if it survives, it has powerful healing and restorative properties. Can these dark powers be used for good? What other secrets lie behind RED FANG's power? Are there more blood-soaked relics in the depths?

TAKE ALFHEIM IN YOUR HAND

Many GM's feel a justified hesitation in altering 'world history.' Leave this feeling to the grave! This world is the sole property of you and your players TOGETHER, harvesting the very little, easily missed instincts and comments at the table, to terrible effect. The tabletop is the realm of total freedom. USE THAT FREEDOM.

ORVALD'S TOWER

This story starts at its ending.
Can the heroes make it to the final page?

OVERVIEW

A DESPERATE ESCAPE

Orvald the Wizard lies defeated, and our heroes stand at the pinnacle of his mind-bending spire. Now, a magical maelstrom destroys the incredible structure, and the only escape is down.

GM'S BULLETS

Orvald used his final breath to summon a terrible storm that will destroy his tower — and the players!

- The heroic victory over Orvald, while short-lived, restores the heroes to full HP
- The tower collapses in 15 ROUNDS, killing everyone inside
- The storm causes weird, extradimensional effects (see Maelstrom table)

MOMENTS

1: GET INSIDE!

A purple maelstrom churns overhead, its eye centered on the tower's spire. Gale force winds pummel you in the darkening gloom, and lightning blasts the stone mercilessly. The tower's foundations quake under the assault!

- The passage into the tower has collapsed; clear the rubble with one HEART of EFFORT
- A hail of lightning bolts falls every 1D4 ROUNDs. DEX save or MAGIC damage
- Orvald has two MAGIC LOOT on his body

2: WELL OF SOULS

The stairs lead down to an opalescent chamber with a massive stone well in the center. A green vortex of howling specters whirls inside — the souls Orvald imprisoned want their revenge!

- The well compels onlookers to do nothing but walk toward it; break the compulsion with a WIS roll
- Reach the well in 1D4 ROUNDS. Pass a final WIS roll or leap inside!
- The well's dark magic is inscrutable. You might die, transform, teleport, or something worse...
- A Feeder emerges from the well each ROUND to attack players not under compulsion

3: SPIRALING STAIRS

Smoke and inhuman screams echo up the crumbling central spire. The tower shudders, and the spiral stairs splinter and crack. Whole chunks fall away into the darkness below!

- Pass a DEX or STR roll to move; the stairs are DOUBLE FAR in length
- Players who fall make a DEX roll to grab the edge, or else fall to the next platform and take ULTIMATE
- Roll on the Maelstrom table every ROUND
- Every 1D4 TURNS, a vicious cloud of Imps wheels over the players

4: RELEASED FROM BELOW

The central hall is a field of burning rubble, shattered masonry, and falling debris. A rift in the floor separates you from the hall leading out. Gouts of fire erupt from the rift, and Flame Kin begin to climb over the edge!

- 1D4 Flame Kin pour out of the rift every TURN
- The earth shakes violently every 1D4 ROUNDS. Pass a DEX roll or fall down
- Jump the rift with a STR roll or by using debris (chains, twisted metal, charred timbers)

5: MAD DASH

Insert 1 or 2 floors of simple 'crumbling chaos.' Players dash through, with a smattering of hazardous debris. Keep it super simple, and use this as a beat of variety.

6: WARDED DOORS

The jewel-encrusted doors leading from the spire should open easily from inside... but they refuse. Orvald somehow reversed their enchantment! The door's gems flare, and an Avenger materializes before you...

- Each time the Avenger loses a HEART, a glowing door gem fades to darkness
- Players can pry out or damage a door gem to make the Avenger lose a HEART
- The doors open when the Avenger is defeated
- Every 1D4 ROUNDS, roll on the Maelstrom table

TOWER MAPS

RUN FOR THE DOOR

Each floor of Orvald's sanctum is a simple exercise in traversal. Keep it simple, fast moving, and dangerous. After 3 or 4 floors, your heroes will be on a shoestring.

TABLES

MAELSTROM

The magical maelstrom spews terrors and havoc from other dimensions. Roll on the below table to add some extra pressure, or just to remind the players the tower is collapsing:

ROLL 1D12	COLLAPSE AND CHAOS
1	Time warps sickeningly; the tower collapse timer goes down by 1
2	Winged shadows fall from above. Pass an INT roll or be paralyzed by fear on your TURN
3	A luminous cloud of Devil Dust swirls through the room for 1D4 ROUNDS
4	The floor quakes! Pass a DEX roll or fall down
5	Titanic claws punch through the walls! A Hellion attacks at random and withdraws
6	What is that bright light? A Seraph's blessing grants each player a free MOVE
7	Slabs of broken stone tumble down. Pass a DEX roll or take ULTIMATE
8	Reality bends, and all players teleport NEAR in a random direction
9	An Angel appears, heals one player to full HP, and leaps into another dimension
10	Time slows! The tower collapse timer does not change this ROUND
11	Cache revealed! Rubble breaks open a hidden LOOT cache. Roll once on ANCIENT LOOT
12	Tumbling relic. A magical object falls from its glass case. Roll once on MAGICAL LOOT

DOWN AND OUT

20 details that can be found inside the tower of a cruel and powerful arch-magus.

ROLL 1D20	TOWER DISCOVERIES
1	An IMP trapped inside a small, glass dome
2	A huge oil painting of Orvald. He is shown hovering above an open grave
3	A tome of demonology on a reading stand, but scorched and burnt beyond use
4	A wandering GHOST that talks to itself, moving up and down the halls
5	An unstable roof panel falls! Jump away with DEX or be crushed for ULTIMATE
6	Purple cracks and energy the color of the maelstrom running up the walls
7	A chest filled with the crowns of fallen dukes and princes
8	Through cracks in the masonry, a titanic face is forming in the storm clouds
9	A glass display case with several disembodied human hands
10	A soggy rug is scuffed aside to reveal it is soaked in blood
11	A feast table of terrible proportions featuring brains, fried fingers, and spider cakes
12	Casks of blood wine, distilled from various people and animals
13	A stained glass window portrays Orvald ruling the valley with a skull in one hand
14	On a small podium, a miniature brass sculpture shows IRON HEART in amazing detail
15	A dirt-floored area is seeded with tiny YOG fragments, some beginning to grow
16	A rack of staves, swords, pikes and common daggers
17	A flawless, white feather in a vice grip. Releasing the grip lets the feather float slowly up
18	An old harpsichord piano, made from human bone
19	A single opulent gem worth 10,000 COIN
20	A hidden vault pops open, revealing a whirring, clicking metal cube...a MAINFRAME!

CONCLUSION

CONCLUSION

- The players escape: As the heroes flee the main entrance, the entire structure collapses in on itself in a colossal explosion of dust and debris. When it settles, the storm is gone and silence settles on the land. This immense collapse was likely heard for miles in all directions. What ramifications or rewards could await our brave survivors?
- The players don't escape: Do they die in the tower collapse? Does the maelstrom toss them into another dimension? Maybe they dig their way from the rubble only to realize they have been turned into undead ghouls thirsty for flesh. The consequences MUST be dire, but the story doesn't have to end here!

THE RELICS OF ODIUM

This unique adventure/setting was a standalone PDF with its own style. The adventure also introduced gem slotting into ICRPG. Presented here as originally published...

INTRODUCTION

SETTING OUT

Index Card RPG uses LOOT to build, distinguish and evolve its player-characters. RELICS take this concept even further, with GEM TAGS. GEMS provide your group with sharable, findable experience that unlocks options and progression in different ways.

Keep your core classes or discard them for truly fluid GEM-driven character paths. Even combine them! Either way, RELICS of ODIUM assumes your heroes want to claim or evolve the RELICS through adventure, and this is where it all starts.

WHAT IS ODIUM?

The Eyes of Odium was a high-danger dungeon I created more than a year ago to push my players and myself to new levels. Odium is a living titan, an enormous dungeon-creature under Lake Rand.

In all your play ahead, be sure to play with the notion that this dungeon is a living thing with desires, motivations and even vital organs. When in doubt, use that fact as your 'deus-ex-machina.'

Have your players roll or choose below...

HOW IT BEGINS

1. Heroes sent to destroy Odium
2. Heroes stumble across Lake Rand
3. Lizards overrunning countryside
4. Odium calls heroes in dreams
5. Heroes seek remains of lost heroes
6. Heroes drawn by limitless treasure
7. Druid magic compels heroes to help
8. A RELIC calls to one hero to find it

ODIUM IS...

1. Awake and enraged, changing shape
2. Groggy, but beginning to awaken
3. Dormant, but teeming with monsters
4. Malfunctioning and confused
5. Under Zugasha's control
6. Rising out of the lake
7. Damaged and crumbling
8. Dormant, covered in moss and silence

THE RELICS ARE...

1. Granted by King Henryk to start
2. Lost somewhere within Odium
3. Drawn to each other, one already owned
4. Awarded by a mysterious druid
5. Haunting heroes' dreams
6. Lying at the bottom of the lake
7. Being used by a band of frogmen
8. Being horded by Zugasha

WHAT'S AT STAKE

1. Odium will be a force of good if freed
2. If Odium isn't stopped, Alfheim doomed
3. Zugasha wants to claim all 8 RELICS
4. RELICS tearing at reality, contain them
5. Portals in Odium will unleash Iron Heart
6. Harness Odium to fight some greater evil
7. A final errand to make heroes knights
8. Other titans only stopped by Odium

NOTE: Relics of Odium introduces a method of character progression focused on legendary LOOT, but it can also be run as an adventure without this component.
Jump ahead to page 14 for more.

THE RELICS

BINDING

The RELICS hidden and lost in Odium are of such ancient power, and unique magical energy, they not only bind to their owners, and to their gems, but each one is ONE OF A KIND.

There is only one way to break the binding... The owner of a RELIC must perish.

The gravity of this permanence should not be lost on heroes, who must choose with great care how they evolve their precious artifact

RELICS AND GEM TAGS

All of the RELICS in Odium's depths can be made more powerful with the addition of GEMS. These GEMS are often called 'Tears of Odium' as they form in the walls of that vast underground domain.

Each GEM possesses its own magical boost, and in turn each RELIC has specific TAGS therein. Combinations of GEMS, RELICS, and CLASSES create synergistic effects.

All RELICS inflict MAGICAL EFFORT.

BLOOD CRYSTAL: A gem formed from pure life force
Add 1 GEM TAG or gain +1 to any STAT

AMBER TEAR: Ancient sap turned harder than stone
Add 1 GEM TAG or gain +3 ARMOR

OCHRE DIAMOND: Concentrated arcane energy
Add 1 GEM TAG or learn 1D2 SPELLS instantly

EMERALD SPIKE: A razor sharp form of volcanic glass
Add 1 GEM TAG or gain +3 WEAPON EFFORT

FROSTFYRE: Supercompressed ice forms a frozen gem
Add 1 GEM TAG or gain +3 ULTIMATE EFFORT

NOTE: Every RELIC possesses different GEM TAGS. Thus, a single GEM will grant different TAGS to different RELICS.
When a GEM is discovered, there is much to discuss.

SKULLCHOPPER

This is the ultimate blade. Its hilt is hewn from dragon tooth, its quillons hammered from meteor iron. The steel was folded by deep dwellers and its pommel the skull of legendary warrior Rimmelstumskin.

CHOOSE or ROLL 1D3

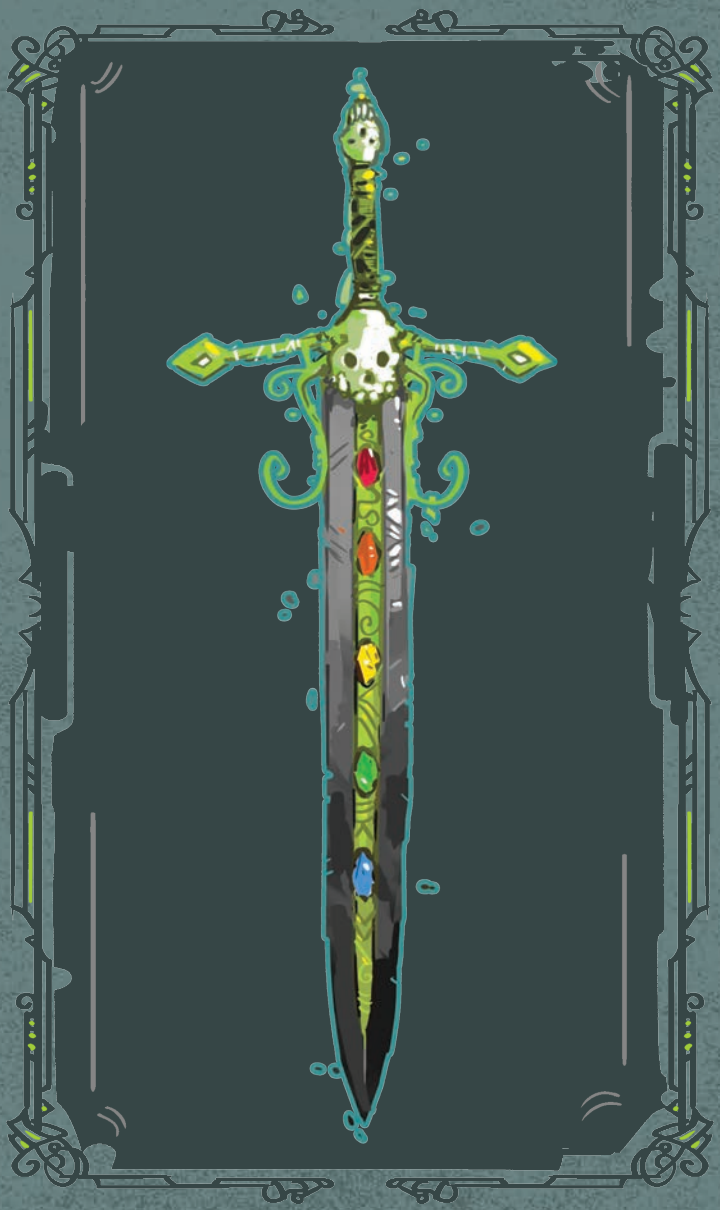
DRINKER: Heal half of damage inflicted
VORPAL: If you deal more than 12 damage in a single hit, inflict D12 more
RAGE: Sacrifice 1-12 HP and add it to your DAMAGE roll

FAST: Add your DEX to your ARMOR
BREAKER: On any hit, choose to destroy 1 item rather than do damage
BANNER: Plant the sword as a banner. Those CLOSE gain +6 ARMOR

NULLIFIER: Foes you harm cannot use MAGIC for 1 ROUND
MIRROR: SPELLS cast at you but failing to hit reflect on their origin
MAGEFYRE: Combine your WEAPON and MAGIC bonuses

RETURN: The sword will fly back into your hand on command
HIDDEN: Stealth is always EASY
DEADBANE: Against the undead, if inflicting 6 or more damage, slay

CLEAVER: Hit 1D4 foes on any attack
SHOCKWAVE: Any natural 20 attack roll damages ALL CLOSE enemies
RIPOSTE: Any CLOSE foe who damages you takes 1D6 damage in return



LION WALL

No bulwark is as unbreakable, or light, or magically imbued, as the famed Lion Wall. This shield is crafted of the same mythic metals as Odium's diamond-hard skin, reforms to fit its master's stance and stature, and emanates an aura of valor. Not even dragon-fire can scathe its surface.

CHOOSE or ROLL 1D3

REBOUND: When hit, inflict 2 damage on your attacker with no roll
SLAM: When shoving with STR, push up to 6 foes to a FAR distance
MIGHTY: HEARTS grant you 15 HP

BRACE: Add your STR to your ARMOR
RESIST: If an attack against you does an odd number, ignore it
BANNER: Plant the shield as a banner. Those CLOSE gain +6 ARMOR

SPELL WALL: MAGIC done against you has its effects halved
MIRROR: SPELLS cast at you but failing to hit reflect on their origin
CORE of POWER: Add MAGIC EFFORT STAT to your ARMOR

DEFLECTOR: Ranged WEAPON attacks only hit you if critical or ULTIMATE
SHROUD: Allies DYING CLOSE to you become instantly stable with no roll
LORD: Good beings honor your command

ROAR: Frighten any in earshot, unless they resist with a CHA roll
FORTRESS: Any time you would be hit for 10+ damage, roll ARMOR to ignore
LION: Take lion form with a WIS roll

GHOST ARROW

The druids of Lake Rand we cunning hunters. From living boughs and magical fibers they crafted their bows. Of these Ghost Arrow was supreme, but was lost in the depths of Odium decades ago. The bow gains it lethal power, and its name, from super strong Ghost Raven feathers at each end.

CHOOSE or ROLL 1D3

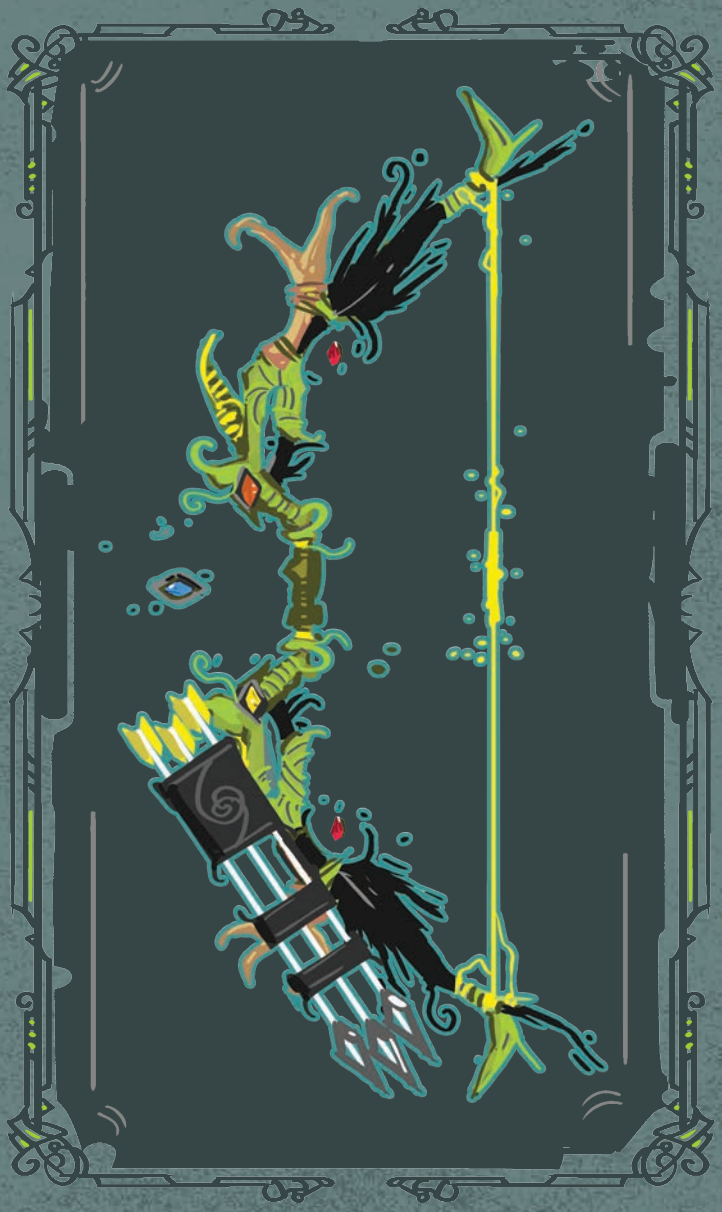
BLUR: Fire as many arrows as your DEX on a single attack roll
VORPAL: If you deal more than 12 damage in a single hit, inflict D12 more
PIERCE: Ignore all damage reduction

FAST: Add your DEX to your ARMOR
EVADE: Per ROUND, dodge 1D4 of any missiles fired at you
FEATHERS: Your gear is very light. Add 10 CARRIED and 10 EQUIPPED slots

SPEED QUIVER: Any attack roll of 13+ lets you roll another attack
SPELL ARROW: Sacrifice 1 SPELL. From now on, it casts on a successful shot
MAGEFYRE: Combine your WEAPON and MAGIC bonuses

SEER: Distance, fog, smoke and weather never inhibit your aim or accuracy
LEAF: You are invisible among trees
BEASTBANE: Against beasts, if inflicting 6 or more damage, slay

BARRAGE: Hit 1D6 foes on any attack
HELD SHOT: For each ROUND you hold a draw, add 1D12 damage if it hits
WINGS: When you move, fly or hover up to 10 feet up from the ground



BLACK CANDLE

This dagger is hammered from black iron and hardened with gold-forged duranium from Aphos. The hilt is a magical candle that burns with a light-drinking 'antiflame.' It is a cunning, devious, and hidden weapon for those who would kill from the shadows.

CHOOSE or ROLL 1D3

STINGER: When attacked, your foes do not know what hit them
VORPAL: If you deal more than 12 damage in a single hit, inflict D12 more
VITALS: Add your INT to your damage

FAST: Add your DEX to your ARMOR
BITE: If your foe has 1 HP, slay them with no attack roll
FLAME: Use as an infinite torch to lower the TARGET by 1 in darkness

SPELLBLADE: Sacrifice 1 SPELL. From now on, it casts on a successful attack
FOCAL: Use a TURN to recover a SPELL burned by a guaranteed cast
KILL UNSEEN: You are never hindered by a foe's invisibility

ANTIFLAME: A shadow follows you everywhere, it has a CLOSE radius
HIDDEN: Stealth is always EASY
SILENCE: Your movements never make sound of any kind unless you wish it

DART: Thrown attacks are never HARD
ERASER: Inflict 8 or more damage, foes suffer amnesia for 1D4 ROUNDS
PRECISE: Score a critical hit on a natural 18, 19, or 20

DRAGON CANNON

The same impossible technology that created Odium also devised this devastating weapon. Exactly how it works has been lost to time, for it not only delivers storms of tiny projectiles, but replenishes them instantly.

CHOOSE or ROLL 1D3

STINGER: When attacked, your foes do not know what hit them
REPLENISH: You never run out of ammunition
SHRED: Hit a foe 4+ times in one TURN, they are slain regardless of HP

DISARM: On a successful attack, choose to disarm a foe instead of damage
COVER: Only a natural 20 will hit you at range if in cover
SPRINT: Even when you MOVE FAR, you can still take an ACTION

CORE of POWER: Add MAGIC EFFORT STAT to your ARMOR
TECH: You use technology, so ignore all anti-magic effects
KILL UNSEEN: You are never hindered by a foe's invisibility

STITCH: Any damage roll of natural 3 or higher explodes
SCARE: When you kill a foe, all other foes must roll CHA or flee for 1 ROUND
SEER: Distance, fog, smoke and weather never inhibit your aim or accuracy

METAGEM: Choose any GEM TAG from any RELIC when socketing this GEM
HYPO BULLET: If you shoot an ally, on purpose or accident, heal them
PRECISE: Score a critical hit on a natural 18, 19, or 20

IRONOAK

Odium's guards are a race of clockwork golems or living armor called Sentinels. It is unknown when or how, but some ancient tinker must have removed or salvaged one of their mighty limbs, and made it a weapon wield-able by men. A true wonder of the 4th realm.

CHOOSE or ROLL 1D3

ARMED: Hold any weapon. Add your STR to your WEAPON DAMAGE
GRABBER: Grappling is always EASY
RAGE: Sacrifice 1-12 HP and add it to your DAMAGE roll

MIGHTY: Add your CON to your STR
HURLER: Throw any object up to your size as if throwing a stone
BOLT ON: All your ARMOR LOOT, combined, only occupy 1 EQUIPPED slot

GROUNDED: If you critically fail a SPELL cast, suffer no ill effects
REACH: Use SPELLS that require TOUCH up to NEAR distance
TECH: You use technology, so ignore all anti-magic effects

STAMINA: Grab and hold as long as needed, no fatigue
CLIMBER: All climbing is always EASY
MACHINE GRUDGE: Mechanical foes seek you out first

CLEAVER: Hit 1D4 foes on any attack
FINDER: If a GEM is found, you sense another somewhere nearby
RESOLVE: Pop up from DYING on a natural 19 or 20

ANVIL STONE

Most of Odium is built from solid granite. While these mighty stones were quarried, a vein of super-hardened rock was discovered. The hardest of this was hewn, with effort, into the mightiest warhammer in Alfheim.

CHOOSE or ROLL 1D3

IMPACT: On a hit, knock foes to NEAR
DAZE: On 12+ damage, stun your foe for 1D4 ROUNDS
RAGE: Sacrifice 1-12 HP and add it to your DAMAGE roll

BLOCKADE: +3 ARMOR
BREAKER: On any hit, choose to destroy 1 item rather than do damage
INSPIRE: Plant the hammer as a banner. Those CLOSE gain +3 STR

HOLY: Always roll ULTIMATE when using healing magic
STORM: You are immune to lightning magic and effects of lightning
VALOR: Your allies only fail fear rolls on a natural 1

RETURN: The hammer will fly back into your hand on command
STONEGUT: CON rolls are always EASY
DEADBANE: Against the undead, if inflicting 6 or more damage, slay

CLEAVER: Hit 1D4 foes on any attack
WINGS: When you move, fly or hover up to 10 feet up from the ground
CHASM: Do 10+ damage against floors or bedrock to open a deep fissure FAR

EZEKIEL'S KEY

The famed wizard Ezekiel stored most of his creations in The Tower of Shadows, under the watchful eyes of Anaxamon. This legendary staff, though, found its way into the depths of Odium, and there waits for a new master.
It is a living thing, always changing...

CHOOSE or ROLL 1D3

PYRO: Double effects of fire magic
RAW POWER: Use a D12 as your MAGIC EFFORT die
POOL: Store and use 10 HP in this GEM either to absorb damage or cast SPELLS

WILL: Add your INT to your ARMOR
ARC: On a critical hit cast, your SPELLS leap to 1D4 more targets
AURA: Plant the staff as a banner. Those CLOSE gain +3 MAGIC EFFORT

MASTERMIND: Always use a D12 for EFFORT when creating SPELLS
LINGUIST: Always use a D12 when translating or deciphering
DEADLY: If your attack reduces a foe to 1 HP, their are slain

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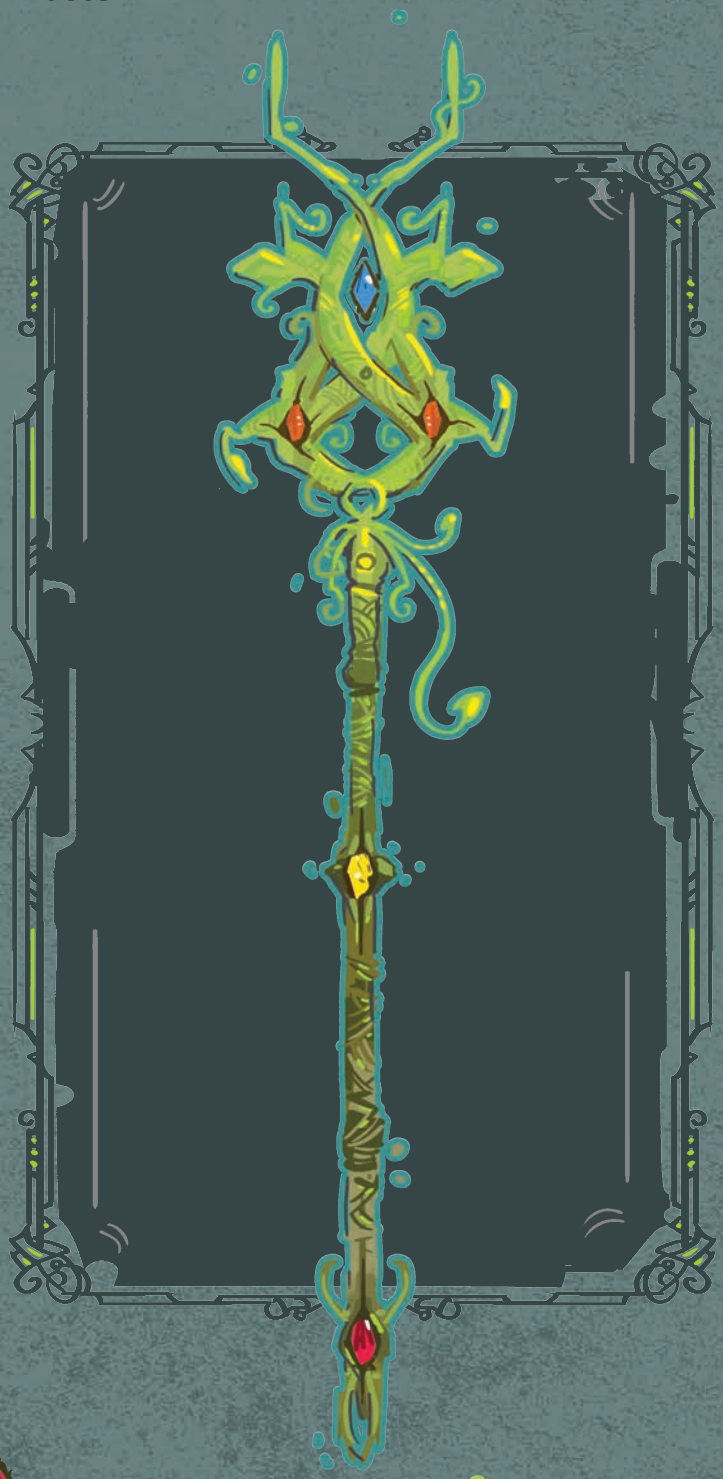
SEEDS: When using any form of plant MAGIC, no roll is needed to cast
LEAF: Weigh no more than a single leaf
TREEMIND: Gain or create 1 WIS POWER after every session

METAGEM: Choose any GEM TAG from any RELIC when socketing this GEM
FINDER: If a GEM is found, you sense another somewhere nearby
RAYS: Use any SPELL at any range



THE ODIUM BATTLE WORLD

Here are 20 key locations you can select with a die roll.

1: King's Road Fen
2: Druid Circle
3: Upper Lake Rand
4: Rand Woods
5: Misty Falls
6: Dock Meadows
7: Grey Crags
8: Fishman Beach
9: Druid Island
10: Shipwreck
11: Henson's Farm
12: Odium's Hand
13: Hidden Beach
14: Dead Lagoon
15: Court of Runes
16: The Great Stair
17: The Workings
18: Breath of Odium
19: Odium's Eye
20: Underlake

ODIUM AND LAKE RAND LOCATIONS

A D20 can be used to select an area for enemy appearances, gear caches, or hidden clues. These descriptions also include brief notes on encounters.

1: King's Road Fen: Players arrive on this small swampy land mass, and confront the abundant and predatory raptor lizard herd. This herd is vast, and just keeps coming.

2: Druid Circle: Druids have worshiped the titan Odium here for centuries.

3: Upper Lake Rand: A smaller lake with a barren bottom. Lurking fishman scouts.

4: Rand Woods: Dense, dark, vine-choked woods. Ghosts of dead heroes.

5: Misty Falls: A huge waterfall concealing the West entrance. A long way down.

6: Dock Meadows: This area offers an open battlefield or place of rest. The dock nearby is home to fishman dingies, piles of fish guts, spare nets and more.

7: Grey Crags: Huge blocks of rain-slick granite with narrow passes and cold fog.

8: Fishman Beach: A village where fishmen gather, all part of an ancient and ruthless Odium cult that secretly serves the dark intentions of druid folk.

9: Druid Island: A sacred place that conceals an entrance to the Halls of Odium. Druids will attack anyone who sets foot here.

10: Shipwreck: A long lost expedition from Grey. Lots of LOOT opportunity. Ghosts.

11: Henson's Farm: Old Henson has lived here for years, mostly unnoticed by the druids.

12: Odium's Hand: Enter the vast interior of Odium the titan here.

13: Hidden Beach: A small boat landing hidden in the hills. Underwater entrance.

14: Dead Lagoon: The main entrance to the Halls of Odium is littered with skeletons.

15: Court of Runes: A place of worship for Odium, and a system of runes that power it.

16: The Great Stair: Odium's chest is a colossal set of terraces.

17: The Workings: Time has exposed some of the mechanical interior of the titan. These could potentially be tampered with to control or disable the giant.

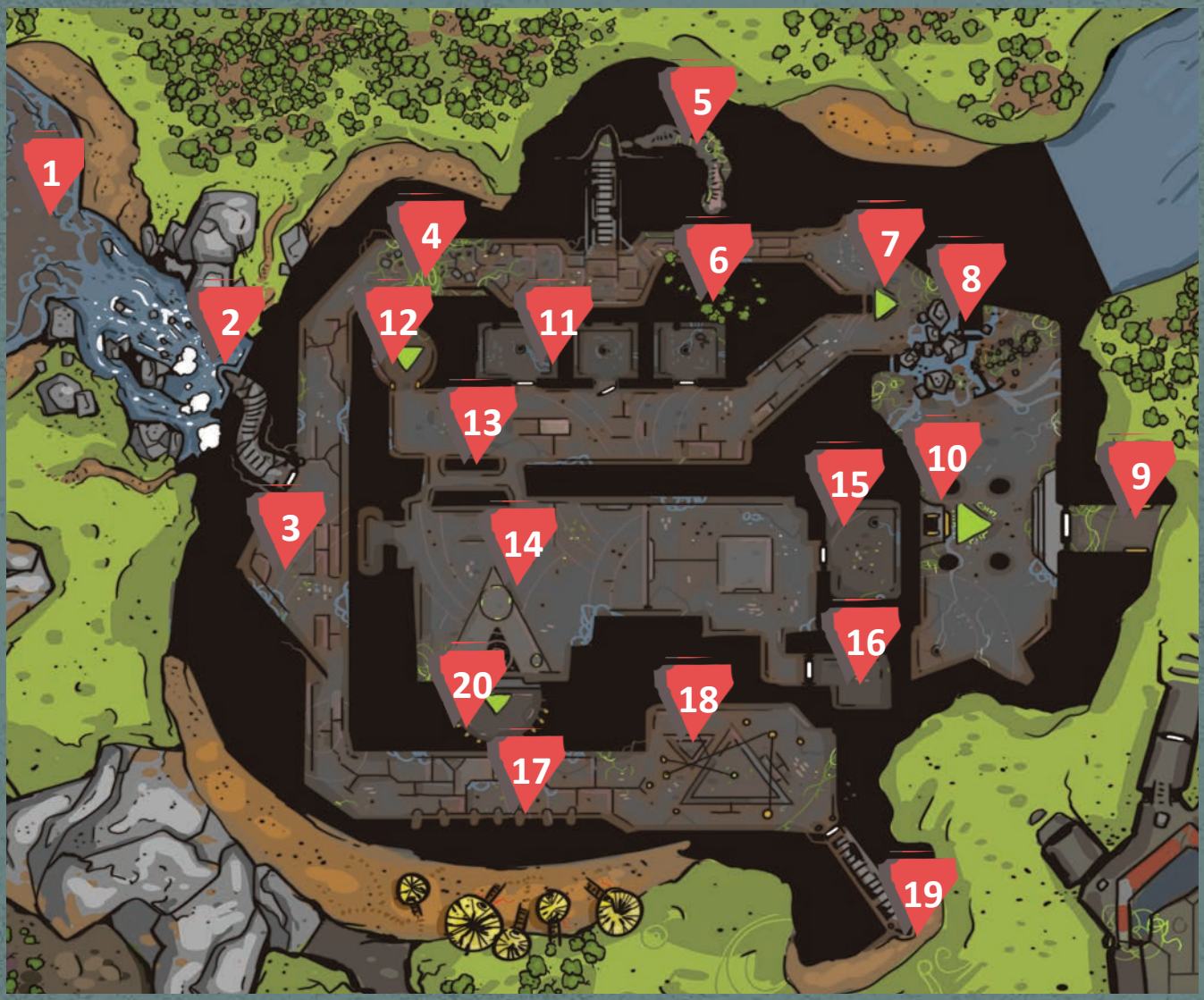
18: Breath of Odium: A cold, vaporous wind flows in these massive vents.

19: Odium's Eye: Odium's slowly waking consciousness is centered here. So are its most powerful energy weapons, booming voice, and terrible mind-invasion powers.

20: Underlake: Beneath Lake Rand lies the vast complex called Halls of Odium.

HALLS OF ODIUM

Beneath Lake Rand is a series of chambers that are, in some mysterious way, part of Odium the titan. It is a wet, dead place with many secrets.



1: Upper Lake Dry
2: Falls Entrance
3: Fish Man Camp
4: Vine Beast
5: Forest Entrance
6: Spore Pods
7: Energy Pylon
8: Cave In Area
9: Main Entrance
10: Throne Room
11: Prison Cells
12: Energy Pylon
13: Stelae
14: Portal Hall
15: Direhorn Kennel
16: Zugasha's Chamber
17: Hall of the Dead
18: The Odium Codex
19: Odium Entrance
20: Zugasha's Pylon

HALLS OF ODIUM LOCATIONS

A D20 can be used to select areas for enemy appearances, gear caches, or hidden clues.

1: Upper Lake Dry: If players have swimming abilities, or manage to drain the upper lake, they find a lakebed rich in treasure. This will enrage fishman and druid alike.

2: Falls Entrance: Beneath the crashing falls, a slick stone door is hidden.

3: Fishman Camp: The fishmen gather here for cooking, planning, and arguing.

4: Vine Beast: The vines in this corridor have grown impossibly thick, and Odium's magical aura has made them predatory, powerful things.

5: Forest Entrance: The druids guard this secret entrance in the darkest woods.

6: Spore Pods: A bloom of poisonous fungus have choked this hallway.

7: Energy Pylon: A magical pad that harbors Odium's power. Also used as a teleport pad by Zugasha in desperate times.

8: Cave-In Area: The ship above ripped the ceiling open here with its anchor.

9: Main Entrance: A grand, decorative hall from the days when a wizard ruled Odium.

10: Throne Room: With powerful magic, Odium can be 'piloted' here.

11: Prison Cells: The enemies of the Odium cult were kept here, and they are now undead.

12: Energy Pylon: Another magical charging/teleport pad.

13: Stelae: These huge slabs of rock are carved with a pictorial history of Odium.

14: Portal Hall: The core of Odium's power is a portal to IRON HEART. This is Zugasha's secret prize, and she will do anything to protect it.

15: Direhorn Kennel: Zugasha keeps several of the giant beasts as pets.

16: Zugasha's Chamber: A small room used to regenerate her power.

17: Hall of the Dead: Wall grottoes contain the remains of great heroes who have fallen in their quest to explore Odium, or claim its RELICS.

18: The Odium Codex: This massive room shows the cosmic forces that must align to create or destroy a creature like Odium.

19: Odium Entrance: A large staircase that exits the dungeon into Odium's gaze.

20: Zugasha's Pylon: Where Zugasha gathers power from the portal.

NPC'S

LEAF

The druids of Lake Rand are truly neutral stewards of the ancient giant. They follow no moral code beyond that of guarding the natural order in this area. Leaf is their leader, and she has deceived many doomed delvers into believing she is good-hearted, in need of aid, or gullible, only to lure them to their deaths.

"Please, help me find my missing sister! She's gone down into a terrible cavern..."

"You lot are mighty indeed. Know you of the Relics of Odium? They await the strong, but I will never see them..."

REGINOLD HENSON

Old Reginold has set up a turnip farm in the fog, and he's as stubborn as a mule. He's no friend of the druids OR the fishmen, but does not actively work against them. He helps travelers lost in the crags, but only reluctantly, and with dire warnings.

"Up here, you fools! What in hells are you doing in these hills?"

"I'll only help ye if ye mean to leave these parts. Only death up north, only death at the feet of the giant."

BLOOD GILL

The lake and surrounding areas are crawling with predatory fishmen. Their tribal leader is Blood Gill, a cunning hunter and master of water tactics. He will hunt the heroes as trophies or food.

"Dirt walkers! Be gone or die!"

"This is no place for men and their steel skins! You will meet you end in the mud!"

GILSUNDER'S GHOST

A famed knight of Grey, Gilsunder came to find his missing brother, and found death at Zugasha's hands. Now his specter lingers here, hoping to help those who would destroy Zugasha and end the threat of Odium forever.

"Do not flee, adventurers! I am no wraith, but the ghost of a fallen knight..."

"Though I can't believe Odium is evil, his power is too great to be contained. It threatens all Alfheim."

"This way, heroes! I can cloud Zugasha's magical stare, but only for a short time!"

"At last, I can rest. You've freed me, my friends. May the light of Udin fall on you."

NOTE: Use the NPC's and locations here, or your own additions, to explain, award or conceal the RELICS.

MONSTERS

FISH MEN

Fish men are the most common enemy in this adventure. Mix up their gear and abilities to keep players guessing. Occasionally throw in a giant mutant, camouflage or super skilled one to escalate challenge.

- Dim witted
- Appearing in great numbers
- Drawn to sound
- Hungry for food/prey
- Primitive equipment
- Terrible smell

VINE BEAST

Anywhere the map indicates a dense pack of coiling vines, consider assailing players with a huge carnivorous plant. These vines can split stone, grow to incredible size, and never give up on prey.

- Vulnerable to fire
- Cannot be killed
- Grow into corridors as block or timer
- Entangle doors
- Leave behind poison wounds
- Can be harvested for venom

DIREHORNS

What a horror to contain a plains beast in a dank, silent dungeon. Thus, these Direhorns are partially undead, filled with fury, and imbued with Odium's immense magical power. Make them super deadly, relentless, and immune to most forms of damage.

- Obey Zugasha's will
- Crumble walls with charging impact
- Immune to common weapons
- Appear alone or in two's
- Undead

THE DEAD

Throughout the adventure, use zombies, skeletons and other animated dead to tell back story, enhance gloom, and attack heroes at every turn. These are the fallen adventurers who have been killed by traps, fish men and Zugasha herself.

- Enchanted to kill all intruders
- Waiting in grottoes and fissures
- Some have magical equipment
- Carry clues to their demise

NOTE: Always feel free to add monster variety or detail to fit your Odium experience. Just be sure to use them to reveal the dark and deadly past of this area with their details or attacks!

Zugasha

Queen of the Dead

Zugasha is a vampire of the highest order, an undead form of druidic matriarch. This combination makes her a terribly dangerous and powerful foe.

Zugasha dwells here for many reasons:

- A perfect place to lure victims, who seek the RELICS
- She feeds off of Odium's immense power at the Energy Pylons
- She commands a legion of dead things here, which pleases her

Zugasha is a sort of fungal vampire, having dwelled in the damp so long. This gives her unusual powers and tactics.

- Teleport to any Energy Pylon at will
- Emit mind-controlling blood spores
- Control and conjure beasts and plants
- Immune to plant or nature magic
- Immune to non magical attacks
- Regenerate very fast
- Can only be killed by destroying her 'nutrient chamber'

"Welcome, heroes, to death's home."

"I will drink your souls for eternity!"

"I have long yearned for a husband to feed upon. You will do."

A Lost Soul

Zugasha may seem like pure evil, but a bit of good role play can make things far more interesting. Consider her loneliness in this tomb, her search for a companion, or the pain of being crushed by Odium's power.

Here are a few ideas for ways to deliver these nuances to players:

- If contained in an anti-magic field of adequate power, Zugasha reveals herself to be Odium's prisoner, pining for centuries in a private hell

- Consider using Leaf as an illusory form of Zugasha, a lovely young druid girl to lure victims and companions to her lair. Reveal this at a crucial moment where Leaf's help is needed.

- Perhaps Zugasha appears early in the adventure, and begs for defeat. If players can overcome her, Odium becomes truly enraged, employing every asset in the module to kill the heroes.

- Zugasha has ruled here for centuries. Maybe her lures are all to find a replacement, so she can finally rest from the tortuous influence of Odium. One of the heroes is her choice to do so.

NOTE: Never worry about overpowering an arch-vampire. They are almost utterly undefeatable if built properly. Make her fast, magical, infinite, immortal. Pull no vampiric punches!

WORLD ENDER

By whatever means your version of the adventure reveals, Odium awakens at last, and rises from Lake Rand in a seismic destruction of legend.

The titan has awaited this for centuries, and now must carry out its dark purpose: to cleanse Alfheim of men and towers and civilization. To return the land to its primitive state, and restore a quiet balance of nature and beast.

This could propose a new set of adventures as players work to stop it, control it, or warn the cities of men of coming doom. Go with what you players THINK will happen and embrace the chaos. THE DECIMATION has come...

ULTIMATE SERVANT

A truly different outcome of this adventure could be that the heroes find a way to turn, communicate with or even control the titan called Odium.

Given such an immense power, what will the heroes do? What errand could call for such titanic force? Are other titans awakened by this event? Do the titans clash or coexist?

Many new questions should arise if this path is followed, and there will be no peace for heroes in command of such power.

CROSSROADS

A simple encounter in a simple town.
This time, though, it's just plain rotten luck.

OVERVIEW

ROOM INTRO

Every town has the potential to become a no-win scenario for players and their band of heroes. The confines of buildings and streets are terribly complex, and the ever-present city guard numbers in the dozens or hundreds. It all makes a perfect recipe to challenge them, and force some exciting dilemmas, like this one.

ESSENTIALS

The streets are quiet by early evening, save the moans of the changelings at the docks. Word of an uprising has spread to the elven King's ears, and a division of guards prowls for anyone causing a stir. Normally, none of it would matter, but your company is here to defy the King and free the city. It's going to be a long night.

TIMERS: Time limits here are less about spike damage and more about the threat of imprisonment.

- The good folk are being experimented on. 1D4 of them changes or dies per TIMER
- Guards patrol the streets in squads, arriving on TIMERS. They are D12 in number
- If dawn comes and the antidote hasn't been found, the city will be lost...consider this a session or 'world' TIMER

THREATS: Normal citizens are the secret friends of our heroes. Everything else is out to kill or capture them.

- Sentry guards: armored pike-men in terrible numbers, generally set on imprisoning
- Mechanized guards: huge steam-powered monsters sent to kill
- Changelings: lycanthropic ravagers who obey the King

TREATS: A large town intersection is a playground of unspoken details and possible strategies for creative players. Here are a few bits to help them out.

- In here! Helpful citizens offer hidey holes
- Shops and larders hold LOOT
- Rooftops, hay carts, and awnings can be used to hide, leap, or elude

MECHANICAL

1: THE CHANGE

- The evil King or lord of this city is delivering a serum to the populace. This induces a terrible change, making them into ravenous killers!
- The procedure is done out in the open on several street corners
- Rumor has spread of an antidote in the possession of a wise, and well hidden, old Alchemist named Varminster

2: ALL THE KING'S MEN

- Be sure to keep a realistic handle on how city guards would work. They seldom fight to the death. Their priority is always calling reinforcements. When groups move in, keep 2 or 3 in the rear, at safe retreat distance. Force players to account for it, rather than just killing them en masse
- For any sentry group being engaged in battle, every ROUND, be sure to mention at least one of them blowing a war horn. If a war horn is blown twice, the number of guards will double the following ROUND
- With capture as such a likely outcome, be ready with a simple jail/dungeon space. Be BRUTAL with how well guarded and fortified it is. Even foreshadowing the impressive jail of this town as a set piece could help sell the gravity of being locked up

CROSSROADS
HOMES
HOMES
SLUM ALLEY
MAIN PATROL ROUTE
HOMES
TAVERN
CROWDS
CARTS
MECHANIZED PATROL ROUTE
FOUNTAIN
CHANGELING TABLE
CHANGELING LAB
CHANGELING SPAWN
ARTISAN SHOPS
JAIL
IRON DOOR
DESK
TOWN RECORDS
= IRON BARS
X= GUARD
= UNDER GROUND

WHAT NEXT?

ROYAL WRATH

One possible outcome could be the heroes finding Varminster, distributing the antidote, eluding capture and helping the changelings. In this case, the following dawn will not bring reprieve, but a vicious counter attack by the elven King. No longer will the dark lord rely on mere guards, but send a dark anti-knight and his lycanthrope minions to end the heroes. This anti-knight will not stop until his deadly goal is achieved, and can only be dissuaded by destroying the evil King himself.

OVERRUN

IF the players tarry too long, fail too many times, or never find Varminster, the city is overrun with changelings by dawn. They form an unbeatable army, and flow out of the city to annihilate their neighbors. The heroes now face a far greater threat, on a larger scale, for their next session.

NUCLEAR OPTION

If players see that they will be overrun or defeated, they might elect to destroy the city as a measure to stop the changeling swarm. This option could be mentioned by Varminster, or a helpful citizen. It could also be suggested by subtle clues including stacks of explosive barrels, or a vast reserve of lantern oil. If they choose this route without evacuating the normal folk, the death toll will be horrible, and the heroes will be considered enemies of mankind until they can prove otherwise.

THE CITADEL

If players manage to stem the change, elude or defeat the guards, and are generally victorious, they may elect to assault the King in his sanctum next. Here's your chance for a classic castle crawl, complete with reclusive supernatural lord and all manner of demonic knights and experimental beasts.

MINOTAUR BRIDGE

Bridges always present a focused, unavoidable challenge.
Turn it up a few notches with this precarious push to the next room.

OVERVIEW

ROOM INTRO

Between where the heroes just were, and where they're headed, place this obstacle. A great gulf, chasm, or fissure is spanned by a hefty stone bridge. The far end is guarded by a furious Minotaur and two scorpion-style arbalests. The near side has bountiful cover. This is one case where a frontal assault will end in disaster.

ESSENTIALS

The wind rushes ahead, revealing a dark-bottomed chasm. The breech is spanned by a heavy stone bridge of elder days, and watched over by a horned creature at the far end. The burning eyes, brass-ringed nose and massive musculature are a distraction. It's the massive double-bladed battle axe that catches what light there is. There is no other way forward.

TIMERS: Three things will push them:

- A cloud of incendiary ash and choking smoke fills the area. The fire they started has grown out of control
- The ritual is under way somewhere ahead. If they tarry, an age of doom will fall
- The fisherman-made-king has delver venom in his thigh, and time is running out to save him, and the throne he belongs on

THREATS: The sentinels here are formidable, but the long drop is the real danger.

- A minotaur, bound to stand guard here
- Twin arbalests (giant siege crossbows) and their operators
- A long fall on either side of decaying stone rails that are all too low

TREATS: This encounter is ruthless, but there are a few hidden gems.

- If the arbalests could be taken, they could be powerful weapons to use
- Old lantern pillars offer effective cover
- The biggest treat players can use here is the clumsy rage of the minotaur

MECHANICAL

1: KORD THE MINOTAUR

- Kord was once a great warrior of Duradin, but he has been transformed and bound by powerful magic
- Kord carries a Great Cleaver's Axe. This weapon can hit ALL CLOSE TARGETS on a successful attack
- Kord will charge if provoked with CHA or good role play. When he charges, he will not only damage those failing to evade, but if circumstances are right, a failed DEX roll will send heroes flying off the narrow bridge
- If unprovoked, Kord will remain with his troops and hunker down
- See page 117 in the **ICRPG CORE 2e** for more. Kord is no ordinary Minotaur. He takes 2 ACTIONS per TURN

2: ARBALEST OPERATORS

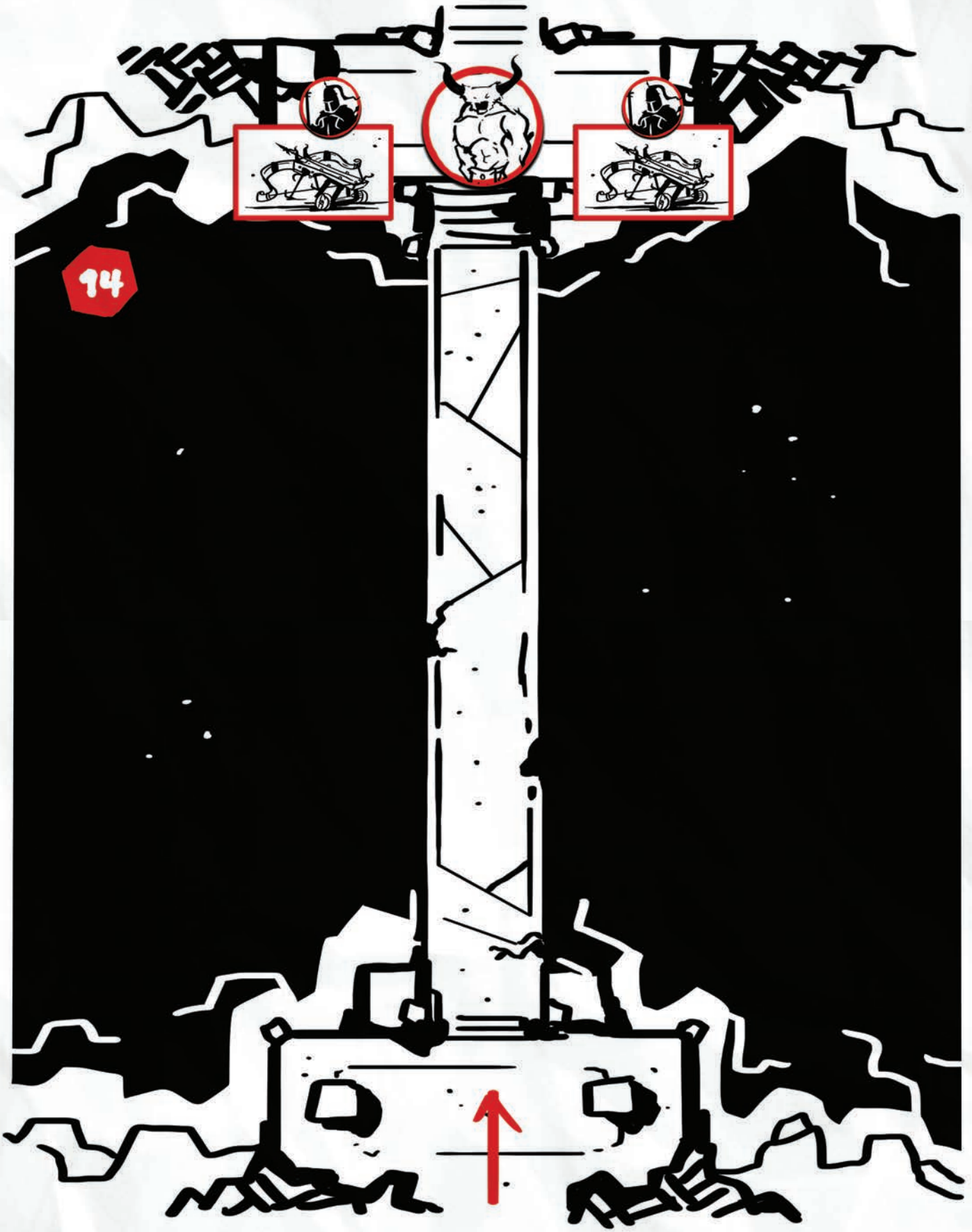
- Arbalests hit for ULTIMATE damage
- They take 1 ROUND to reload
- Each operator is a human warrior, +2 all rolls
- Arbalests are built in place, but can be turned

3: THE ANCIENT BRIDGE

- Three huge pillars support the bridge, disappearing far below in distant gloom
- One pillar is somewhat weakened with age
- There are almost no rails
- The bridge is only 8 feet wide
- If impacted by explosives or heavy force, the bridge will begin to crumble in 1D4 ROUNDS

4: HOWLING WIND

- Amplify the challenge level by adding an erratic, gusty wind through the fissure
- The wind blows every 1D4 ROUNDS
- Use D12 as a 'clock reading' to determine wind direction
- All creatures not secured or safely sheltered must roll STR or be pushed NEAR with the howling gust
- The wind only blows on the GM turn, and only for a moment, then roll the timer again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WHAT NEXT?

HERO REVEALED

If and when Kord is defeated, he will revert to his original human form as he breathes his last. He was once a great knight of Duradin, friend to the dwarves, and loyal subject of Ramthas.

Heroes at this moment, unlike many monster deaths, can choose to heal Kord and help him recover. This comes with revelations and new opportunities for the story to take new directions.

- Kord does not return to his Minotaur form when healed, but keeps his STATS and Axe.
- Kord's gratitude to the heroes is infinite. He will pledge himself to them if they desire, fighting even to the death to honor his life bond.
- Use Kord as a voice to reveal more about your specific dungeon or events ahead. Give him complete knowledge of the enemy, and be generous with players!
- Kord is despondent as time goes on. His wife Elsa has been taken by whatever primary villain you have ahead in your story. Kord will not directly ask the party to risk their lives to help him, but until he saves her he will never smile, joke or laugh.
- Finally, Kord has knowledge that other good fighting men are being transformed into bull warriors. This can be happening nearby as a dungeon side chute, or be a separate adventure entirely, if the players choose to help these poor cursed souls.

WHAT'S DOWN THERE

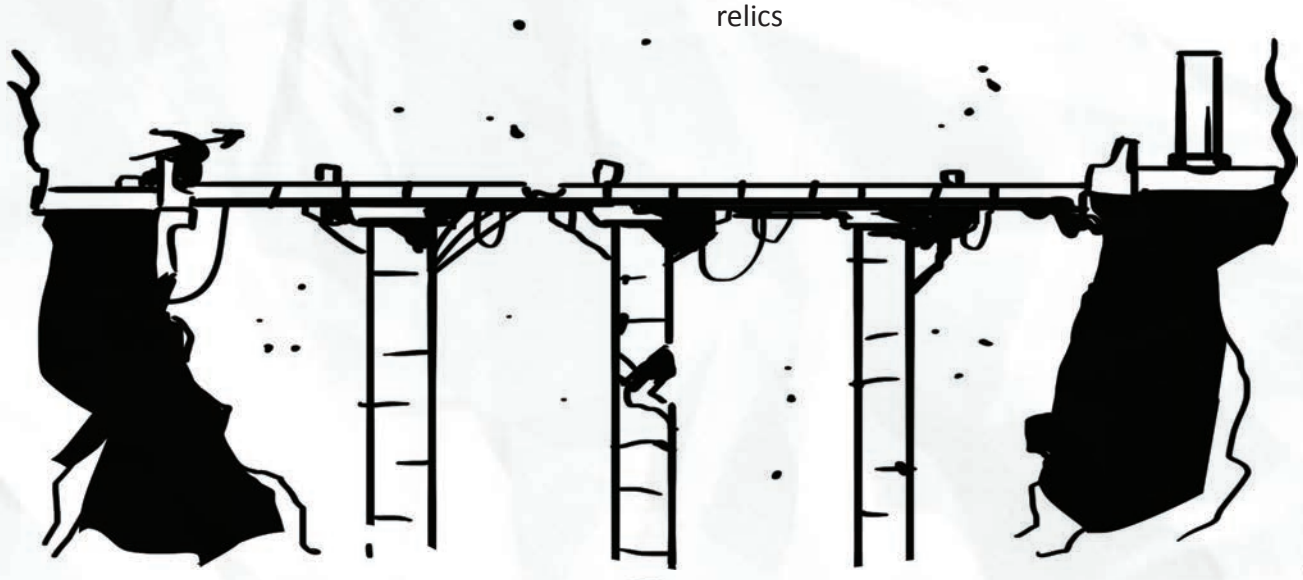
Falling off the bridge into the abyss may not be lethal. It can lead to an entirely new offshoot to your adventure path if players find a way to survive the plunge.

- Mud-soaked frog warrens and tunnels lead back up to the main levels. One among them is a truly old, hungry monster who can swallow men whole
- If deep enough, the chasm reveals rivulets of lava and a series of wide cracks and gaps in the stone. Fire folk and Fire Salamanders dwell here.
- Why not go classic? SPIDERS! Fill a cave set with spider webs and egg sacs, but twist the tone with a pious, gentle mother spider who only wants to survive. Can she be communicated with?

CLUES IN THE STONE

The bridge, regardless of its final state as the encounter concludes, holds subtle clues about the overall setting. These can be discovered with WIS rolls, or simply revealed by you to draw players forward.

- This place was built ages ago by dwarves. They have hidden tiny etchings. They are slogans of freedom and rebellion. They must have been enslaved
- The weaknesses in this masonry can be found elsewhere in the 'dungeon' and exploited to topple or ruin structures
- The stones show signs of duranium tools. Some stones hewn like warm butter. IF such tools can be found somewhere ahead, they would be mighty relics



THE MYRE MINERS

Rescue missions often suffer from too-much-to-do and not-enough-time. Dwarves hate being rescued, but that's what you're in for.

THE MYRE MINERS

ROOM INTRO

Somewhere in YOUR game world, place a small mountain town called Abbey's Gate. The town sits at the base of Myre Canyon. Far up this gorge is the remote Myre Abbey, a now-ruined refuge once occupied by the Holy Sisters of Andal. This encounter takes place en-route to the old abbey, as players must unravel the mystery there. The canyon's river is also infested with frog-headed 'river folk' who abide no intruders.

ESSENTIALS

The curving canyon has partially collapsed up ahead, clogged with giant boulders. Sheer walls prevent any go-around. Behind you, the frog-eyed river folk approach with spears and nets. You are trapped!

TIMERS: One timer is your way out, the other two spell certain doom

- Boulders tumble from above
- A huge River Hulk joins the battle
- The Myre Miners break through more rubble, allowing forward progress

THREATS: A previous encounter with river folk makes a perfect preamble for the tension here

- River folk spear fighters
- River Hulk behemoths
- Falling boulders

TREATS: The natural environment can always be exploited by those of keen eye

- Discover healing good berries
- The miners have a stash of gear chests

MECHANICAL

1: RIVER FOLK ONSLAUGHT

- Spawn 1D6 river folk every ROUND. They appear lower in the canyon, and come shambling up in a rage
- When one of your TIMERS runs out, add a huge river hulk to the fight. They are yelling in froggish. If translated, they warn that no one may approach the old abbey

2: MINER ANTICS

- Boot, Tibble and Scratch are three Durosian dwarves caught in the boulder fall. They are working hard to break their way free, hell bent on reaching the abbey to plunder its riches.
- On a ROUND where all three dwarves succeed on their mining roll, remove one barricade of rubble. Roll a +2 ATTEMPT on the TARGET for each of them in this way. If one or more of them is killed, players can substitute
- The Myre Miners also fight if called to. They use short swords and crossbows.
- Be sure to include lots of wacky, fun lines for these boisterous, blue-collar, gar-chugging miners!

3: UNSTABLE CLIFFS

- Climbing or using the canyon walls can worsen the barricade effect. If players meddle with the walls twice or more, tumble down an additional barricade.

TO MYRE ABBEY
BARRICADE 3
BARRICADE 2
MINERS
BARRICADE ①
TO ABBEY'S GATE

WHAT NEXT?

THE HAUNTED ABBEY

Decades ago, the goodly nuns and monks that lived here suddenly vanished. Since then, the river folk have been proliferating in the canyon. The frog people worship some creature they claim lives in the old ruins... a creature created by the nuns themselves. Players may be seeking to fully explore/plunder or put a stop to the abbey and its dark presence. This makes for a perfect dungeon run or mini-campaign.

RIVER FOLK DISGUISE

If the players use magic or river folk body parts to disguise themselves, the froggy folk of Myre River re very easy to fool. This will let them bypass a few combat scenes, and even gain easy entry to the abbey. The dwarves, however, will take kindly to such dreadful tactics.

XIL'HUL THE ABOMINATION

The nuns and monks of Myre were heretics. They used their good reputation to secretly 'harvest' Abbey's Gate innocents for their experiments. These experiments culminated in the creation of a tentacle-face mind-eater called Xil'Hul. This being quickly killed and devoured its creators, and now broods in the cold dark of Myre Abbey, plotting more doom to the world it hates.

Xil'Hul is a very powerful sorcerer and dimension traveler, and cannot easily be defeated. So mighty is this hidden devil, consider an entire story arc or campaign to defeat it.

A DWARVEN VOW

The Myre Miners can befriend the heroes, or fall out of their favor. This is a truly open-ended element of this story piece. Use the dwarves' friendship as a hook for later adventure, continuation of the Xil-Hul story, or revenge arc. Never lightly is the friendship of dwarves gained or lost!

HAIRPIN GATE

Deep below the Wildwood, where fungi rules,
a band of heroes faces a particularly difficult convergence of events.

HAIRPIN GATE

ROOM INTRO

This space is bent in half to maximize player travel distance in a contained area. Characters are faced with rounding the sharp corner without being detected, then trigger a rapid gate closure that will make things very unpleasant.

Rooms like this can be used in any contained tunnel, corridor, or even city street type environment. The key is utilizing the corner and the gate to make any combat that may occur exciting and surprising, as well as offering a stealth option to more devious players.

I've populated this tunnel with neutral Mykonoid warriors, downright nasty gnomish guards, and mindless giant insects for good measure. The real formula to get best gameplay is a neutral population, and evil (intelligent) population and an evil (unintelligent) group. This mixture gives players a waide array of possible approaches.

ESSENTIALS

Up ahead, the tunnel bends sharply out of sight. The darkness obscures movement up ahead, but the near section of tunnel drips with egg sac ooze and loose soil in a foreboding way. The gnomish patrols will come through soon, what will you do?

TIMERS: Three things will push them:

- Gnomish patrols come up from the rear
- Insect spawn will become deadly
- The gate, once closed, will be very difficult to get past

THREATS: This room does not feature any environmental hazards, only monsters:

- Gnomish mecha
- Giant insects
- Mykonoids (if angered or harmed)

TREATS: Only very clever players will utilize these delicate treat elements:

- Making allies of the Mykonoids
- Stealing or using Gnomish Battle Armor

MECHANICAL

1: INSECT AMBUSHERS

- If the loose soil is disturbed, or loud noises made, 1D6 giant roaches and millipedes burrow into the starting area and attack.
- Single giant bugs, 1 HEART, +2 all STATS except EFFORT. Give them a BITE WEPON and a sticky WEB GOO ranged attack. They behave as mindless feeders, dangerous only in numbers.
- Swarm! If players get a 6 on a spawn roll, spawn a swarm of nasty biting roaches. Swarm rules can be found on p. 125 of CORE 2E.

2: MYKONOID DENIZENS

- At the bend ahead, 3 Mykonoids are standing. They can be allies or enemies, depending on player actions.
- Mykonoids only speak their own language.
- They hate the gnomes, but don't want to die fighting them
- Mykonoid rules can be found in the 'Mercury Dale' adventure module

3: GNOMISH GUARDS

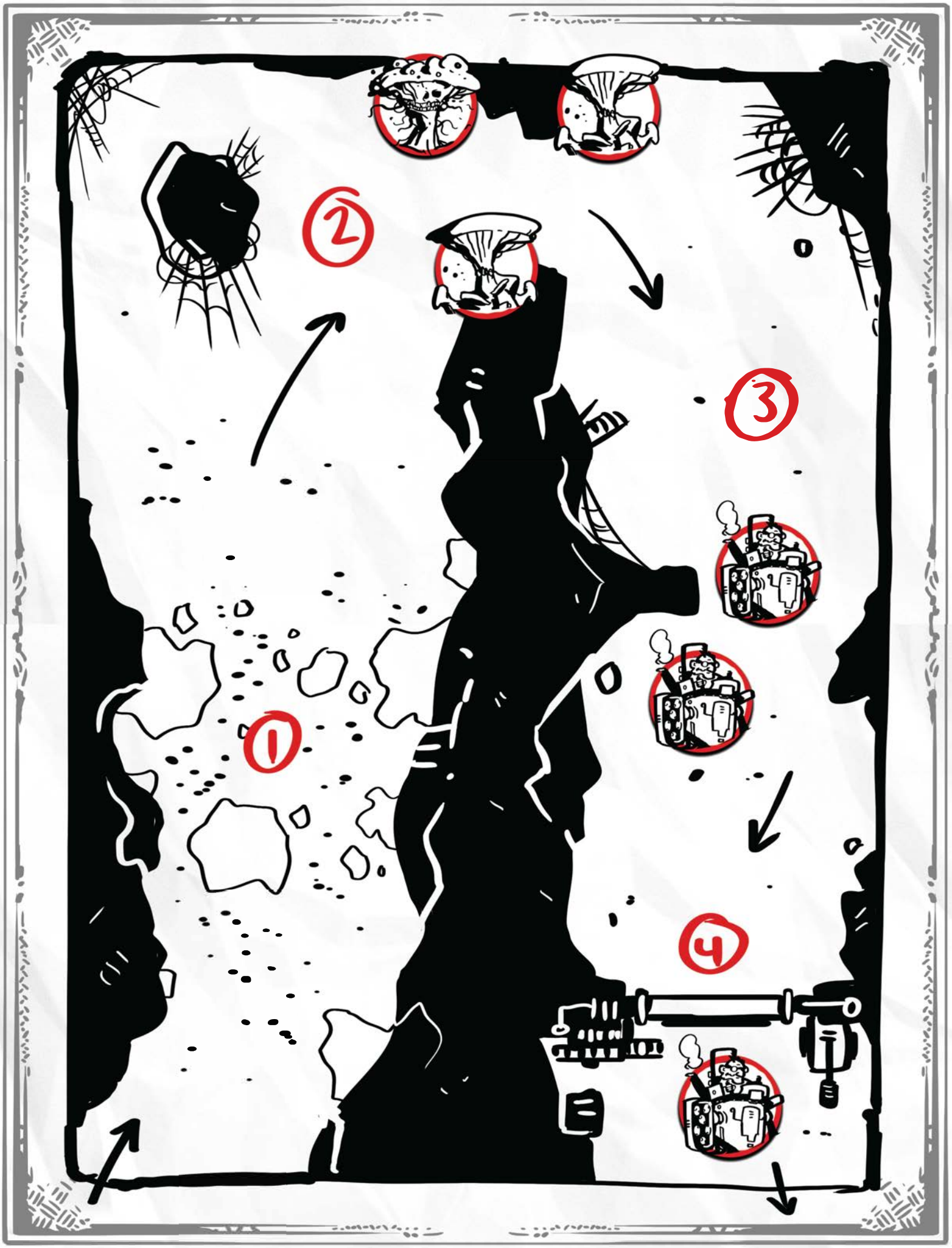
These gnomes use steam-powered battle armor, and are here to kill or subdue intruders. Mean buggers.

- Battle suits feature 4 CHUNKS, each with 5 HP. The suits also ignore any damage of 5 or less. See p. 3 for more details.
- 2 gnomes patrol the tunnel beyond the bend, and 1 operates the lever at the gate

4: DESCENDING GATE

If the gate switch is thrown, the gate will take 1D4 ROUNDS to slam down and lock. This will trap players with whatever combat mess has erupted.

- The gate keeper gnome is a leader, with +4 to all STATS. Very tough to deceive
- A closed gate has 3 HEARTS hp, or can be pried opened with a HARD STR roll.
- Creatures under the gate when it closes are dropped to 0 hp instantly, and pinned in place.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WHAT NEXT?

THE GNOMISH ENEMY

Having wounded or even killed the gnomish warriors comes at a price. The gnomish force will pursue the-heroes at any cost, relenting only if enough COIN is offered up to pay for lives lost and equipment damaged. Greedy little guys.

To spice things up, add a 'Gnomish Battle Giant' or 'Dreadnought class battle armor.' This is mechanical armor piloted by 3 gnomes, with 5 CHUNKS of 1 HEART each. The huge mecha is all but unstoppable, and shows up at an inopportune moment in the near future.

If there is a gnomish city ahead in these tunnels, the heroes will be prusued bya greater and greater force until finding a way to shake them, or destroying them utterly. Perhaps the gnomes have other enemies that could help...

A MYKONOID ALLIANCE

If the group manages to speak Mykonoid, or find a way to befriend the fungus-men, they will have stalwart allies that seek to be rid of the giant bugs AND the gnomish menace. Completing these tasks will earn characters epic LOOT from the fungus king himself, and a friendship for life.

THE HIVE

These insects are driven mad by a dark force deep underground: THE HIVE. This hellish place is a breeding ground, ruled over by a mutated cross between a Brain Horror and a Corroder. It is a huge, pulsating thing with an exposed brain, driving the insects mad with psychic energy and raising its hideous brood. Burn it all to ash, and make safe the tunnels once more.

Brain Horror, p. 104 and Corroder p. 108 in the ICRPG CORE 2E. If played as written, this boss monster will be terribly deadly, so be sure to warn players with a frightened NPC, piles of egg-covered skeletons, or divination of doom.

BATTLE ARMOR FUN

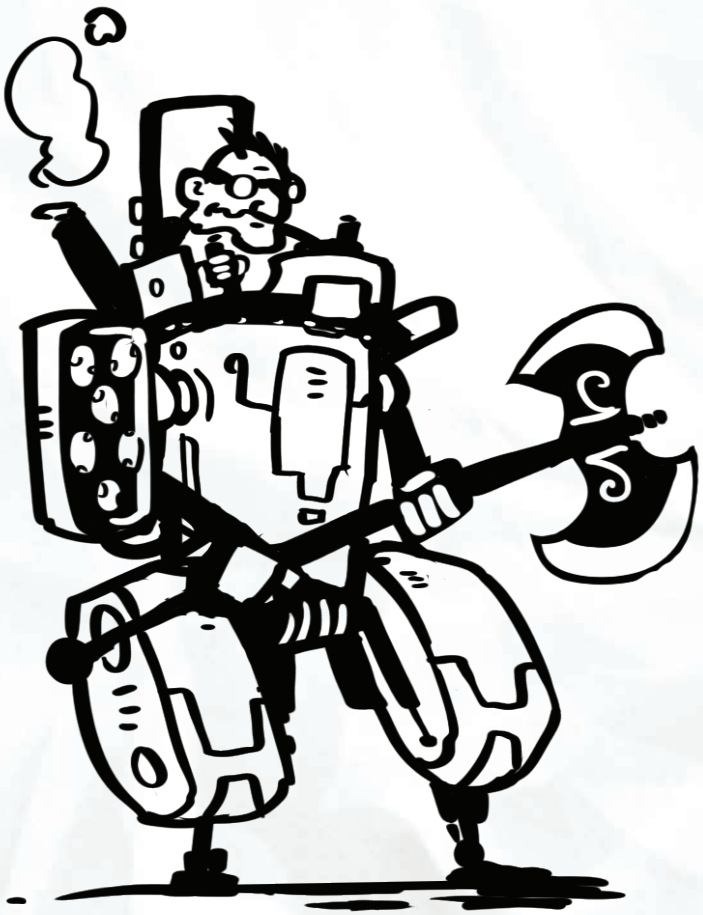
Players will almost inecitably want to steal or somehow acquire Gnomish battle armor. Here are the details.

2 ACTIONS per TURN
4 CHUNKS, 5 hp each:

- Battle Axe (Magical WEAPON)
- Missile Pack (All NEAR roll DEX or be hit for WEAPON damage)
- Repair Crane (Repair 1 CHUNK to full)
- Ejector Seat (Fling pilot FAR)

Duranium Shell (Ignore damage of 5 or less)
Clumsy, noisy mess!

- Battle armor can never make a stealth roll
- DEX rolls use the pilot's DEX, but are always HARD



MECHS& MYCONIDS

Goblins operating mechanical monsters never goes well.
Add some angry mushrooms to taste.

USING THE TABLES

There's two main styles to bringing the cruel and wonderful surprises of table-driven play to your game: as a tool for session prep, or generating twists and turns *during* play. When using for prep, you have the safety of your GM's sanctum. You can alter or roll again, jot down results, then let your imagination fly. During play, however, it's critical to be up front and out in the open with randomized events and details. Let the players roll, and read results verbatim before discussing what chaos they may induce!

META IS OKAY!

Openly saying 'let's roll on a table for this' is ok! You can even directly frame table use in game terms. *"You peer around the corner, straining to see in the darkness. What you see rests on this next random roll!"* This type of narration brings players directly into the GM's chair, and gives them that feeling of truly swaying what happens!

Enough chat. Here are the tables, use them as you will, and may your dice roll high.

ROLL 1D12	WHAT GNOMISH MECHA DO
1: Rogue Killers	1D6 Battle Armors, roaming the underground in search of victims
2: Junkers	A group of 1D12 Gnomes and 1D6 Battle Armors seeking scrap
3: Malfunction!	3 Gnomes struggle to control a wildly malfunctioning Battle Armor
4: Patrol Squad	1D8 Battle Armors slowly approach, scanning for anything out of place
5: Repair Effort	A group of Gnomes gathered 'round a HUGE Battle Armor making repairs
6: Survey Team	1 Battle Armor and 1D12 Gnomes setting up a new tunnel excavation
7: Defector	A solitary Battle Armor, piloted by a gnomish defector. He is pursued
8: A.I. Runaway	Battle Armor with no pilot, double normal actions per TURN, confused
9: Miners	The Gnomes are using their Armors to dig. 1D10 of them working
10: Do-Gooders	1D4 Over zealous Armor pilots looking to kill monsters or save damsels
11: Lunch Break	1D8 Armors are shut down, parked, and their pilots are eating
12: Vacant	A single Battle Armor suit, undamaged, sitting vacant

ROLL 1D12	WHAT MYKONOIDS DO
1: Enraged	1D20 Mykonoid warriors driven mad by unseen chemicals
2: Phermonal	This squad of 1D12 Mykonoids is following a trail to vile Acid Fungus
3: Hunting	This group is looking for food for their dwindling tribe. 1D12 appearing
4: Border Guard	5 Heavily armed fungus men stand watch at the edge of their realm
5: Rescuers	A group of 3 baby Mykonoids is lost! These 3 adults seek to find them
6: Still	A stand of 2D20 Mykonoids is dormant, clogging the corridors
7: Moisturizers	These 1D10 mushroom men emit a dense foggy mist into the caves
8: Tending Young	Tiny Mykonoid polyps are cared for by 1D8 gardeners, protective
9: Fighting Gnomes	A full on battle rages in the tunnels ahead! 2D20 combatants go wild!
10: Armor Mod	A group of 3 fungus men are modifying Battle Armor for their own uses
11: Gianting!	This Mykonoid has grown wildly huge, storming around in a rage
12: Seeking Help	A group of elders, injured, seeks help to fight off the Gnome menace

ROLL 1D12	GNOMISH BATTLE ARMOR MALFUNCTIONS
1: Overload!	The Armor blows its reactor! A huge explosion occurs in 1D4 ROUNDS
2: Ejector Seat	Next ROUND, the pilot is EJECTED straight up, with a chute descent
3: Boomerang	Missile guidance goes wild! A full barrage returns on its origin!
4: Funky Feet	Move FAR ina random direction this TURN, no matter what is there
5: Exhaust Cloud	The engine blows a valve, filling a NEAR area with black smoke
6: Fire!	Sudden inferno! Ignites anything it touches, destroyed in 3 ROUNDS
7: Headlong	This mecha runs at a sprint DOUBLE FAR, or until it hits solid matter
8: Whirling	Use only melee attacks for 4 ROUNDS, legs do not function
9: Power Loss	The Battle Armor is powered off for 1D4 ROUNDS
10: Beep!	A piercing alarm sounds erratically, heard for miles
11: Ballistic	Jump jets malfunction, sending the Armor straight up DOUBLE FAR
12: Enemy Heal	Repair cranes become confused, using 2 ACTIONS to heal NEAR enemies

ROLL 1D12	GNOMISH BATTLE ARMOR TACTICS
1: Missiles	All Armors stay at a distance, or behind cover, and use missile barrages
2: Charge!	The squad unites, running into the heart of the enemy
3: Fall Back	All Armors huddle and retreat to teh safest location available in one move
4: Scatter	The squad splits and runs in every direction
5: Hold Ground	All Armors rally on a key point or high ground and will not yield it
6: Rock Toss	These mecha throw huge rocks at the enemy
7: Ceiling Collapse	Aim for the ceiling! With 2 HEARTS total EFFORT, a collapse occurs
8: Overload	One Armor is chosen to intentionally overload itself as a bomb
9: Decoy	A battle Armor is sent to a flank or behind enemies, getting attention
10: Hide	These mechanized troops stay hidden in rocks or darkness
11: Subdue	Rather than destroy, Battle Armors work to grapple foes
12: Rocket Man	One Armor fires its jet, becoming a massive ram-missile!

MECHS AND MYKONOIDS

ROLL 1D12	MYKONOID ODDITIES
1: Tiny	The cutest little mushroom man you ever saw
2: Tentacled	A tangled mess of sticky, whipping cords in no orderly array
3: Healing Polyps	Little yellow blobs that can be picked and eaten for 1D8 healing
4: Talkative	This Mykonoid loves to talk, in many languages, about almost anything
5: Friendly	Hugs, hugs, and more hugs. It gets annoying
6: Hateful	This mushroom cannot be reasoned with. He hates everyone
7: Demihuman	A Mykonoid that is partially human, and in pain because of it
8: Albino	Colorless fungus that lashes out at any light source
9: Tunneler	These fungi are always busy tunneling or excavating gems
10: Cyborg	A Mykonoid fitted with Gnomish prosthetics and weapons
11: Infernal	Grown too deep underground, this fungus is demonic
12: Ancient	Centuries old, slow as dirt, and all knowing

ROLL 1D12	MUTUAL ENEMIES OF GNOMES AND FUNGI
1: Insects	Giant roaches, millipedes, and spiders erupt from loose soil
2: The Darkness	An antlered giant, part bear, part grim reaper, created by evil forces
3: Acid Fungus	Herds of acid-spraying mushrooms with no intelligence
4: Black Slime	A thick goo that is drawn to, and dissolves, living matter
5: Cave Crab	Huge, hard-shelled hunters that hide on ceilings
6: Bat Swarm	Found sleeping in vast numbers in the larger caverns
7: Trophy Hunters	Human explorers looking to kill for sport and glory. Real jerks
8: Corroders	The infamous metal-eaters are territorial and violent
9: Cave Ropers	Nothing is safe from the chomping fangs of these things
10: Crystal Worms	Only found where YOG can feed them, but feared by all
11: Driller	A colossal armored worm that tunnels in the greatest depths
12: Hellsmoke	Tendrils of evil black vapor that have seeped from hell's fires